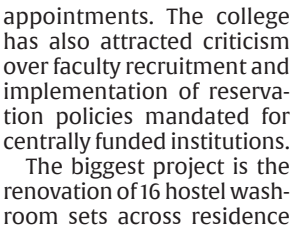


PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

repaired institutions, needs: storage of washrooms across residence blocks; essential road repairs on campus; air conditioning of selected spaces, including the Junior Common Room, staff room, canteen and library; modernisation of the college canteen and mess; and an end-to-end Enterprise Resource Planning system to digitise academic and administrative operations.

The fundraising appeal comes at a time one of India's most prestigious higher educational institutions faces sustained scrutiny over its governance, admissions and faculty



blocks at an estimated cost of ₹2.29 crore, or about ₹14.3 lakh for each set comprising ground and first-floor facilities. The college has also proposed spending ₹30 lakh on revamping internal roads, ₹25 lakh on modernising the college canteen, and ₹20 lakh on air-

conditioning the cafe, ₹12 lakh on installing air-conditioners in the library and ₹13 lakh on renovating girls' washrooms near the auditorium. Other projects include improving accessibility through tactile pathways, setting up water-purification systems, upgrading sports infrastructure and landscaping the campus.

The ERP platform is estimated to cost ₹8.50 lakh, excluding recurring charges for maintenance and cloud hosting.

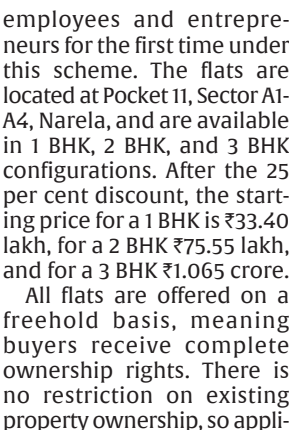
Rather than seeking general donations, the college has invited alumni to

sponsor specific infrastructure projects. "Item-wise sponsorship will enable every contribution to be linked to a clearly identified project and will ensure that the utilisation of funds can be monitored and reported with clarity," the principal said. For each sponsored project, the college has promised to provide photographs documenting the work before, during and after completion, utilisation reports, work-related documentation and completion reports. Donors who wish to be recognised will also be acknowledged at

an appropriate location on campus. The college said it can currently accept contributions only from resident Indian bank accounts and not from foreign sources.

It added that donations would qualify for tax benefits under Section 80G of the Income Tax Act. "I sincerely hope you will consider supporting this endeavour and helping the College meet these important needs," Elias wrote, directing alumni to an online document listing projects for which sponsorships have already been promised or received.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi



cants who already own a residential property can also purchase under this scheme. Adjoining flats can also be amalgamated subject to DDA norms and approval. The entire booking process will be conducted online through the DDA Awaas Portal. Sample flats are available for inspection before purchase.

The Narela location is approximately 1.2 km from an upcoming metro station, 1.9 km from a proposed RTTS station, 2 km from the Narela Sports Complex, 5 km from an

upcoming education hub, and 9.2 km from an upcoming integrated sports stadium. It is 500 metres from Urban Extension Road-I, 1.1 km from GT Karnal Road, and 6.15 km from UER-II. The project overlooks the Mamurpur Forest.

DDA said Narela Sub-city has been the dominant driver of its recent housing sales. In the first quarter of the current financial year, DDA sold 1,284 flats, generating revenue of over ₹1,020 crore, of which Narela alone accounted for 1,153 flats, representing nearly 90 per cent of total sales.

The scheme builds on this established buyer interest in the area. The extension of the 25 per cent discount to corporates and private sector workers marks a significant policy shift in how DDA prices its housing for different categories of buyers. Previously, the discounted pricing under various DDA schemes was

structured primarily as a benefit for government servants and public sector employees. The Karmajeevi Awaas Yojana recognises a different logic: that working professionals in the private sector, entrepreneurs, and those in corporate employment contribute equally to the economy and face similar homeownership challenges in an expensive city like Delhi. For a first-time buyer in the private sector looking at Narela, a 1 BHK at Rs 33.40 lakh after the discount represents one of the more accessible entry points to freehold property ownership within Delhi's boundaries currently available. The proximity to upcoming transit infrastructure, the established Narela Sports Complex, and the planned education hub add long-term value to the location beyond the immediate price advantage.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi



Delhi University has completed the first round of undergraduate admissions under the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) with a total of 63,756 candidates securing admissions, according to official data.

Of the admitted candidates, 15,265 have opted to freeze their allotted seats, while 48,153 have chosen the upgrade option to be considered for a higher-preference programme or college in the subsequent rounds.

The latest admission figures indicate an increase from the data released on July 21, when the university had reported that 61,932 candidates had confirmed their admissions after paying

A photograph of a brick building, likely a part of the University of Delhi campus. A sign on the wall reads 'UNIVERSITY OF DELHI' in English and Hindi. The building has a red brick facade and a small arched window.

the requisite fees ahead of the round one payment deadline.

Earlier, over 81,900 candidates had accepted the undergraduate seats allotted to them in the first round, reflecting strong participation in the admission process.

The first allocation list, announced last week, had offered seats to 93,033 can-

didates against more than 71,000 undergraduate seats across 221 programmes in 67 colleges for the 2026-27 academic session.

The allocations were made from among more than 2.08 lakh candidates who completed Phase II of the admission process by submitting their programme and college preferences.

Candidates opting for the upgrade option will be considered for higher-preference choices in the next round, while those who have frozen their seats will retain their current allotment.

The university is scheduled to release the second allocation list on July 25, while the new academic session will commence on July 28.

[illegible]

Regd. & Head Office P. B. No. 599, Mahaveera Circle Kankananadi Mangaluru - 575 002.	Phone : 011-40591567 (Ext.-231) E-Mail : delhiarn@ktk.bank.in Website : www.karnatakabank.bank.in CIN : L85100KA1924PLC001128
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LEGAL & RECOVERY DEPARTMENT

1. Mr. Ashok Kumar S/o Mr. Natha Ram R/o House No. 82, Upper Ground Floor, Pocket - 27, Sector-24, Rohini, New Delhi -110085.	2. Mrs. Neha Kumar W/o Mr. Ashok Kumar R/o House No. 82, Upper Ground Floor, Pocket - 27, Sector-24, Rohini, New Delhi -110085
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PUBLIC NOTICE

It is publicly notified that the Residential Flat No. J9, First Floor, Type-IV, Block-L, Sector-25, Vajpayee Nagar, Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, Along with Scooter Garage No. J9/7 & Extra Scooter Garage No. 92, has been allotted/transferred in the name of Mr. Vijay Kumar S/o Late G.N. Vatal R/o I-7, Badli Vihar, Sector-25 Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh and Mr. Vijay Kumar Vatal S/o Late G.N. Vatal had executed a WILL on 18.08.2023 Sub-Registr-Ir-II, Noida in favour of Viney Vatal S/o Mr. Mr. Jai Kumar Vatal S/G N.Vatal R/O G2401, Anandpur Chowk, Delhi 1277-1223, Haveli Pune, Maharashtra-412207, and Mr. Vinod Kumar Vatal S/o Late G.N. Vatal has expired on 22.03.2026, so with the help of the notice it is informed the transfer of the above said Flat and Scooter Garage to Viney Vatal S/o Mr. Jai Kumar Vatal S/o Late G.N. Vatal. If anyone has/have no objection he/she/they may submit his/her/their objection in the group housing department.

Noida Authority along with sufficient proofs within 30 days of the publication of this notice.

 J&K Bank Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited	The Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited Plot no 132-134 sector 44 Gurugram 122002, Haryana, India T 0124 47715800 E gursec@jkmail.com W www.jkbank.net
Annexure-IA	
Possession Notice	
<u>Notice under Section 13 (4) of the SARFAESI ACT, 2002 read with</u> <u>Rule 8 (1) of the Security (Enforcement) Interest Rules, 2002</u>	
Whereas Mr. Aadil Quadri, as the Authorized Officer of the Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers under section 13(2) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notice dated 24-04-2026 thereby calling upon the Borrower namely Rajesh Gupta to repay an amount of Rs. 49,93,820.53 (Rupees Forty-Nine Lakhs Ninety-Three Thousand Eight Hundred Twenty and paise Fifty-Three only) being the balance outstanding as on 24-04-2026 in the accounts of the Borrower, within 60 days from the date of the said notice together with the future interest and other charges thereon.	
The said borrower having failed to repay the said amount, notice is hereby given to the said borrower in particular and the public in general that the undersigned being authorized officer of the J & K Bank Ltd. has taken possession of the mortgage property described herein below, in exercise of the powers conferred on me under section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules, on this the twenty First day of July month of the year 2026.	
The said borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned against dealing with the said property in any manner whatsoever and any dealings with the said property will be subject to the charge of the J&K Bank Limited for the amount in aggregating to Rs. 49,93,820.53 (Rupees Forty-Nine Lakhs Ninety-Three Thousand Eight Hundred Twenty and paise Fifty-Three only) together with future interest thereon from 24-04-2026 and other charges incurred or to be incurred.	
The borrowers attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.	
Description of the Immoveable Property	
(As per the schedule provided in mortgage deed/latest particulars including any accreditations)	
Equitable Mortgage of freehold residential flat at third floor, Front Side, Pvt. No. 401, with roof/terrace rights, (3 BHK) Lift facility with common one hatchback car parking space ground floor of built up property No. D-4, Allt No 5, area measuring 100 Sq Yards, out of Khalsa No 650, Khewat Khattuni No 47/79, situated in the revenue estate of village Nasirpur, Delhi State, Delhi with proportionate rights of the land underneath	
Dated: 21-07-2026 Sd/-, Place: New Delhi Authorized Officer	

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF MORTGAGED PROPERTY

Property No.1 All that part and Parcel of Residential Flat No. 1101, in Tower-E, 11th floor, in project named KSHITIJ, affordable Group Housing, Sector-95, Gurugram, having tentative carpet area of 321.20 sq.ft. and balcony having tentatively 28.74 sq.ft. together with two-wheeler parking, situated in the revenue estate of Village Dhorka, Sector-95, Tehsil Harsaru, District Gurugram, Haryana -122505, **belonging to Mrs. Neha Kumar.**

Property No.2 All that part and Parcel of Residential Freehold Flat No.708, on 7th Floor in Tower-B, in residential Society, named as KSHITIJ, affordable Group Housing, Sector-95 having tentative carpet area 463.51 sq.ft. and balcony having 96.52 sq.ft. together with two wheeler parking, along with freehold unindivided, Proportionate share /rights of the land underneath the said property, situated in the revenue estate of Village Dhorka, Sector-95, Tehsil Harsaru, District Gurugram, Haryana -122505, **belonging to Mrs. Neha Kumar.**

Please note that I, the Authorised Officer of the secured creditor Bank intend to enforce the aforesaid securities in the event of failure to discharge your liabilities in full on or before the expiry of 60 days from the date of this publication.

Place : New Delhi Date : 22/07/2026	Sd/- For Karnataka Bank Ltd., Chief Manager & Authorised Officer.
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PUBLIC NOTICE

On behalf of M/S MAX HEIGHTS TOWNSHIP & PROJECTS PVT LTD having its registered office at 408, 4th floor, RG Trade Tower, Netaji Subhash Place, Pitampura, New Delhi-110032, the general public is hereby informed that on the basis of application/documents submitted by Smt. Brij Bala W/o Late Sh. Vinod Kumar R/o 1794, Gali No 133, Shanti Nagar, Tri Nagar, Okar Nagar Delhi-110035, the Developer M/s. Max heights Township & Projects Pvt. Ltd is Substituting, in place of Late Sh. Vinod Kumar, the name of following persons i.e. Legal heirs of Late Vinod Kumar, who are qua allotment of Flat No. MF-07, 1st Floor Maxheights Metro View Apartments, Sector-35, Sonapat, Haryana:-

- 1. Ankit (Son)
- 2. Brij Bala (Wife)
- 3. Parul Singh (Daughter)
- 4. Sarika Bansal (Daughter)

If any person has any objection/claim on the said property or against the said substitution, they may file his/her claim within 15 days to the said company, and thereafter no objection/claim will be entertained in this regard.

Kshiti Sharda Advocate
Date 23.07.2026 P/1545/2008

PUBLIC NOTICE

On behalf of M/S MAX HEIGHTS TOWNSHIP & PROJECTS PVT. LTD having its registered office at 408, 4th Floor, RG Trade Tower, Netaji Subhash Place, Pitampura, New Delhi-110032, the general public is hereby informed that on the basis of application/documents submitted by Smt. Kiran Gupta W/o Late Sh. Vijay Kumar Gupta R/o BW- 78A, 5/3 F Flat, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi- 110088, the Developer M/s. Max heights Township & Projects Pvt. Ltd is Substituting, in place of Late Sh. Vijay Kumar Gupta, the name of following Class I Legal heirs of Late Sh. Vijay Kumar Gupta, a allotment of Flat No. 5/3 F Flat, Shalimar Bagh, Max Heights Metro View Apartments, Sector-35, Sonapat, Haryana:-

1. Kiran Gupta (Wife)
2. Niran Gupta (Son)
3. Vaibhav Gupta (Son)

If any person has any objection/claim on the above proposed allotment/substitution, they may file his/her claim/object objection within 15 days to the company, and thereafter no objection/claim will be entertained in this regard.

Kshiti Sharda Advocate
Date: 23.07.2026 D/15/26/2008

PUNE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

CHIEF ENGINEER DEPARTMENT

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS (N.I.T) YEAR 2025-26

Tender Sale Date:- 23-07-2026 09:00 AM to Date 17-08-2026 upto 02:30 PM
 Bid Submission Start & End Date 23-07-2026 09:00 AM to Date 17-08-2026 upto 02:30 PM Technical Envelope Opening
 Date :-18-08-2026 03:00 PM

Tender No.	Name of Department	Name of Work	Cost of Tender Document (Rs.)	Estimate Cost (Rs.)	EMD Amount Rs.	Work Period (Month)	Concern Contact Person
PMC/ROAD/2026/63	Road	Development of the road from Lexicon School to Mhasoba Temple to Kesanand in Wagholi, newly included in the Pune Municipal Corporation	Rs. 17879/-	Rs. 78560447/-	Rs. 392802/-	24	Rahul Awarkar 9049451339

A) All details of Terms & Conditions of above works are incorporated in tender documents which is available on website www.mahatenders.gov.in Sale & acceptance is available by online system only. Tender needs to be submit in two envelope format.

B) If sales or submission not been available on last day also & it is not been submitted will be sole responsibility of tenderer.

C) Online tender process information will be available at Road, Pune Municipal Corporation.

D) As per office order No. 32, dated 22/04/2016 EMD deposit amount will be acceptable through ECS/RTGS/NEFT Online Banking only.

Date:- 23/07/2026
Advt. No:- 3/422

Hritik Ganpat Talape
Sanjay Dharav

Delhi Police debunks 15 ‘fake news’ claims amid CJP protest

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

As investigations into the violence during the Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) “Sansad Chalo” march continue, Delhi Police has initiated a parallel effort to address what it calls misinformation related to the July 20-21 protests. The police have issued rebuttals to at least 15 viral social media claims and are reviewing hundreds of videos, photographs, and audio clips connected to the unrest.

Police sources report that a dedicated fact-check team has been established to verify viral posts related to the protests, trace the origins of misleading content, and identify those allegedly responsible for spreading false infor-

mation. Officials stated that legal action will be taken against individuals found deliberately circulating fabricated or doctored material intended to create panic or disrupt public order.

Police stated that force was used only after protesters refused to vacate the Jantar Mantar site late Monday afternoon and violence erupted during the march toward Parliament.

Authorities reported that at least 118 security personnel were injured in the clashes, while several protesters sustained minor to moderate injuries and received treatment at Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital.

The official rebuttals addressed a range of allegations circulating online. These

included claims of a 12-year-old girl being assaulted and injured, the detention of CJP founder Abhijit Dipke, Sonam Wangchuk’s wife Geentanjali Angmo being dragged by her hair, the death of a young girl in a stampede after a police lathicharge, and the illegal detention of approximately 3,000 protesters without food or water. In each case, Delhi Police labelled the claims as “false” or “misleading” and urged the public not to share unverified information.

Notably, CJP spokesperson Saurav Das posted on X that Dipke had been detained on July 20 but deleted the post after Delhi Police. The police also rebutted several viral videos alleging that officers assaulted women, used batons with nails, or fired



Supporters of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) during a protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

pellet guns during the clashes. They stated that many of these videos were unrelated to the protest or shared out of context. Police further asserted that Delhi Police

does not possess or use pellet guns during crowd-control operations.

Investigators are also reviewing a viral audio clip that, according to police

sources, features the digitally manipulated voice of a senior officer. The source alleged that the original public appeal for peace was altered by “Pakistan-based

handlers” before being circulated online.

In addition to investigating misinformation, Delhi Police is analyzing nearly 250 videos, CCTV footage, and AI-assisted camera feeds to identify individuals involved in stone-pelting, attacks on security personnel, vandalism of police vehicles, and damage to public property. Sources indicated that forensic experts and AI teams have also been deployed, and 10 FIRs have been registered so far.

However, the police’s account has come under scrutiny. Several independent fact-checking organisations have challenged some of the force’s rebuttals, particularly those concerning the alleged use of batons with metal nails during the crackdown.

Videos circulating online also appear to show a senior Delhi Police officer slapping a woman near Jantar Mantar, an incident for which the force has not yet provided an official response.

Questions have also been raised regarding the denial of pellet gun use. As per claims, a 25-year-old protester Shaikh Irshad Mansoori underwent surgery after doctors reportedly removed multiple pellets from his face and upper body. If confirmed, this would be the first known instance of pellet ammunition being used against civilian protesters in Delhi. However, Delhi Police continues to vehemently reject the allegation, stating that the claims are fabricated.

RAF attacked: Police intensify investigation into CJP violence

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has intensified its investigation into the violence that erupted during the Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) Sansad Chalo march, examining over 250 videos with artificial intelligence while significantly bolstering security across the New Delhi district after two Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel were allegedly attacked in Connaught Place on Tuesday.

The heightened investigation comes as the Union Home Ministry approved the deployment of 30 additional companies of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) in the national capital after the Delhi Police sought reinforcements to maintain law and order amid ongoing protests by the CJP, student organisations, and Opposition parties over alleged question paper leaks.

With the fresh deployment, Delhi Police now has 45 companies of central forces,



around 4,500 personnel, at its disposal until July 27. These include 24 companies of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), 15 of the RAF, 3 of the Border Security Force (BSF), 1 of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), and 2 of the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB). The additional CRPF personnel are being airlifted from West Bengal following directions from the Home Ministry.

Apart from the CAPF deployment, the New Delhi district has also witnessed a heavy presence of Tripura Rifles and BSF personnel units at key locations, particularly around Parliament Street, Jantar

Mantar and Connaught Place.

The security build-up follows the attack on two RAF personnel in Connaught Place on Tuesday night. According to police, a scuffle broke out after RAF personnel intervened during an assault on a man amid the protests. One of the personnel allegedly got separated from his colleagues and was attacked by a mob armed with swords and sticks.

Videos circulating on social media purportedly show the officer attempting to flee before being chased, tripped and assaulted. A second RAF personnel who tried to rescue his colleague was also alleged-

ly attacked and sustained injuries. Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police (New Delhi) Anand Kumar Mishra confirmed that an FIR has been registered in connection with the attack.

So far, Delhi Police has registered 10 FIRs linked to the protests across the New Delhi district. Four FIRs have been lodged at Parliament Street police station, three at Connaught Place, and one each at Mandir Marg, Barakhamba Road and Kartavya Path police stations.

The cases include allegations of criminal conspiracy, obstruction of government work, assault on police personnel, damage to public property, unauthorised drone operations during the Parliament session, and violations under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), the Arms Act and the Prevention of Damage to Public Property (PDPP) Act.

Police sources said investigators are analysing footage from CCTV cameras, mobile

phones and social media to identify those responsible for the violence that broke out during the July 20 protest. Sources reportedly said they were probing conversations on BitChat, a messaging application that can operate without internet connectivity, to determine whether the unrest was preplanned.

Police have alleged that protesters turned aggressive and violent during Monday’s demonstration and refused to disperse despite repeated warnings. Investigators are now examining whether the violence was part of a pre-planned conspiracy; the analysis of digital evidence is expected to play a crucial role in identifying those involved.

The ongoing protests have been led by the CJP and backed by several student organisations and Opposition parties, who are demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged examination paper leaks.

AI cameras help police identify suspects in CJP protest violence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has begun using its network of artificial intelligence (AI)-enabled surveillance cameras to identify people allegedly involved in the violence that erupted during the CJP protest earlier this week, with investigators saying those found responsible for attacking police personnel or damaging public property will face legal action.

According to police sources, AI-powered cameras installed across the New Delhi district are being used to analyse CCTV footage and identify individuals who allegedly participated in clashes with security personnel, vandalised government vehicles or assaulted police officers.

Officials said the identities of those flagged by the surveillance system will be



verified using police databases to check for any criminal history before further action is taken. Police maintained that those who participated in the protest peacefully have “nothing to worry about,” while urging citizens to share information about people involved in the violence. Officials assured that the identities of informants would remain confidential.

“There is an extensive CCTV network across New Delhi. Every person found involved in the clashes will be identified, their background verified and action will be taken

on the basis of evidence,” a senior police officer said.

The investigation has so far led to the registration of 10 FIRs across multiple police stations in the capital. Four cases have been lodged at Parliament Street Police Station, three at Connaught Place Police Station, and one each at Mandir Marg, Barakhamba and Kartavya Path police stations.

Among these is an FIR lodged based on the complaint of a Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel who was allegedly assaulted by protesters during the violence.

Police enforce uniform rule at Jantar Mantar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Responding to public anger, Delhi Police has ordered all officers at Jantar Mantar to wear their uniforms while on duty. Plain clothes are now banned. This decision came late Tuesday after videos of Monday’s clashes spread widely online. The videos showed men in civilian clothes, some with their faces covered and carrying police lathis, hitting protesters. Other clips showed uniformed officers without name tags or clear identification.

The new rule is meant to bring back accountability at Jantar Mantar, a major protest site in Delhi. On Monday, July 20, thousands of young people, organised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), gathered there for a “Sansad Chalo” march to Parliament.

They were demanding answers about problems with the NEET exam and calling for Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to resign. Protesters



moved past the first barricades on Tolstoy Marg and Sansad Marg.

Security forces, including Delhi Police and the Rapid Action Force, set up several barricades to stop the crowd from reaching the high-security area near Parliament. When protesters pushed against the last barricade near Transport Bhawan, police used lathis to break up the crowd. Many people, including both protesters and police, were hurt in the clashes. An internal police report called the action “mild force” used to disperse an unauthorised gathering near a sensitive area. The police were in the videos. Multiple

clips showed plain-clothes men, some wearing Delhi Police helmets or carrying standard-issue lathis, beating demonstrators.

In one widely shared video, a man in civilian clothes is seen striking people before uniformed officers appear to intervene. Social media erupted with questions. The CJP posted, “Who are these lathi-armed goons in plain clothes? Who have you hired on your force to beat us up? Why are such monsters called police in India?” Critics highlighted the absence of nameplates, rank badges, and force identification on both plain-clothes and some uniformed personnel.

Legal experts noted that under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), dispersal orders must be issued by identifiable police officers or magistrates. Unidentifiable personnel using force raises serious questions of legality and accountability.

Late on Tuesday, Delhi Police Headquarters told all units that anyone working at Jantar Mantar must wear a full police uniform. Civilian clothes are no longer allowed for officers at the site. This step is intended to address the current controversy and prevent further claims of unaccountable policing.

The fact that they were unauthorised and posed a security risk near Parliament means they have not yet issued a detailed public explanation of the identity or role of the plain-clothes individuals seen in the videos. Broader Implications: The episode has once again brought into focus the use of plain-clothes personnel during protests and crowd-control operations.

Record crowds join CJP protest at Jantar Mantar

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Unprecedented crowds continued to pour into Jantar Mantar on Wednesday night as CJP’s protests continue against the NEET paper leak and other examination irregularities. Crowds lined up from outside of Janpath Metro Gate Number 2, leading up to the main stage area. Protests went up to the Kerala House area, and protestors continued demanding Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation.

Additionally, anger poured out against the Delhi police after the Monday crackdown, leading to several protestors being injured. Protestors commented on the alleged excessive use of force by the police and sloganeered against the action.

Walking into the main Jantar Mantar area, a large group of protestors stood at attention and sang the



Supporters of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) during a protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

National Anthem with conviction. The crowd was emotional about the loss of lives of students who died by suicide due to the paper leak. A protestor said, “We are singing the national anthem every day; we are peaceful, yet we were attacked.”

A protestor who came from Sangrur said, “I waited

many days for some change but joined the CJP movement to extend support to my brothers and sisters.”

Additionally, a group of lawyers practising in the Delhi High Court and the Supreme Court met with The Pioneer and spoke about the ordeal of helping with detained protestors. Advocate Mohit Jakhar said,

“We visited several police stations in the North Campus area of Delhi University. Many protestors were taken to Model Town and Civil Lines stations. So far, all protestors in the North Campus area PSs have been released.”

A huge line was queued up, leading to the inside protest area where the main stage is designated. CJP volunteers have formed human chains to enter the area.

Claims have floated about a possible scuffle between the Delhi police and protestors near the Rafi Marg and Sansad Marg area. Protestors have allegedly used force and attacked the police personnel.

Police continue to warn the protestors to maintain peace and not develop any stampede-like situations. The police personnel continuously have announced and got protestors to not pick any stones and indulge in violence.

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^Over the last three Fiscals

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INDO-MIM LIMITED is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP along with the Abridged Prospectus dated July 17, 2026. The RHP is available on the website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in, as well as on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE and NSE at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively, on the website of the Company at www.indo-mim.com and on the websites of the Book Running Lead Managers (“BRLMs”), i.e. HDFC Bank Limited, Axis Capital Limited, ICICI Securities Limited, Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited and SBI Capital Markets Limited at www.hdfc.bank.in, www.axiscapital.co.in, www.icicisecurities.com, https://investmentbank.kotak.com/ and www.sbicap.com, respectively. Any potential investors should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see ‘Risk Factors’ on page 18 of the RHP filed with SEBI and the Stock Exchanges. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP filed with SEBI and the Stock Exchanges for making any investment. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act of 1933, as amended (“U.S. Securities Act”), or any state securities laws in the United States, and unless so registered may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, such Equity Shares are being offered and sold (i) outside of the United States in offshore transactions in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur; and (ii) within the United States to “qualified institutional buyers” (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act), pursuant to the private placement exemption set out in Section 4(a) of the U.S. Securities Act.

Adfactors 186/26

Ram Temple trust approves accounts, extends CEO search

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Ayodhya

The Board of Trustees of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Tirtha Kshetra approved the trust's annual accounts and auditor's report today. They also cleared the State Bank of India of any transparency issues and gave themselves another month to choose a new Chief Executive Officer. The meeting in Ayodhya, led by senior Nyas members, focused on finances, security, administration, and working with devo-

tees and the community. The board made several important decisions while questions about the accounting for chadava, or devotee offerings, continue. Trustees officially approved the annual financial statements and auditor's report. They postponed discussion about possible irregularities in chadava calculations because the Special Investigation Team's final report is still pending. In a significant development, the Nyas met with officials of State Bank of India to discuss completed trans-

actions and banking responsibilities. After checking transparency measures and finding no irregularities with previous banking partners, the board cleared SBI of any issues. The finance committee will continue to review the trust's relationship with the bank and its procedures to keep things running smoothly. The trust has received numerous applications for the post of the CEO. To allow thorough evaluation, the board granted a one-month extension to the selection process. The



trustees accepted the outgoing CEO's resignation because of ongoing administrative and audit issues. To handle the expected increase

in visitors and keep daily operations running smoothly, the board approved appointing a Secretary for the Coordination and

Religious Committee. Trustees personally inspected the temple premises and held detailed discussions with security officials. They reviewed the functioning of CCTV surveillance systems. Trustees visited the temple to inspect the premises and spoke in detail with security officials. They checked how the CCTV systems work and reviewed access rules for the chadava counting rooms and other sensitive areas, known as kemars. Directives were issued to complete pending

audits of all associated shrines and treasury rooms while ensuring robust security arrangements remain in place. "This reflects the trust's priority on safeguarding both the sanctity and the assets of the temple complex, sources said. The Nyas stressed the need to keep talking with devotees, civil society, and the media. They decided to improve coordination so the public stays informed and concerns are addressed openly. The board also reformed the Religious Committee to help preserve

the traditional authenticity and purity of daily pooja and archana rituals in the temple. The new committee includes several well-known spiritual leaders and seers. This helps keep old traditions alive while also following modern administrative practices. Wednesday meeting centred around governance, financial prudence, security, and long-term planning as the Ram Mandir continues to draw unprecedented numbers of pilgrims from across India and the world.

Lalit Modi announces return to India

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Lalit Modi, the founder and former chairman of the Indian Premier League (IPL), has spent more than 16 years abroad because of controversies and legal troubles. Now, he says he plans to visit India again at the end of 2026 or early 2027. This will be his first visit to India since he left in 2010, ending a long period of self-exile and difficulties. Many cricket fans are looking forward to his return. He decided to come back after a major legal win. On July 16, 2026, the Appellate Tribunal ruled in his favour in the 2009 IPL South Africa FEMA case. Most penalties imposed by the Enforcement Directorate were dropped because the tribunal found he was not responsible and that there was insufficient evidence. Lalit Modi posted a message on X, "I am really looking forward to returning to India after a long time. Stay well and stay safe. Reacting to the tribunal's ruling, Modi said the ruling shows he is innocent and that he has always tried to grow the IPL and make it successful around the world. The decision is a relief after years of legal battles. Modi has made a big difference in cricket. In 2008, he started the IPL with a new franchise system and player auctions, turning cricket into a major entertainment



Lalit Modi

event. Top players from around the world joined Indian stars, filling stadiums and raising TV ratings. The league made a lot of money, raised player salaries, and inspired T20 leagues in other countries. It changed how cricket is managed and brought the game to more people. The IPL made cricket more accessible and exciting for millions who felt left out by older formats. But success also brought problems. In 2010, accusations of irregularities and conflicts of interest

led to Modi being removed from the BCCI and to his being forced to leave India. He spent most of the next sixteen years in London, facing investigations but saying he was still working to improve the game he loved. Despite these challenges, Modi kept up with cricket news and often shared his opinions from abroad. He stayed active in cricket discussions in the media and on social media, often talking about how much he missed India and its people. Now, after the tribunal's decision, he looks forward to seeing friends, visiting familiar places, and taking care of family business. He will keep his main home in London, so this visit is not a permanent return. News of his visit has generated excitement and debate in cricket circles. Some people wonder if he will share ideas about the IPL's future or reconnect with his past and supporters. His role in building one of sport's biggest success stories is clear, but opinions about his leadership are still mixed. Lalit Modi's story shows the drama of sports leadership, with bold ideas, tough challenges, and now a possible comeback. After many years away, his planned visit shows his resilience and strong connection to his roots. Whether he stays in the background or gets involved again, his presence will spark memories and conversations about the league he helped create.

Delhi cuts processing time for 84 single window services

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has reduced the processing time for 84 services available on the Single Window System following a detailed study of 95 key services across 18 departments. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Wednesday that some services are now being provided instantly after process improvements were introduced. The study was conducted by the Information Technology Department under Priority Area-21 as part of Deregulation Exercise Phase II. It was designed to assess the time taken to deliver each service from application submission to final disposal and to identify where processing steps could be shortened or eliminated. The Single Window System is a digital platform through which citizens and businesses can apply online for and obtain a range of licences, permits, approvals, and clearances at one place rather



than approaching different departments separately. The 95 services reviewed span 18 departments of the Delhi Government. Based on the findings of the study, process improvements were introduced across the identified services. The result is a reduction in processing time for 84 of the 95 services reviewed, with a subset of those now available on an instant basis at the time of application. The Chief Minister said the initiative is intended to make doing business in Delhi easier, improve the

transparency and efficiency of Government services, and simplify procedures for citizens and businesses. She said the Information Technology Department continues to work toward delivering faster, simpler, and citizen-centric public services through digital technology and improved work processes. The reduction in processing time for Single Window System services fits within a broader pattern of administrative reforms the Delhi Government has been rolling out over the course of 2026. In June, the

Government brought 23 new services under the Delhi Right of Citizens to Time-Bound Delivery of Services Act, 2011, which mandates that specific services be delivered within defined timelines ranging from a single day to 60 days. Those additions covered services from the Labour Department, Delhi Jal Board, Agriculture Department, Excise Department, Forest Department, PWD, and RERA, among others, and brought the total number of services under the Act to approximately 500. The Deregulation Exercise Phase II study is complementary to but distinct from the time-bound delivery framework. Where the time-bound delivery law sets maximum permissible timelines, the deregulation exercise looks at how long services are actually taking and finds ways to shorten that time through process redesign, automation, and the elimination of redundant steps, without necessarily changing the legal deadline.

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Govt outreach meets CJP demand for talks

"Therefore, I respectfully request an unequivocal assurance from the government that none of the young protesters will face any punitive or retaliatory legal action for participating in this movement. Their only 'offence' has been to raise their voice for a fair and accountable education system," Wangchuk wrote. He also said that Union ministers JP Nadda and Jitendra Singh had already assured him that the Government would positively consider his two other key demands. "If such an assurance is given, I shall end my fast with faith that the Government has heard not only my appeal but also the aspirations of lakhs of young Indians. In the absence of such an assurance, I will be forced to continue my fast indefinitely," he wrote.

Sharing the letter on social media platforms, Wangchuk said, "An appeal to the government regarding breaking my fast... Once the assurance from the government comes, I will also appeal to the peacefully protesting students to halt the movement for now and enter into dialogue with the government."

Referring to the July 20 'Chalo Sansad' march, Wangchuk said it "remained very peaceful despite the atrocities and disproportionate use of force by the police". "The entire nation and the world witnessed their patience and commitment to democratic protest. I sincerely hope that this faith in democratic institutions is not further undermined by any legal cases, harassment or vindictive action against those who participated," he said. Around 65 MPs from different political parties had written to him, while several met him personally and urged him to end his fast, Wangchuk said. In another development, addressing a Press briefing at the protest site, CJP chief spokesperson Saurav Das said police informed the outfit on Wednesday morning that Union Minister JP Nadda wanted to hold discussions and had invited them to his residence. "We refused to go to anyone's house or office. The people's court is here. Ministers should come among the people. If they want to talk, the talks should be held at Jantar Mantar," he said.

Das, however, said the movement remained open to dialogue and was willing to consider a neutral venue near the protest site if there were security concerns. "We are educated people. If there are security concerns at Jantar Mantar, we can meet at a neutral place nearby. We have always said we are ready for talks. It would be good if the issue is resolved through dialogue," he said.

After Delhi police crackdown, protesters...

CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka, addressing the crowd at Jantar Mantar on Wednesday, said the movement had already achieved two victories. He said the country, which had forgotten how to ask questions and where questioning the government was considered anti-national, had been awakened and was now asking questions. The CJP announced it would not leave Jantar Mantar until Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigns. A young woman who identified herself as a third-year engineering student from Hyderabad said she had arrived in Delhi on Sunday night, just before Monday's march. She had been beaten, she said, and had a bruise on her arm to show for it. "My

parents are calling me home. I told them I will come when Pradhan ji resigns. They think I am joking." Separately, AAP Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh travelled to Medanta Hospital in Gurugram on Wednesday to visit Sonam Wangchuk, who had been shifted there from Safdarjung Hospital on Tuesday evening following a Delhi High Court order directing his transfer. Police officials at Medanta denied Singh permission to enter and meet Wangchuk. Singh then sat down in a dharna at the hospital entrance, refusing to leave. He eventually ended the sit-in after a period of time, but not before drawing attention to the restricted access being maintained around Wangchuk, who continues his indefinite hunger strike even after the hospital transfer. Wangchuk was brought to Medanta by ambulance at around 7:30 pm on Tuesday under tight security and admitted to ICU-8 under the supervision of Dr Sushila Kataria, an internal medicine specialist. His vital signs remained stable, but his blood sugar levels continued to be low, and he showed persistent pancytopenia, including anaemia and low white blood cell counts, according to the hospital's latest medical bulletin. The state answered with numbers of its own. The Union Home Ministry ordered 20 companies of the Central Reserve Police Force airlifted from West Bengal on Tuesday night, each with about 100 personnel. Roughly 30 companies of the CRPF and the Rapid Action Force were already with Delhi Police. CJP spokesperson Saurav Das said the party remained willing to talk and suggested holding any government meeting at a neutral location near Jantar Mantar, after police approached the CJP and informed them that JP Nadda wanted to speak with them. CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke had already said anyone wanting to hold discussions would have to come to the protest site.

Metro curbs across Capital hit daily life

A similar shutdown happened on Monday but then it was limited to few stations in proximity to the Parliament. Ritu, a commuter travelling through Central Secretariat, said protesters had gathered near the station premises, leading to confusion among passengers. "The Central Secretariat Metro station was taken over by protesters. Several of them had gathered near the exit and were chanting 'Vande Mataram'. There was a lot of uncertainty and people did not know whether they would be able to leave the station," she said. Another passenger travelling on the Yellow Line said announcements inside the train informed commuters that they would not be allowed to disembark at stations between Delhi Gate and Khan Market. "We were not allowed to get down from Delhi Gate Metro to Khan Market Metro. People are getting stranded here without any prior notice. It is utter chaos," he said. Several commuters said they were late for work, college and other appointments as they struggled to find alternate routes after discovering their destination stations had been shut. Many were seen checking navigation apps, calling family members and booking cabs outside operational stations, while long queues formed at bus stops and auto-rickshaw stands. "I had an important class this morning but I had to get off much before my destination and now I am trying to find another way to reach college," said a student waiting outside an operational metro station.

Rahul backs students, targets Govt over...

A video of police violence against students during Monday's 'Sansad Chalo' protest was shown at the start of the press conference. Referring to the police action, Rahul said, "The question is why is this happening to our students? What have they done to have security forces aiming weapons at them, to be beaten up, to be thrashed? Children have committed suicides, they go through unlimited stress and there is a legitimate, very deep problem in this country. The thing that is clear to everybody is that our education system, which was known to be one of the best education systems in the world, is a rigged system." Rahul claimed 152 paper leaks have taken place in the last decade while 7.5 crore students were affected by the breakdown of the education system. Annual exam expense of families is Rs 1.32 lakh crore, which is nearly equal to the education budget of Rs 1.4 lakh crore, the Congress leader claimed. He asserted that the demands of the students are legitimate. "They are demanding the resignation of the education minister Dharmendra Pradhan, who is known to be corrupt. He should be relieved of his duties," the Rahul said. His remarks came a day after he, along with Priyanka Gandhi and Samajwadi Party's (SP) Akhilesh Yadav, were forcibly removed by police after they held a sit-in outside PM Modi's residence in New Delhi, demanding his resignation. Minister of State in the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) Jitendra Singh, along with Union Home Secretary Govind Mohan, visited the venue to persuade the Opposition leaders to vacate the sensitive site. The leaders were then detained and later released.

Govt offers debate on NEET leak as...

Rijiju said Birla should convene an all-party meeting of floor leaders to finalise the rules under which it will be held, its date and duration. Birla underlined that time will not be a constraint and he will allow all members to speak as much as they want, once they give a notice according to procedures. Most Congress and SP members wore black to the House on Wednesday to protest the NEET paper leak and police crackdown on protesters at Jantar Mantar and other areas on Monday. Due to disruptions leading to multiple adjournments third day in a row, the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha was adjourned to meet on Thursday. As Birla asked Rijiju to make a statement, Congress leader KC Venugopal intervened to assert that the Opposition is also seeking the resignation of Union education minister, Dharmendra Pradhan. "Our demand is simple. When the entire nation is feeling the pain of our students, all other business of the House should be set aside and this burning issue should be the top priority for Parliament," Venugopal said. SP chief Akhilesh Yadav expressed anguish that while the BJP and the Congress members spoke, he was not allowed to participate. He said if the interests of youth and students are hurt, the Opposition is bound to protest on the streets also. The opposition has been demanding a discussion on the NEET paper leak issue and is also seeking the resignation of Pradhan over the handling of the controversy over the alleged examination irregularities.

Similar scenes were witnessed in the Rajya Sabha which saw repeated adjournments after the government accused the opposition led by the Congress of bringing in new conditions to not allow a discussion on the NEET paper leak issue. Leader of the House JP Nadda slammed the opposition parties, saying, "The INDI Alliance has indulged in irresponsible behaviour; they are destroying the dignity of Parliament." No business has been conducted in the two Houses since the beginning of the Monsoon session on Monday.

School dropout built AI scam network, arrested

Of these, 2,928 devices were fully compromised, resulting in 54,094 fraudulent banking transactions totaling about ₹64.38 crore. Most cases involved fake RTO challan payment apps, followed by fake SBI and PNB apps. The investigation started in May 2026 when a Surat resident lost ₹5 lakh. The victim got a malicious file on WhatsApp, installed it, and saw his money transferred to a Union Bank account. He quickly called the national cyber helpline 1930, which led Surat police to file an FIR and begin their investigation. Digital forensics on two mobile phones and a laptop revealed the full scale of the fraud. Surat Police are continuing their investigation to identify other groups using Shakya's software and anyone else involved. If you download apps from official stores, make sure to check app permissions and report any suspicious messages right away by calling 1930.

Terror strikes Anantnag, cop killed in terror...

Eyewitness reports claimed that soon after the firing incident, which took place at around 12:30 pm, chaos prevailed in the busy market area. In the Lal Chowk area, the security personnel cordoned off the entire area and searches were launched in the crowded streets to track down the footprints of terrorists behind the attack. Director General of J&K, Nalin Prabhat, along with Inspector General of Police, Kashmir range, VK Birdi, and SSP Anantnag, Amod Ashok Nagpure, also visited the busy market area in Anantnag to supervise the ongoing operation. According to a police spokesman, J&K police conducted extensive raids across multiple locations following the terror incident in Anantnag. During the operations, nearly 700 suspected over-ground workers were detained for questioning and verification. Similar operations were launched in Baramulla, where 178 OGWs were detained for questioning; 200 suspected OGWs were detained in Budgam; and 100 in Ganderbal district of Central Kashmir. Similar drives were carried out in Pulwama and Shopian as well. Later in the evening, senior police officers led by the DGP attended the wreath-laying ceremony of Constable Ashiq Hussain at District Police Lines (DPL), Anantnag and paid floral tributes to the fallen policeman. Chief Minister Omar Abdullah condemned the attack. Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha while condemning the killing and said the "heinous act" would not go "unpunished". "I strongly condemn this cowardly attack. This heinous act will not go unpunished. JK Police and our security forces are on the ground and will bring those responsible to justice," Sinha said in a post

on X. "Deeply saddened by the death in the line of duty of Head Constable Ashiq Hussain of IRP 3rd Battalion J&K Police. HC Hussain made the ultimate sacrifice in a cowardly terror attack in the Anantnag area of South Kashmir. I unequivocally condemn this attack and send my heartfelt condolences to the members of his family.

Trump's drug tariff plan puts India's pharma...

"This is done to RESHORE Generic Pharmaceutical Production into America, with a penalty to those Companies that decide not to build Plant and Equipment within the stated period of time given to them," Trump said. The president said the objective of this policy is to protect the people of the United States. "The Policy on Patented, Branded, or Innovative Drugs, which has been so successful, will remain as it is," he said. India is often referred to as the pharmacy of the world, as it supplies generic medicines to countries worldwide. In 2025, India exported USD 9.7 billion worth of pharmaceuticals to the US, accounting for 38 per cent of its total global pharma exports of USD 25.8 billion, according to a Global Trade Research Initiative. Indian generic medicines are widely prescribed for hypertension, diabetes, cancer, infectious diseases, and mental health. Trump's announcement came days after US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer, in an interview with the New York Times, said that the US was planning to impose more tariffs to recreate levies struck down by the Supreme Court earlier this year. The Trump administration plans to impose new tariffs of 10 to 12.5 per cent on as many as 60 countries, including India, citing investigations into alleged forced-labour practices and unfair trade policies. The US trade chief said the tariff policy was driven purely through an economic perspective instead of a foreign policy approach. "This is not a foreign policy shop. This is an economics shop here. And so when I look at someone like the European Union that blocks American agricultural goods for specious, non-scientific reasons, that's a problem. Friend or foe, that's an issue," he said in response to a question that the tariff policy was hard on traditional allies. According to the New York Times report, generic drugs, such as statins and antibiotics, account for about 90 per cent of Americans' prescriptions. They are most often manufactured in India, with heavy reliance on China for ingredients. Republicans and Democrats have identified that as a national security vulnerability. Doctors and supply chain experts have been sharply critical of the idea of taxing imported generics, saying it threatened to raise costs, spur rationing and lead to shortages of crucial drugs. Until now, the administration had said that generic drugs would be exempted from tariffs, the Time report said. John Murphy III, chief executive of the Association for Accessible Medicines, a trade group for generic drug makers, said in a statement on Tuesday evening that his industry will work with the administration and lawmakers "to pursue solutions that restore the generics industry to growth and to prioritize its place as a critical national security asset here in the US," the report said.

Need to evolve governance with changing times: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday chaired a high-level meeting with Secretaries to review progress of rural development, agriculture, social welfare and allied sectors towards Viksit Bharat Goals, at his residence at 7, Lok Kalyan Marg.

The meeting was attended by the Cabinet Secretary, Secretaries of key Ministries as well as senior officials from the Prime Minister's Office.

Prime Minister emphasised that the welfare of citizens must remain at the heart of all reforms. He said that reforms designed around people's needs should gather

real momentum and deliver meaningful transformation. He emphasised that the objective of reforms is not merely to improve the functioning of the Government, but to accelerate India's journey towards becoming a developed nation.

Prime Minister highlighted that governance systems are witnessing rapid changes and stressed the importance of adapting and strengthening governance processes to effectively meet the needs of a dynamic and evolving environment. He suggested undertaking a comprehensive mapping of emerging requirements across various Ministries and Departments.

Modi stressed the need for



a whole-of-Government approach to achieve the nation's development goals. He further emphasised that the dream to build a Viksit Bharat should become a Jan Andolan and that India's youth should form the foundation of this vision.

Sources said the PM underscored the importance of tackling the serious issue of drug abuse among youth. He suggested that efforts should be made to develop an institutional mechanism

to break departmental silos and foster greater inter-departmental coordination and convergence in youth-centric initiatives.

He further emphasised the need to adopt an integrated approach for the development of sports. He noted that, with sports tourism emerging as a key focus area, India should aspire to host major international sporting events to establish itself as a global sports hub. He stressed the importance of promoting technology and fostering innovation through startups in the sports sector.

Prime Minister highlighted that the widespread adoption of initiatives such as the PM KUSUM Scheme by farmers

can bring transformative changes to the agriculture sector. He further stressed the need for a global mapping of skill requirements to ensure better alignment with international opportunities and future needs.

The Secretaries shared their experiences and perspectives on various initiatives and challenges in their respective domains. The Prime Minister shared his suggestions and his vision for the future course of action. The meeting was marked by comprehensive and productive discussions across the sectors, focusing on effective implementation, greater convergence and accelerated progress towards the goals of Viksit Bharat.

India needs you, not in suffering, but in service: Opposition MPs urge Wangchuk to end fast

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assuring Sonam Wangchuk that his message had resonated across the country and would now be raised in Parliament, a delegation of opposition MPs urged the activist to end his indefinite hunger strike that entered its 25th day on Wednesday over alleged examination irregularities. The delegation, which included Congress MP Vivek Tankha, TMC MP Sagarika Ghose and CPI(M) MP John Brittas, met Wangchuk and his wife Gitanjali Angmo at Medanta Hospital in Gurugram.

They appealed to the activist to withdraw his indefinite fast, saying the struggle for a fair and transparent examination system had become a national cause.

Wangchuk has been on an indefinite hunger strike for the last 25 days in support of students demanding accountability over alleged examination irregularities.



"The nation, especially its youth, needs your wisdom and guidance far more than your sacrifice... Just as the Union Territory of Ladakh needs Sonam Wangchuk, India needs you too... not in suffering, but in service, serving those causes that will benefit generations to come. The country needs you," the MPs said in a letter handed over to the activist.

After the meeting, Ghose said the delegation had appealed to Wangchuk to end his fast while extending complete support to the students' movement. "...while wholeheartedly supporting the cause of the students, we fervently urged Sonam

Wangchuk ji to give up his fast in the interests of the nation and the students," Ghose said in a post on X. In their letter, the MPs said Wangchuk's "selfless commitment to the cause of India's youth" and his advocacy of "a fair, transparent and accountable examination system" had inspired millions across the country. "We, as Members of Parliament, request you to kindly withdraw your fast, while we take forward in Parliament the national mission and debate on educational reforms and the future of India's youth, so passionately espoused by you," they said.

Senior CPI(M) leader Rajeev calls out Satheesan remarks about Waqf Board

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

Senior CPI(M) leader P Rajeev on Wednesday termed as "lies" Chief Minister VD Satheesan's claims regarding the issues of Waqf Board appointments and investments from the Tata Group, saying that the CM needs to ensure the veracity of the statements he is making.

Satheesan, at a press conference in the state capital in the morning, accused opposition leader Pinarayi Vijayan of trying to turn the Muslim community against the UDF Government by making communal remarks in connection with the Waqf Board issue.

He also told reporters that the previous LDF administration had passed orders saying two non-Muslim members would be appointed to the Board after the Bar Council polls are over.

The CM further contended that the state Government had in the Kerala High Court sought dismissal of the pleas challenging the validity of the



current Waqf Board.

Regarding the proposed shipbuilding venture of the Tata Group in Kerala, Satheesan claimed that representatives of the company had met him and held discussions on issues related to their proposed investments in the state.

He also contended that the state expects investments worth around Rs 10,000 crore in the first phase of various maritime sector projects being planned under its 'Mission Samudra' initiative.

Terming all the statements by the CM as "lies", Rajeev, who was Law Minister in the previous LDF Government, said that every-

one expected Satheesan to correct his stand on the Tata project issue, but he did not.

On the Waqf Board issue, the former minister said that everything claimed by the CM was false.

He said that Vijayan adopted the same stand as the top Congress leadership, including Rahul Gandhi, regarding appointment of non-Muslim persons to the Waqf Board, so how can a Marxist veteran's remarks be termed as "communal".

He also said that in the previous LDF administration's order constituting the Waqf Board, the term 'non-Muslim' is not mentioned anywhere.

Rajeev further said that the Supreme Court has not rejected the pleas challenging the amendments to the Waqf Act and its section 14 as claimed by the CM.

"The Supreme Court is only going to consider the pleas. He (CM) could have said that the section 14 has not been stayed. He cannot authoritatively claim that the matter has been rejected," he said.

States Focus



I AM FINE: AMITABH BACHCHAN CLARIFIES HOSPITAL RUMOURS

Megastar Amitabh Bachchan has clarified that his recent blog post about hospitalisation, surgery and intensive care was not about his own health, saying people had "assumed incorrectly" that he was referring to himself.

The 83-year-old actor, whose cryptic post on Tuesday sparked concern among fans, said the post was inspired by Argentina's recent defeat to Spain in the FIFA World Cup final. "I am fine .. misunderstood post .. I was giving an example," Bachchan said in the new post on Tuesday night.

He said the post used recovery after surgery as a metaphor for the emotional and physical toll a champion endures after a crushing defeat, referring to Argentina captain Lionel Messi in the wake of the World Cup final loss.



'330 OFFICIALS TRAVELLED ON LUXURY TRAINS IN 12 YEARS'

A total of 336 railway officials travelled on Indian Railways' luxury trains, such as Palace on Wheels, Maharajas' Express and Deccan Odyssey, over the last 12 years by utilising their travel passes, Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw informed the Lok Sabha on Wednesday.

However, the minister did not reveal the names and designations of these officials, as sought by DMK MP VS Matheswaran.

The Railway Ministry, through the Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC), operates three luxury trains - Palace on Wheels, Maharajas' Express and Deccan Odyssey - whose fares range from ₹4.5 lakh to ₹26 lakh per person, depending on the itinerary.

Matheswaran wanted to know the "details of railway officials, including their names, designations and class of travel, who availed complimentary travel on luxury trains like Palace on Wheels, Maharajas' Express and Deccan Odyssey from 2014 till date, year-wise."

Mamata stands by Kalyan; BJP suggests counseling

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The Mamata Banerjee faction of the Trinamool Congress cried "victimisation" and expressed its full support to party MP Kalyan Banerjee after he was suspended from the Lok Sabha for the remainder of the Monsoon session due to an altercation and alleged use of unparliamentary language against break-away members of his party including some women MPs who had joined the NCPI post TMC's debacle in the April-May Bengal Assembly elections.

Reacting to Wednesday's developments in Lok Sabha senior TMC leader and party spokesperson Kunal Ghosh said "One should not comment on whatever transpired in the House but for Kalyan da we firmly stand behind as he has not done anything wrong by showing the traitors the mirror ... those who left Mamata Banerjee's hand after the elections could not ever had won a panchayat election without using her picture ... by remind-



ing them of their treachery he has done the right thing... after today it is clear that the traitors are patronized by the BJP whereas Kalyan Banerjee is being victimised."

Referring to an open stage altercation between Mamata Banerjee and Kalyan Banerjee during a rally on Tuesday where the latter told the former that it was only him who was standing by her and everyone had fled under pressure from the BJP. "Considering that at least now you should be more gentle while dealing with those who are with you," Kalyan told the former Chief Minister in full public glare after she openly chided her for occupying the mike and speaking too long and making her wait for one hour.

India and China continue diplomatic reset as Jaishankar meets Wang Yi in Manila

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Manila

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met Chinese Foreign Minister and Politburo member Wang Yi on the sidelines of the ASEAN Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Manila, signalling continued efforts by India and China to stabilise bilateral relations more than six years after the deadly Galwan Valley clashes.

The meeting comes amid a gradual improvement in ties following sustained diplomatic engagement between the two Asian neighbours. Referring to the progress made since the leaders' meeting in Kazan in October 2024, Jaishankar said relations had been steadily moving towards normalisation. "Since the meeting of our leaders in Kazan in October 2024, relations between India and China have been gradually normalising," Jaishankar said. "This direction was further affirmed when they met in Tianjin last August."

The External Affairs Minister underlined that a stable India-China relationship was essential not only for the two countries but also for the broader regional and global order. "Such a relationship can make a valuable contribution to a multipolar Asia and a multipolar world," he said, adding that bilateral ties should be guided by the principles of "mutual respect, mutual interest and mutual sensitivity."

Reiterating India's long-standing position on border issues, Jaishankar stressed that peace along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) remained the foundation for normal bilateral relations. "Peace and tranquillity in the border areas is obviously the prerequisite for normal ties. Since October 2024, both sides have engaged to ensure that important objective. This will continue to need our constant attention," he said.

He also recalled the understanding reached by the two leaderships that "differences should not become disputes," emphasising the need for sus-



Union External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar meets Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi in Manila, Philippines

tained diplomatic engagement to manage differences responsibly. Highlighting recent confidence-building measures, Jaishankar welcomed the resumption of direct flights, updated visa arrangements, the restart of the Kailash Manasarovar Yatra, and the reopening of border trade. At the same time, he flagged unresolved economic concerns, including the need for fair market access, addressing the trade imbalance, and ensuring more predictable supply chains.

The meeting took place against the backdrop of a gradual reset in India-China relations. Following the violent Galwan Valley clash in June 2020, which claimed the lives of 20 Indian soldiers and an undisclosed number of Chinese troops, the two sides have carried out disengagement at several friction points along the LAC while maintaining military and diplomatic dialogue.

The two ministers also discussed multilateral cooperation. India, which holds the BRICS chairmanship this year, will host the BRICS Summit in September.

China has extended its support for India's BRICS Presidency, reflecting a shared interest in maintaining engagement through multilateral platforms even as both countries continue to address bilateral challenges.

Opposition using students' protests as political tool to serve interests: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Wednesday expressed serious concern over the ongoing students' protest in Delhi and accused the opposition of attempting to use it as a "political tool" to fulfil its political interests. Singh urged the opposition to raise issues in Parliament instead of on the streets.

His remarks came as protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) at Jantar Mantar entered the second month, with more supporters joining the agitation.

Additionally, leaders of several opposition parties, wearing black clothes, held a demonstration outside Parliament on Wednesday to express solidarity with students protesting against the NEET paper leak issue. "It is extremely unfortunate that some people are attempting to use the stu-



dents and youth of our country as a political tool to fulfil their political interests," Singh said in a post on X. He said the Narendra Modi Government is committed to fulfilling the aspirations of students and ensuring that no injustice is done to them.

"It is our responsibility to listen to every concern of our students and resolve it. I am fully confident that India's aware, mature and sensible youth fully understand such deceptive attempts and will choose

the path of progress, development and nation-building," he said.

The defence minister alleged that some opposition leaders are displaying a "manufactured sense of anger" to confuse and mislead people, especially the youth. "We are fully sensitive to the sentiments and concerns of the youth. Parliament is in session and the Government has also stated its willingness to have meaningful debates on every issue," Singh said.

He further accused the

opposition of making an "inappropriate attempt" to resolve issues not in Parliament but on the streets. Congress leaders, led by Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and party president Mallikarjun Kharge, held a dharna outside the prime minister's residence on Tuesday, demanding Modi's resignation over the police action against students protesting the alleged NEET paper leak issue.

Besides Rahul Gandhi, Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and other opposition leaders were later detained by the police.

The defence minister said Parliament is the appropriate forum for discussions in a democracy and the opposition should allow the smooth functioning of the ongoing Monsoon session if it is serious about raising public issues.

Suwendu attacks Mamata, Abhishek over appeasement politics, corruption

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari continued his tirade against corruption even as he on Wednesday warned that strong actions would be taken on the top functionaries of the previous Trinamool Congress Government if they were found guilty in the Comptroller and Auditor General report which his Government would table in the State Assembly on July 25.

Addressing the issue in the Assembly Adhikari said that "the previous Government did not table the CAG reports ... but the reports will be placed on July 25 and if any evidence of corruption is found in the CAG reports, we will act according to the recommendations of the report ... no one will be spared — be it the former CM or any minister. We will immediately approach the



Governor for his consent to prosecute the persons concerned ... the Government will directly recommend to the Governor for an FIR to be lodged... more so in the case of misuse of funds for (super cyclone) Amphan."

The super cyclone hit the State in 2020 post which the Centre had sent ₹3,750 crore for relief. But there were allegations of large-scale corruption in the use of the Amphan funds.

He said, "Honorable Prime Minister Narendra Modi-ji provided ₹3,750 crore in two

installments during Amphan ... but soon there were reports of major corruption (in utilisation of funds and distribution of relief) ... this even led to Public Interest Litigations (PILs) in the Calcutta High Court."

Adhikari slammed the previous Mamata Banerjee Government for not tabling the report of the CAG inquiry which was ordered by the High Court adding while the report will be placed on July 25 full discussion would take place in the next session post which actions if required would be taken against those found to be guilty.

The Chief Minister also said that the Uniform Civil Code Bill would be tabled in a special session of the House only after the Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai report on the issue was placed before the Government.

Alleging that the previous Government had systemati-

cally demolished all the constitutional bodies including the Human Rights Commission, Women's Commission, Child Protection Commission, Information Commission etc the Chief Minister said that all these commissions would be made functional from August 1. "From August 1, all these constitutional bodies will be functional. They will have to accept complaints and will be bound to take action on them," he said.

Referring to a severe statement from TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee that scores would be settled when his party would come back to power in 2031, Adhikari said that Banerjee who is also the nephew of Mamata Banerjee would not be able to win the next parliamentary elections in 2029 from Diamond Harbour seat which he had won by 7.5 lakh votes in 2024.

WB CM ANNOUNCES ₹5 LAKH AID FOR KIN OF TRAWLER, SIKKIM TUNNEL VICTIMS

Kolkata: West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Wednesday announced an ex gratia of ₹5 lakh and a civic volunteer's job for one member of the family of every person from the state killed in the recent trawler tragedy off the state's coast and the under-construction tunnel disaster in neighbouring Sikkim.

Making the announcement in the state assembly, Adhikari expressed grief over the two tragedies and said the state Government would stand by the affected families.

The announcement came after BJP MLA Chandrasekhar Mondal raised the issue of the fishing trawler that went missing in the Bay of Bengal on July 2 with several fishermen on board. The trawler, based in Shankarpur in Purba Medinipur district, was traced five days later, overturned near Bagher Char off Kakdwip. "So far, 11 decomposed bodies of fishermen have been recovered from the trawler, while four others are still missing," the chief minister said, describing the incident as a major tragedy. He said most of the deceased fishermen hailed from the coastal areas of Purba Medinipur, Howrah and Nadia districts. Adhikari announced that the next of kin of each deceased fisherman would receive ₹5 lakh financial assistance and that one eligible member from every affected family would be appointed as a civic volunteer in the local police station.

The chief minister also announced the same compensation package for families of West Bengal residents killed in the tunnel disaster in Sikkim.

States Focus



Representation image

ABVP SEEKS HIGH-LEVEL PANEL ON COMPETITIVE EXAM REFORMS

The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) on Wednesday demanded that the Centre constitute a high-level committee to conduct a comprehensive review of the integrity, transparency and institutional reforms in competitive examinations.

In a statement, the youth organisation affiliated to the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) said the committee should submit "concrete, time-bound recommendations" to make the examination system more credible and accountable. The youth organisation also condemned the acts of "chaos, public disruption, and violent clashes" that unfolded at Jantar Mantar during recent demonstrations regarding NEET-UG and education reform. (PTI)



NGT SEEKS NMCG REPLY ON GANGA FLOODPLAIN IN VARANASI

The National Green Tribunal has asked the National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) to explain the basis for the criteria it used to demarcate the Ganga River's floodplain in Varanasi, noting potential discrepancy between its adopted methodology and rules. A bench of NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert member A Senthil Vel was hearing the matter regarding an alleged illegal construction by M/s Sri Wari Chemicals Private Ltd inside the active floodplain zone at Ramghat in Varanasi. (PTI)

TMC MLA marshalled out of West Bengal Assembly, suspended

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

TMC MLA Kunal Ghosh of the Mamata Banerjee-led 'Kalighat' faction of the party was on Wednesday marshalled out of the West Bengal Assembly and later suspended for the remainder of the day after he disrupted proceedings by preventing Opposition Chief Whip Akhruzzaman from speaking during a debate.

Dramatic scenes unfolded during the discussion on the budgetary demands of the Home and Hill Affairs Department, as Ghosh resisted eviction, prompting Assembly marshals to lift and carry him out of the House after repeated appeals by the Speaker failed to restore order.

The scuffle triggered noisy protests, with members trooping into the well before proceedings could resume.

The dramatic scenes, marked by slogan shouting, jostling and intervention by marshals, underscored the deepening rift within the Trinamool Congress legislature party between the TMC's Kalighat camp and the rebel



faction headed by Opposition Leader Ritabrata Banerjee.

The commotion began when Akhruzzaman, a legislator aligned with the Ritabrata camp, rose to participate in the discussion. Ghosh immediately left his seat and stood in front of the microphone allotted to Akhruzzaman, repeatedly asking him why his own name had been removed from the list of speakers.

"Why did you strike off my name? Why are you not allowing me to speak?" Ghosh was heard asking

CCTVs in police stations: SC says things moving very well

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday said things are moving well and have taken a positive turn in the matter concerning installation of CCTVs in police stations across the country.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta was informed by senior advocate Siddhartha Dave, who is assisting the top court as an amicus curiae in the matter, that substantial progress has been made.

"It is heartening to note that in this matter, things are moving very well and we must give credit to Dave for his efforts," the bench said, adding that things have taken a positive turn in the last few months.

The top court was hearing a suo motu matter concerning the lack of functional CCTVs in police stations.

During the hearing, the bench flagged two issues — extension of the funding scheme for installation of CCTVs in police stations and maintenance of cameras installed.

The law officer appearing for the Centre said he would take instructions on these aspects.

The top court granted two weeks to the law officer to take instructions and posted the matter for hearing on August 5.

It noted that the amicus has placed before it a note based on the meeting held on July 11 with the representatives of the Centre, states and the Union Territories (UTs).



On May 13, the amicus had informed the bench that most of the States were proceeding in the right direction and substantial work was carried out with regard to the installation

of CCTVs in police stations.

Earlier, the issue concerning utilisation of funds by the states for the installation of CCTVs was flagged before the court.

The bench was informed that the Centre gives 100 per cent funds in UTs and 90 per cent in the hilly States.

It was told that in the remaining States, the Centre gives 60 per cent, while the remaining 40 per cent funding is by the respective State.

The top court had earlier directed registration of a suo motu case over the lack of functional CCTVs in police stations after taking cognisance of a media report.

The apex court had in 2018 ordered the installation of CCTV cameras across police stations to check human rights abuses.

In December 2020, the top court directed the Centre to install CCTV cameras and recording equipment at the offices of investigating agen-

cies, including the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and the National Investigation Agency (NIA).

It said that States and UTs should ensure that CCTV cameras were installed at every police station, at all entry and exit points, main gate, lock-ups, corridors, lobby and reception, as well as in areas outside the lock-up rooms so that no part was left uncovered.

The top court had said that CCTV systems must be equipped with night vision and have audio as well as video footage.

The court had made it mandatory for the Centre, states and the UTs to purchase such systems which allow storage of data for at least one year.

Jadhav proposes Ayush OPDs in military hospitals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union minister Prataprao Jadhav has written to Defence Minister Rajnath Singh proposing the establishment of Ayush OPDs and the provision of Ayush-based treatment services across military and field hospitals.

Jadhav, the Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Ayush, highlighted in his letter the role played by the Armed Forces Medical Services in providing healthcare to the country's soldiers serving in diverse and often challenging operational environments.

While noting that the Armed Forces have a robust modern medical infrastructure, he said integrating India's traditional systems of medicine can further strengthen preventive, promotive and holistic healthcare for defence personnel,



according to a statement issued by the ministry.

Jadhav said Ayush facilities are presently available only in a limited number of institutions under the Ministry of Defence and that a large number of military and field hospitals do not yet have dedicated Ayush services.

He suggested that expanding Ayush facilities across these hospitals would provide soldiers with greater access to evidence-based traditional healthcare, particularly in the areas of preventive healthcare, lifestyle management, rehabilitation and overall well-being.

Mehbooba slams Omar for ruling out Article 370 return

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti on Wednesday said that Chief Minister Omar Abdullah "ruling out" the reinstatement of Article 370 was like pouring acid on the hopes of the people of Jammu and Kashmir, trying to instil a sense of defeat among them.

"Stating that (Article) 370 will not return is like throwing acid on the hopes of the people of J&K, which should not be done. He (Abdullah) wants to instil a sense of defeat among people, which I don't think any leader should do. It is not right," Mehbooba told reporters when asked about the issue.

Addressing a press conference on Tuesday, Abdullah said, "Some people tell us to talk about (restoration of) Article 370 and J&K's special status first... I want to ask them, what does Article 370 or 371



PDP president Mehbooba Mufti, along with former MLA Shoaib Lone, who recently joined the party, addressing a press conference at the party headquarters in Srinagar on Wednesday

ranging from plebiscite to autonomy. I think it is unfair," she said.

The former J&K chief minister also accused the National Conference (NC) of trying to normalise the post-2019 situation in J&K.

"The NC has always normalised such situations. When the late (NC founder) Sheikh Abdullah signed the 1975 accord, there were posts of prime minister and 'Sadar-e-Riyasat'. But he compromised on both to become the chief minister, thereby normalising all the erosions that took place until then.

"Similarly, looking at Omar Abdullah's current activities going to the Jantar Mantar and talking only about Statehood, avoiding talking about Article 370 and now claiming that its restoration is impossible, I believe they are normalising what was done to J&K in 2019. They are normalising the situation, just like the BJP," Mehbooba said.

mean without Statehood?"

He argued that clubbing the demand for Statehood with the restoration of Article 370 only gave the BJP-led Centre an excuse to delay restoring Statehood to J&K.

"To expect the BJP Government to restore Article 370 will be foolishness. What we can get from this Government is the foundation for restoring special status," Abdullah said.

Asked about her views on Abdullah's remarks,

Mehbooba said, "The Kashmir issue is alive even today, and it has to be resolved."

"Articles 370 and 35A should be a part of it (the resolution). Statehood is a part of what happened to us in 2019. It is like cutting off someone's feet and then saying, since the feet are gone, give me the shoes. I feel this is unfair to the people of J&K and to his (Abdullah's) own party (National Conference), which made grand promises

Congress protests in Delhi delay Karnataka Cabinet reshuffle

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With the Congress central leadership occupied with the students' protest in the Capital, the much-awaited expansion of the Karnataka cabinet has been delayed further.

Chief Minister DK Shivakumar and predecessor Siddaramaiah were unable to finalise the list of probable ministers with the Congress high command on Tuesday.

The two leaders, along with Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) president BK Hariprasad, had travelled to Delhi for the meeting. However, the discussion could not take place as Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, along with several MPs, took part on Tuesday in a dharna outside Prime Minister Narendra Modi's residence over the police action against protesting students.

"Senior leaders have been asked to come again for the discussion on Saturday or Sunday. The list may be finalised then, and the swearing-in will be next week," PWD Minister Satish Jarkihole told reporters.

He added that the discus-



Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar

sion could not take place "due to the protest held in the interest of the country."

Talks are also on for creating two posts of deputy chief ministers to represent the Scheduled Tribe (ST) and Lingayat communities.

"We have heard about this, but the final decision is to be taken by the senior leaders," Jarkihole said, adding that he had not personally demanded a deputy chief minister's post from the ST community.

Before leaving for Bengaluru, Siddaramaiah

held a breakfast meeting in Delhi with a few legislators, including Basavaraj Rayareddy, Ashok Pattan, Rajendra Rajanna, Basavaraj Shivannavar and Tejaswini Gowda, among other State Congress leaders.

Asked about his next visit to the national Capital, Siddaramaiah said the decision rested with the Congress high command. Shivakumar, Siddaramaiah and Hariprasad flew back to Bengaluru on a private flight after the meeting fell through.

Rahul Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav led a sit-in outside the PM's residence demanding Modi's resignation over Monday's police action against protesting students.

The chief ministers of Karnataka and Kerala, along with several MPs, joined the dharna, which began around 3.30 pm after Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi visited injured students at a hospital.

Rahul Gandhi was

detained and released later on Tuesday night.

Preliminary talks were held last week, but the list could not be finalised after AICC president Mallikarjuna Kharge had to leave for Bengaluru on urgent work.

"The discussions have just started... very soon there will be an expansion of the Karnataka Cabinet," AICC in-charge for Karnataka Randeep Surjewala had said after that round.

The reshuffle is also expected to address the vacant assembly speaker's post as it fell vacant after UT Khader took over as health minister and the vacancy of deputy chairperson of the Legislative Council.

Surjewala had said selection of probable candidates would factor in caste, religion and regional representation, with young leaders likely to get priority. A woman minister is also expected to be inducted, as the Cabinet currently has no woman member.

With Delhi visits piling up and Kharge yet to take stock of the State unit's list, sources said the leadership faces mounting pressure to manage competing claims from aspirants.

Govt warns of exponential rise in drone drug smuggling

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Agencies have noticed an exponential rise in the use of drone-assisted narcotics smuggling by drug trafficking syndicates, who are using encrypted digital platforms to shield operatives' identities and obfuscate financial transactions, with Punjab emerging as the "most affected border State", the Rajya Sabha was informed on Wednesday.

In a written response, Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai said drone-assisted drug trafficking has witnessed an "exponential rise", making Punjab "the most affected border State" in the country.

Rai said trends of cross-border narcotics infiltration reveal that drug trafficking



MoS Home Affairs Nityanand Rai speaks in the Rajya Sabha during the Monsoon Session of Parliament in New Delhi on Wednesday

syndicates operating from across the border have increasingly been employing sophisticated methods such as drones, GPS-enabled consignments, encrypted communications and local receiv-

er networks to infiltrate heroin, methamphetamine and arms and ammunition into India.

"In 2025 alone, 305 drone-related drug trafficking incidents were reported nation-

wide, of which 298 occurred along the Punjab border, resulting in the seizure of about 460 kg of narcotic drugs, including 448 kg of heroin, 9 kg of methamphetamine and 3 kg of opium, which reflects the concentration of this emerging threat in the State," Rai said.

He said the Government is extending comprehensive support for combating trans-border narcotics trafficking through various means like deployment of advanced anti-drone systems along most vulnerable stretches, installation of enhanced surveillance systems including CCTV cameras, PTZ (Pan-Tilt-Zoom), NVD (Night Vision Devices), strengthening border fencing through installation of new design fence, border flood light, etc.

Google defends Play Store after Hyderabad cyber crime police name India head

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Google on Wednesday said it has initiated an immediate investigation after being alerted about alleged cyber fraud cases involving investment apps and found that only one of them was available on the Play Store and complies with its financial services policy.

The comment from the tech giant assumes significance as Hyderabad Cyber Crime Police has named the "Head of Google in India" as a co-accused in three cyber fraud cases in which the complainants alleged that fraudsters cheated them in the name of high returns to their investments by making them download "fake" apps from Google Play Store.

"Google Play strictly prohibits all forms of deception. We investigated this issue as soon as we were alerted, and confirmed that only one app was available on the Play Store. Our reviews



reveal that the app complies with Play's financial services policy," a Google spokesperson said.

The spokesperson further said Google reviews valid legal removal requests when notified through the correct legal processes "and, where appropriate, we restrict or remove

apps in keeping with local laws".

In the Hyderabad cases, complainants have alleged that they downloaded the fraudulent trading applications, believing them to be genuine and trustworthy because they were available in the Google Play Store.

Based on the three separate complaints, police registered cases under relevant sections of the IT Act and BNS against the fraudsters and the Google India Head.

A senior police official said that they are in the process of issuing a notice to Google India seeking information about such apps.

The complainant stated that the accused, through the fraudulent investment platform, whose app is available on the Play Store, dishonestly induced him to transfer huge sums of money on the false promise of high investment returns and then refused to release his funds.

Assam floods: 31 dead, 5.65 lakh affected

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Thirty one people lost their lives and nearly 5.65 lakh were affected by floods in Assam for the past two days with incessant rain across several districts deteriorating the overall situation on Wednesday, officials said.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma visited several flood-affected areas in Upper Assam districts and interacted with the victims, and announced an ex gratia of ₹4 lakh to the relatives of each deceased.

“There has been extensive damage caused by the floods. I have assured the affected families that they are not alone in this crisis. Our Government is standing with them in every step of rehabilitation and rebuilding of livelihoods,” he told reporters in Sivasagar.

On complaints of not receiving relief items by a large section of the affected people, Sarma said that there have been difficulties in providing relief materials in villages which are under water.

“There is no road or any mode of communication to



reach out to those people who are still in their homes. The administration accepts that. We have not been able to reach many places. As and when floodwaters recede, we will be able to reach such localities. We also cannot airdrop relief items now. We are trying our best to reduce the people's difficulties,” the Chief Minister said.

The CM, however, said that for all those who have

managed to reach the relief camps, there is no shortage or issue in distributing relief items. “We will immediately give a relief of government 4 lakh to the relatives or families of every deceased. I will also try to help them in future.”

According to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), 21 people have lost their lives in the deluge during the last

24 hours.

Thirteen people, including four women and two children, drowned in floodwaters in the Sivasagar district, followed by five, including two children, in Charaideo, two in Golaghat, and one woman in Jorhat, it added.

According to the authority's daily flood report issued at midnight on Tuesday, more than 5,64,600 people have been affected in

Biswanath, Charaideo, Dhemaji, Dibrugarh, Golaghat, Jorhat, Kamrup, Kamrup Metropolitan, Karbi Anglong, Nagaon, Sivasagar and Tinsukia districts.

Sivasagar is the worst-hit district with nearly 3.6 lakh people affected, followed by Jorhat with almost 88,000 and Charaideo with more than 72,500 reeling under floodwaters.

The India Meteorological Department has issued a ‘yellow alert’ for Assam and predicted thunderstorms and heavy rains at isolated places over the next four days.

IMD's Regional Meteorological Centre (RMC) in Guwahati said that the upper air cyclonic circulation over Central Assam and adjoining Nagaland between 1.5 and 3.1 km above mean sea level has become less marked.

Sarma said he interacted with the people at one of the relief camps set up in Charaideo to take stock of their situation and assured them that people with serious illness or who are immobile will be shifted to hospitals.

“Medical teams and all

essential services are in place. I assured every family that we will stand by them through relief, rehabilitation and recovery,” he added. Multiple agencies, like the Army, NDRF, SDRF, Fire & Emergency Service, police and civil agencies, have rescued more than 6,000 people from different parts of Charaideo, Golaghat, Jorhat and Sivasagar, it added.

At present, 872 villages are under water, and 24,210.35 hectares of crop areas have been damaged across Assam, the ASDMA said.

At present, the Brahmaputra river is flowing above the danger mark at Neamatighat, while its tributaries Buridihing at Khowang, and Dhanisiri at Golaghat and Numaligarh are also flowing above the danger level.

On the other hand, the Dikhou river at Sivasagar and the Disang river at Nanglamuraghat are flowing above the highest flood level, the ASDMA said.

On account of widespread flooding, 1,85,029 domestic animals and poultry are affected across the state.

Uddhav bats for Opposition dialogue as AAP accuses Congress of suppressing CJP protest



AAP National Convenor Arvind Kejriwal and Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray during a joint press conference over the ongoing student protests in New Delhi on Wednesday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Wednesday said that just as the Government should engage in dialogue with the protesting students, Opposition parties also should talk to each other on the issue.

His remarks came in response to AAP's allegation that Congress was the BJP's “B-Team” and staged a protest in front of the prime minister's residence on Tuesday to suppress the Cockroach Janata Party's (CJP) agitation, suggesting differences within the Opposition over the ongoing students' protest. “We must stand behind the youth. I am with the youth, which is why I met Abhijeet (Dipke). Just as the Government should talk to the youth, the Opposition should also talk to each other,” Thackeray, who arrived in Delhi on Tuesday evening and went to the Jantar Mantar to meet the CJP founder, told a press conference. Hours after the press conference, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal met Thackeray at Shiv Sena (UBT) Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut's residence here. Thackeray said he had backed the students' agitation from the very beginning and accused the Centre of refusing to engage with them despite the protest continuing for more than a month.

“I have backed this protest since day one. The youth are the future of the country. If you are going to crush them, they will not accept it. When you call them cockroaches, it goes beyond all limits of tolerance. The youth will not remain

silent if dictatorship is imposed on the country,” Thackeray said. Questioning the Government's handling of the agitation, the former Maharashtra chief minister said dialogue was the essence of democracy. “What is wrong with talking to the youth? They have been protesting for more than a month. Had the Government spoken to them, the issue would have been resolved,” he said.

“Whenever anyone stages a protest, it is the Government's duty to go and speak to them. If they are under some misconception, it is the Government's responsibility to clear it through dialogue. Had the Government spoken to them on the very first day, matters would never have reached this point,” Thackeray said. Recalling earlier instances of governments engaging with protesters, Thackeray said former prime minister Indira Gandhi personally met Sonam Wangchuk's father during a hunger strike in Leh, while the UPA Government deputed then-Union minister Vilasrao Deshmukh to hold talks with Anna Hazare during his anti-corruption movement. If the Government could keep channels of dialogue open with Pakistan despite accusing it of sponsoring terrorism, it should have no hesitation in engaging with the protesting students, Thackeray said.

He cited RSS general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale's remarks in a PTI interview in May that there should always be a window for dialogue between the civil societies of India and Pakistan.

J&K LG: Anantnag terror attack won't go unpunished

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Wednesday condemned the killing of a policeman in a terrorist attack in Anantnag district and said the heinous crime will not go unpunished.

Head Constable Ashiq Hussain, posted on Amarnath Yatra security duty, was shot dead by a terrorist at Lal Chowk in Anantnag around 12.30 pm. “I strongly condemn this cowardly attack. This heinous act will not go unpunished. J&K Police and our security forces are on the ground and will bring those responsible to justice,” Sinha said in a post on X. He said he spoke to Director General of Police (DGP) Nalin Prabhat to take



stock of the situation. “I spoke with DGP Shri Nalin Prabhat to review the situation following the terror attack in Anantnag. My heartfelt condolences to the family of Head Constable Ashiq Hussain Qureshi, who sacrificed his life in the line of duty. The whole country stands shoulder-to-shoulder with the family of the martyr,” he added. DGP Prabhat visited the spot for a first-hand assessment of the situation. A massive operation has been launched to track the terrorist.

629 national highway projects behind schedule: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As many as 629 national highway projects have missed their original completion schedule among the total 1,191 under-construction projects, Parliament was informed on Wednesday.

In a written reply to the Rajya Sabha, Union Minister Nitin Gadkari said that currently 1,191 National Highway (NH) projects are under construction without attaining any of the various stages of project completion.

“Of these, 629 projects have spilled beyond their original completion schedule,” the minister stated without assigning any reason for the delay.

In a separate reply, the minister said that from 2023-24 to 2025-26, 103 contractor/concessionaire were blacklisted/penalised for poor quality work in the execution of national



highway construction work execution. Responding to a separate question, Gadkari said the Government has adopted a phased roadmap for deployment of advanced traffic management systems (ATMS) across all four-lane and above National Highways and Expressways (about 52,647 km).

The roadmap includes establishment of Local, Regional, and National

Command and Control Centres for centralised monitoring, incident management, traffic analytics, and coordinated response, he added. The road transport and highways minister said to ensure interoperability, scalability, and uniform service delivery across the National Highway network, a Unified ATMS Software Platform is being implemented with standardised proto-

cols for monitoring, enforcement, data integration, and performance management.

Responding to another question, Gadkari said based on the available accident data from Electronic Detailed Accident Report (e-DAR) for the period 2023-2025, total number of 6,358 Black corridors have been identified.

Certain segments on National Highways (NHs) have been identified as black corridors which are continuous stretches qualifying the criteria of black spots i.e. locations with occurrence of certain number of accidents involving fatalities and grievous injuries.

These black corridors have been identified in real time through AI-based tools.

To a separate query, he said the Government has introduced a FASTag-based Annual Pass for non-commercial cars, jeeps, and vans, which has come into effect from 15th August, 2025.

No compromise on crowd management during Bahuda Yatra: Odisha CM Majhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar/Puri

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Wednesday reviewed preparations for the Bahuda Yatra and directed officials to ensure foolproof crowd management and security arrangements in Puri.

His instructions come in the wake of the death of two devotees and several others falling ill during the Rath Yatra in Puri on July 16.

Reviewing preparations for the return car festival scheduled on July 24, Majhi stressed the need for foolproof arrangements as lakhs of devotees are expected to visit the pilgrim town. The three chariots of Lord Jagannath, Lord Balabhadra and Devi Subhadra will be pulled back to the 12th-century shrine during the Bahuda Yatra on July 24.



Bahuda Yatra will be followed by the ceremonial Suna Besha of the sibling deities on July 25, which is expected to draw more than 10 lakh devotees. While asking the Shree Jagannath Temple Administration to ensure smooth conduct of rituals, the chief minister said, “There should be no compromise in matters of law and order, security and crowd management.” He asked officials to adopt scientific methods and use technology to monitor crowd density and integrate CCTV feeds with the Integrated Command and Control System for swift response to any situation.

Tripura DGP Anurag Dhankar cremated with full State honours in UP home town

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Baghpat (UP)

Tripura Director General of Police (DGP) Anurag Dhankar was on Wednesday cremated with full State honours in his ancestral town of Baraut here in Uttar Pradesh, officials said.

His son, Abhishek, lit the funeral pyre at the cremation ground near Bawli Chungi on the Delhi-Saharanpur highway. A guard of honour was accorded to the senior IPS officer before the last rites.

Dhankar (60) was found hanging in his washroom at the Tripura police headquarters on Monday. Officials have said it appears to be a case of suicide. He was elevated to the post of DGP from Additional DGP in May 2025 and was due to retire in 11 months.

On Wednesday, a funeral procession of around 1 km was taken out. Nearly 500 people, including police offi-



cers, public representatives and locals, participated in it. Dhankar, a native of Biharipur village in Baghpat district, was brought to his residence on Gandhi Road in Baraut shortly after midnight on Tuesday.

From Wednesday morning, a large number of people gathered to pay their last respects. Senior police and administrative officials, elected representatives and local residents offered floral tributes. Uttar Pradesh

Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Social Welfare Asim Arun, a former IPS officer, attended the funeral and expressed condolences to the bereaved family.

Arun and Dhankar belonged to the 1994 batch of the Indian Police Service and had training together at the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration in Mussoorie and the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel National Police Academy in Hyderabad. They also served together in the United Nations mission in Kosovo. Recalling his batchmate and close friend, Arun shared memories of their years together and prayed for peace to the departed soul. Dhankar led the CBI probe into the Rs 13,000 crore PNB fraud case involving Nirav Modi and the reinvestigation of the 1984 anti-Sikh riots case. He is survived by his wife and son, who lives in Canada.

SC asks States, UTs to consider raising judicial offices retirement age from 60 to 61 years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday asked the states and union territories to consider raising the age of superannuation of judicial officers from 60 to 61 years.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joyymallya Bagchi and V Mohana passed the direction while hearing a petition seeking uniform enhancement of the retirement age of district judiciary judges from 60 to 62 years across the country. “All State governments and union territories (UTs) are directed to take a decision, in consultation with their respective jurisdiction-



al high courts, on this issue. In case they agree, judicial officers in such states shall be permitted to continue in service up to the age of 61 years. Such continuation shall remain subject to the final outcome of these proceedings,” the bench ordered. The provision will come

into effect from April 1, 2026. While the retirement age of Supreme Court judges is 65, the high court judges superannuate at the age of 62 years. It also said that the interim arrangement would not prejudice the final adjudication on the substantive legal question of whether the retirement age of district judicial officers should be uniformly enhanced from 60 to 62 years throughout the country.

“We clarify that the question of law formulated at the outset shall be decided by this court independently, irrespective of the stand that may be taken by the states or the high courts,” the bench said. It directed all states and UTs, after consulting

their respective high courts, to place their stand on record within two weeks.

The jurisdictional high courts have also been asked to file their responses within the same period. However, the bench clarified that states and the high courts that are already in agreement with enhancing the retirement age need not file detailed counter affidavits, and a brief statement indicating their concurrence would suffice.

The issue arises against the backdrop of the top court's 2002 judgment declining to accept the recommendation of the Justice K Jagannatha Shetty Commission, which had proposed raising the retirement

age of district judges to 62 years. Since then, some states, including Telangana and Madhya Pradesh, have moved towards increasing the retirement age.

On Wednesday, the bench was informed that the Full Court of the Madhya Pradesh High Court has now passed a resolution recommending enhancement of the retirement age of judicial officers from 60 to 62 years. It was, however, pointed out that certain high courts, including the Punjab and Haryana High Court, continue to oppose the proposal, citing the fact that the retirement age of Government employees in their respective states remains 60 years or below.

Sikkim: Rescuers resume operation to recover bodies from NHPC tunnel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Namchi

Search and rescue operations at the under-construction NHPC Teesta Stage VI Hydropower Project tunnel in Sikkim's Namchi district resumed on Wednesday after being temporarily suspended due to the accumulation of mud and water inside the tunnel, officials said.

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and the Asansol rescue team resumed operations early in the day, with efforts focused on pumping water out of the tunnel, they said.



Officials present at the site after a tunnel under construction collapsed following an explosion of suspected methane gas, leaving at least 20 workers killed and five others trapped for over 24 hours in Namchi district, Sikkim

At least 20 workers were killed after the tunnel under construction collapsed following an explosion of suspected methane gas. Officials said that 12 bodies have so far been retrieved

from the tunnel. The recovery of the remaining bodies will begin once the accumulated water is drained and the site is declared safe for further operations, they said.



Editor's
TAKE

Tunnel collapse: Safety cannot be an afterthought

The tragedy at the Teesta Stage-VI project in Sikkim already feels depressingly familiar – we fail to prioritise safety systems

The tunnel – part of NHPC's 500 MW Teesta Stage-VI hydropower project, built by contractor Patel Engineering - caved in on July 20 after workers reportedly tried to vent a pocket of naturally occurring methane gas trapped in the rock. That attempt is suspected to have triggered an explosion, which set off a landslide, sealing the tunnel's mouth. Of the 27 people inside, only two could escape.

Days on, NDRF, SDRF and mine-safety teams are still fighting low oxygen, carbon monoxide and blocked debris to reach those unaccounted for, as the confirmed toll keeps climbing. What makes this tragedy so hard to accept is how familiar the warning signs look in hindsight.

Methane pockets trapped in young Himalayan rock are a known hazard in this terrain, and standard practice calls for careful monitoring and controlled release – not an on-the-spot venting attempt near a live worksite. That such an attempt could trigger an explosion powerful enough to bring down the tunnel roof points to a breakdown in monitoring, ventilation or protocol – questions the promised inquiry must answer honestly, not defensively. This is not an isolated failure.

In 2023, all 41 workers trapped in Uttarakhand's Silkyara tunnel were pulled out alive after a globally watched 17-day rescue. In 2025, a similar collapse at Telangana's SLBC tunnel ended far worse, with most trapped workers never recovered alive. Each time, officials promise inquiries and stricter norms; each time, the cycle repeats at the next site, and another list of names is read into a moment of silence – as Sikkim's Assembly did this week for the Samardung victims. Preventing a repeat needs more than compensation cheques, necessary as those are for grieving families.

India needs mandatory, real-time gas monitoring and ventilation on every underground worksite, not only coal mines; independent safety clearances that precede construction rather than follow disaster; enforceable protocols for handling suspected gas pockets; and public, time-bound accounting of past inquiries, so contractors understand negligence carries consequences beyond a bad headline.

Migrant workers – Samardung's victims came from West Bengal, Assam, Punjab and Uttarakhand, and Sikkim itself – deserve written safety briefings, accident insurance and enforced contracts, not just an ex-gratia cheque after they are gone.

The men who died at Samardung were building the power lines meant to light homes hundreds of kilometres away –infrastructure the rest of the country will use without a second thought.

They deserved a worksite built with the same urgency now spent on their rescue. Until India treats tunnel safety as non-negotiable rather than an afterthought, the next collapse isn't a possibility. It's a schedule.

The Pawar puzzle: Can he make a comeback?

With contentious legislation on parliamentary delimitation set to dominate the session and Maharashtra's political equations in flux, Pawar's next move could determine not only the future of the NCP but also the balance of power in one of India's most politically significant states



KALYANI SHANKAR

As the Monsoon Session of Parliament begins, Sharad Pawar, the leader of the NCP, faces internal conflicts within his party. There could be political changes first in Maharashtra, and then the merged NCP could ally with the BJP.

Pawar is known as a political survivor because he has often saved his party from disappearing. He is skilled at forming unexpected alliances, such as the 2019 Maha Vikas Aghadi alliance with Shiv Sena and Congress. He also has a strong grassroots network in Maharashtra. Even after the tragic loss of his nephew, Ajit Pawar, in a plane crash, and ongoing power struggles within his faction of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), he still has significant influence in both national and regional politics.

In July 2023, the political climate in Maharashtra worsened when Ajit Pawar left the NCP to join the BJP-Shiv Sena government. Soon after, the Election Commission recognised Ajit Pawar's group as the official NCP. In response, Sharad Pawar started a new party called the Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar). Now, Maharashtra has two rival parties, both claiming the same political legacy. This session arrives at a critical point, where upcoming legislation on parliamentary representation could reshape governance, inspiring hope for change despite controversy.

Pawar's involvement in the legislative process is especially important given the upcoming bill to amend provisions related to parliamentary representation in India, which could significantly alter Maharashtra's influence by increasing Lok Sabha seats from 550 to 850 and shifting census-based delimitation powers.

This bill is an important step in the ongoing conversation about how we represent people in Parliament. It is especially relevant for Maharashtra and the southern states, where people are concerned about getting fair representation and sharing resources. The bill proposes increasing the number of parliamentary seats from 543 to 850 and introducing new rules for reporting census data. These changes could greatly impact the political landscape in these regions.

Sharad Pawar has the opportunity to build coalitions and address stakeholders' concerns, which can foster confidence and optimism about his ability to influence Parliament's



FOLLOWING THE TRAGIC LOSS OF HIS NEPHEW, AJIT PAWAR, IN A PLANE CRASH IN JANUARY 2026, THE PARTY HAS THE CHANCE TO ADDRESS SUCCESSION CHALLENGES, WITH AJIT'S WIDOW, SUNETRA PAWAR, STEPPING INTO THE ROLES OF DEPUTY CHIEF MINISTER AND STATE PARTY CHIEF

The writer is a popular columnist

support. As a pivotal figure in Maharashtra politics, Pawar has demonstrated resilience amid internal divisions within his Nationalist Congress Party (NCP). Following the tragic loss of his nephew, Ajit Pawar, in a plane crash in January 2026, the party has the chance to address succession challenges, with Ajit's widow, Sunetra Pawar, stepping into the roles of Deputy Chief Minister and state party chief. Despite facing these challenges and ongoing factional issues, Sharad Pawar retains significant influence over the NCP. This situation presents a critical juncture for the party to regroup and develop innovative strategies to succeed in future Assembly elections.

Pawar faces pressure to merge with the NDA-aligned NCP faction. However, his search for a solution raises hope for stability while also highlighting concerns about ongoing factional conflicts.

This situation illustrates that Pawar is resolutely committed to preserving unity within the opposition and has consciously chosen to forgo any merger plans. His actions not only bolster his leadership but also demonstrate his support for political stability in Maharashtra, thereby enhancing confidence in his resolve.

Sharad Pawar's faction has eight MPs in the Lok Sabha and plays an important role as the NDA seeks to strengthen its majority. This group's support could be key to passing important laws, such as the women's reservation bill, which proposes reserving 33 per cent of seats in Parliament and state Assemblies for women. If Pawar's

faction supports these reforms, it could significantly affect their implementation and influence the legislative process now and in the future.

Sharad Pawar reflects on his extensive political journey; he notes the significance of fleeting moments in politics, having 'witnessed many sunrises and sunsets', and remains cautious about his future alliances amid Maharashtra's shifting landscape. Observers and political analysts are closely watching whether Pawar's faction will align with the NDA or continue to navigate a complex, evolving political terrain that could reshape governance in Maharashtra and beyond.

At present, there is no official confirmation regarding a merger or the establishment of an NDA alliance. However, the series of events - such as reports of ongoing merger discussions, meetings between senior leaders from various political parties, and a separate discussion with Fadnavis on Tuesday night - indicates that talks are still underway behind the scenes. It is said that the two NCPs will merge first, and only then could they join the NDA.

Pawar has the option of going with the Congress too, but this will pose problems regarding his role and his daughter's role in Congress.

The coming days will be crucial as the session unfolds, and the implications of these political manoeuvres will resonate beyond Parliament, shaping broader public perception of governance and representation in the region.

PIC TALK



Forest guards patrol the flood-submerged Pobitora Wildlife Sanctuary in a boat, in Morigaon district, Assam

PHOTO: PTI

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AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

Please believe me, we are all defined by our dominant emotion. The main ones are lust, greed, anger and hate. Out of these, lust is the most common and harmful. Lord Krishna has spoken about lust, anger and greed as three doors to hell (the Bhagavad Gita, verse 16.21). And the Lord has termed the jealous and mischievous as the lowest among men (14.19). Specifically, the Lord has singled out lust as the worst enemy of humanity.

The reasons are obvious. "It is lust only that devours, and is a great sinner. Know this to be the enemy of the world." (3.37) "By this insatiable fire in the form of lust, which is the eternal enemy of a knowledgeable person, knowledge is covered." (3.39)

I have quoted these verses because no one other than God could have explained the gravity of the situation



better. I am an avid reader of the Gita. A few decades ago, I decided to take shelter in God to fight against my dominant emotion of lust. By the way, lust is of many kinds, like lust for wealth, power, fame and sensuous attractions. We all have weaknesses for all these, but one of them dominates and defines us.

Taking shelter in God and remaining in His shelter are not the same. Many take shelter in God for different reasons. Lord Krishna has explained, "Four kinds of virtuous people worship Me. These are a distressed person, an inquisitive person, a seeker of wealth and a wise person." (7.16) I realised over a period of time that I fitted all these descriptions of taking God's shelter.

Soul searching is required now not later

Therefore, I had to do better; I graduated from taking shelter in God to remaining in the shelter of God. I began to sincerely pray for Him to take charge of me.

This is when my transformation began. My Lord, convinced of my sincerity, took me under His care. He began working on my nature. The deep-rooted aspects don't change like habits of eating, etc., can be changed. Only God can help in changing the deep-rooted ones because He alone knows our real weaknesses and our deep desires. He knows what will really move us, which will make us agree to take the pain for their change. And plenty of pain of reformation is required to get the nature changed. My Lord has a wonderful system of reformation. He punishes me with my bad karmaphalas (fruits of deeds) coming to fruition, and He rewards me with good karmaphalas on alternate days. This way, I have kept on going. The result is unbelievable; I am very satisfied with my progress.

No one should wait any longer. Soul-searching is required to be done urgently regarding what is one's most pronounced personal weakness. Nobody else needs to know except God, and He already knows. Begin praying for help till God accepts these prayers for reformation. The beneficiary will know because a mirror will be shown to remind one of the weakness. Shame for oneself and anger towards God will both surface; tolerate them. Reformation has begun, with God in control.

The writer is a spiritual teacher

DIALOGUE MUST PREVAIL OVER FORCE AGAINST PROTESTING YOUTH

It is painful to learn that more than a hundred people were injured at Jantar Mantar, Delhi, following a police crackdown on protesting youth. The incident raises serious questions about whether the administration adequately assessed the situation and responded to the warning signs before tensions escalated.

The call by the BJP for a march to Parliament reportedly received an immense response, with thousands of young people participating in the protest. Given the scale of mobilisation, greater engagement between the authorities and the organisers beforehand could perhaps have helped prevent the situation from deteriorating. Had the Government reached out to the organisers at an earlier stage, there might have been an opportunity to address concerns and make suitable arrangements without the need for

the use of force.

Young people raising genuine questions and expressing their anxieties deserve a patient hearing from the authorities. At the same time, protests must remain peaceful and respect the law, while the administration should exercise restraint and ensure that legitimate democratic expression is protected.

Confrontation cannot provide a lasting solution to grievances. Dialogue, deliberation and mutual respect offer a more constructive way forward. Both the authorities and protest organisers have a responsibility to prevent escalation and maintain public order. Democratic institutions are strengthened when citizens can raise their concerns peacefully and governments remain willing to listen and respond through meaningful engagement.

DVG S RAO | ANDHRA PRADESH

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Balancing dissent and national security

The recent Opposition march towards the Prime Minister's official residence, in connection with student protests and clashes, has sparked a critical debate over the boundaries of democratic dissent. While peaceful assembly is a constitutional right, targeting a high-security zone raises serious law-and-order concerns, shifting the focus from political debate to potential security risks. Troubling parallels are already being drawn with recent crises in neighbouring countries, where crowds stormed executive buildings. India's democratic system provides established institutions and mechanisms through which political and public grievances can be raised and addressed.

Whatever the grievances may be, they must be resolved through constitutional and legislative frameworks, parliamentary debates and electoral processes, rather than through confrontational street protests that risk escalating tensions. As security forces prepare to maintain order, both organisers and authorities share a significant responsibility to prevent confrontation and ensure public safety. Citizens have the right to hold leaders accountable and question government policies, but dissent must remain peaceful and within democratic boundaries to protect public order and India's democratic framework.

M PRADYU | KANNUR

Indian seafarers killed in war

The killing of four Indian seafarers in a Russian attack during the Ukraine war (22 July, p. 7) is inexcusable. The indiscriminate killing of Indian mariners in international waters amid the Russia-Ukraine and US-Iran conflicts is deeply unfortunate. Such incidents can damage diplomatic relations and strategic cooperation.

So far, neither the US, Iran nor Russia has expressed regret over such deaths caused by their attacks, nor have adequate efforts been made to rescue those affected. This raises serious concerns over the safety of commercial vessels and seafarers caught in conflict zones. The line between friends and foes is becoming increasingly blurred, putting diplomatic credibility at stake.

Maritime shipping is the backbone of global trade, responsible for transporting roughly 80 to 90 per cent of international goods by volume. In these circumstances, international laws and conventions need stronger provisions for the rescue of seafarers in cases of inadvertent attacks and compensation for the families of those killed. Greater protection and safer passage for commercial and cargo vessels in international waters must also be ensured.

VINOD JOHRI | DELHI

Building resilience in edible oils

El Niño's persistent dry spell has severely disrupted India's agricultural heartlands, driving kharif oilseed acreage down by nearly 40 per cent in vulnerable districts. Beyond affecting farmers' livelihoods, this supply shock threatens to increase India's dependence on imports and widen the country's foreign exchange bill.

Meanwhile, widespread dependence on affordable imported palmolein, which contains a high proportion of saturated fat, highlights the need for dietary moderation and greater use of indigenous oils such as mustard and groundnut oil. Encouraging locally produced alternatives could benefit both domestic agriculture and consumers. Long-term food security cannot depend primarily on imported stopgaps. India must strengthen its domestic oilseed sector by expanding micro-irrigation facilities, promoting climate-resilient seed varieties and incentivising sustainable cultivation practices. Greater investment in research, storage, processing infrastructure and farmer support can also help improve productivity and reduce vulnerability to unpredictable weather conditions.

Climate change makes agricultural resilience vital. Boosting domestic production can reduce import dependence, protect farmers and strengthen India's long-term food sovereignty.

VIJAYKUMAR H K | RAICHUR

Hydrogen trains are a green leap – but only if the hydrogen is truly green

Hydrogen trains may prove invaluable on remote, non-electrified routes where overhead power lines are impractical, but they are no substitute for renewable electricity. The real challenge lies not in building hydrogen trains, but in ensuring that the entire ecosystem powering them is as green as the technology promises



BK SINGH

India's first hydrogen-powered passenger train, flagged off by our PM a few days ago on the Jind-Sonipat route, is supposed to be marching its way towards carbon-neutral Indian Railways and eventually a carbon-neutral country by 2070. The only fuel the train engine uses is hydrogen and no other fossil fuel. Hydrogen is used to generate electricity on board that energises the movement of the train. Water vapour is the only direct emission, and there are no other by-products in the process. In other words, a hydrogen train is an electric train with its power generation on board. Clearly, the process does not require the burning of hydrogen inside the engine, and thus the possibility of accidents on account of hydrogen leakage is ruled out. Hydrogen is a highly inflammable, colourless and odourless gas. The train is equipped with leak detectors, sensors for locating flame and smoke, and an automatic shutdown facility.

Apart from passenger coaches, two hydrogen-powered driving cars, one at each end of the train, are deployed. The cylinders in the driving cars are especially designed to maintain the pressure of hydrogen at 350 Pascal or newtons per square metre. The energy generated by hydrogen at normal pressure is quite low, but under pressurised conditions, the weight goes up and a substantial amount of energy is stored in this fuel. It is necessary that hydrogen be compressed and liquefied. Strong cylinders, special pipelines and valves are an absolute necessity to handle the fuel.

Hydrogen is stored inside the engine in high-pressure cylinders. As the process begins, the hydrogen is fed to a proton exchange membrane (PEM), which can also be termed a fuel cell. Oxygen from the surrounding air is drawn into the fuel cell, which splits the hydrogen molecules into protons and electrons. The protons pass through the membrane, while electrons are guided to pass through an external circuit, generating electricity. The electricity powers the traction motor of the train and, in turn, brings it into a state of motion. The fuel cell is supported by lithium iron phosphate batteries so that the system can adjust to the requirement for excess energy and can operate steadily. At the other end of the fuel cell, protons, electrons and oxygen recombine to form water. The reaction being exothermic, heat is generated in the process. Only water vapour and heat are released, and no other greenhouse gases like carbon dioxide, etc., are released.

To understand the real carbon footprint in the process, it is necessary to examine the source of hydrogen. As we know, hydrogen is usually bonded with other elements and is also present in compounds like water, natural gas and biomass. It is obtained as a result of the electrolysis of water. The main agent that causes the electrolysis of water and splits it into oxygen and hydrogen is electricity. If the electricity is produced from renewable sources like solar, wind and nuclear sources, the hydrogen generated is known as green hydrogen. Electricity, however, is generated using fossil fuels like coal, oil and gas, and also hydroelectricity generated after sacrificing millions of trees and compromising carbon sequestration potential. If this is used for the electrolysis of water, the hydrogen so produced is not green hydrogen; it carries a lot of carbon footprint. Besides producing hydrogen, we also need to examine the process of its compression, transportation and storage. If any of these processes are completed without using renewable energy, they will also impart a carbon footprint. Further, if hydrogen is extracted from natural gas without capturing the carbon, it may leave quite a huge carbon footprint, and our journey in a hydrogen train would result in aggravating the warming of the globe.

The loss of electricity at each stage of generation, transmission and use is a well-known phenomenon. Besides, electricity theft in rural and semi-urban areas is also not uncommon. The hydrogen obtained from electrolysis after using electricity is to be reconverted into electricity in the train's engine; there are many stages in this process. The electricity is used to make hydrogen fuel, which is then compressed, stored, trans-



ported and finally converted back into electricity on the train, undergoing losses at each stage. This makes the proposition quite expensive and sufficiently inefficient.

Nevertheless, it has distinct advantages. While we lay several rail lines in remote and hilly areas, providing continuous overhead electric lines to power the train engines is uneconomical and not environmentally friendly; the easier solution is to go for hydrogen trains. Landslides in the Himalayas often disrupt the running of heritage trains for a considerable period. If train tracks are restored after disruption, they can easily be used to run hydrogen trains without waiting to restore a continuous power supply line. This would minimise the carbon footprint.

The entire broad-gauge network in the country is electrified at the cost of huge investment. As long as the power is generated from renewable sources, the existing infrastructure is enough to run electric trains without any carbon footprint. No useful purpose would be served by replacing existing electric trains with hydrogen trains. Germany, the US and China have used the technology and have been running hydrogen trains for the last few years. These countries are encountering certain technical issues, and the endeavours are still under experimentation. India has also exhibited its technological prowess in starting a hydrogen train on the Jind-Sonipat route.

A number of new rail tracks through inaccessible and hilly areas are in the pipeline in this country. Quite a few of them are at the proposal stage, and the viability of each of these is still under examination. Laying rail lines on several hilly routes is an environmental disaster, which cannot be compensated for by a hydrogen train. The inaccessible and hilly areas are generally covered with very good-quality forests, and any linear infrastructure through these forests would fragment them and compromise their potential to sequester carbon. Other ecological services like soil conservation, forested catchments from where rivulets drain into tributaries and rivers, and the control of floods and landslides are likely to be badly hit. The Institute of Social Change, Bengaluru, has published a study on the valuation of forests recently, and it concludes that Indian forests provide ecological services worth \$2.5 trillion annually, which is nearly two-thirds of our GDP.

In the warming world, the downpours are always heavy. 400 mm of rain in 48 hours can bring misery to the people. Within two years, Wayanad in Kerala has experienced another landslide, claiming several human lives and damaging properties. Heavy downpours and landslides in J&K's Poonch and other areas, as well as in Assam during the last few days, are testimony to this. Linear fragmentation of forests is detrimental to wildlife, too. There are studies concluding that the forests from the coast, through the ghat section and further up to the interior of the continent are useful in setting a convection current that can transport moisture from the ocean up to 1,000 km into the interior of the continent and can bring rain there. The impact of deforestation in one area can bring drought 1,000 km away.

The advent of hydrogen train technology and its implementation will not be able to undo the disasters in waiting. In conclusion, I recommend hydrogen trains in regions where tracks are newly constructed, but care must be taken to ensure that forests are not sacrificed in the hills for laying new train lines.

The writer is the retired Head of Forest Force, Karnataka, and teaches Economics at the Karnataka Forest Academy

Yamuna water agreement ends 32-year dispute



SHEHZAD POONAWALLA | VIJETA RATTANI

Imbalance between demand and availability. For generations, people, especially in the Shekhawati region, comprising Churu, Sikar and Jhunjhunu districts, have had to witness cracked earth and empty wells, with the worst sufferers being farmers and women. Therefore, ensuring water security and effective water management have been the key policy focal areas for the present government. Against this backdrop, the historic Yamuna Water Agreement, signed on 29 June 2026 between Rajasthan and Haryana, is not just a water-sharing agreement. It is a successful example of cooperative federalism, of partnerships built on value, in securing a historic deal on water security towards inclusive development and economic stability.

Cooperative federalism in action

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has repeatedly emphasised cooperative federalism for India's progress, where the Union and states work as partners in nation-building. Initiatives such as the Jal Jeevan Mission and the Ken-Betwa River Linking Project have already demonstrated its success in governance. The Yamuna Water Agreement is the latest and one of the most significant milestones of this approach.

Resolving water-sharing disputes is never easy, as they involve network gaps, infrastructure barriers and, moreover, competing regional aspirations. The implementation of the Yamuna Water Agreement 1994 between Rajasthan and Haryana was blocked predominantly because of such challenges.



Under PM Modi's vision, Home Minister Amit Shah played a pivotal role in fostering consensus between Rajasthan and Haryana, turning a three-decade-old impasse into a workable solution. At the heart of this success also lies the determination of Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma. Long dismissed as a "parchi CM" and questioned for his ability to deliver big outcomes by his critics, he has altered this perception by breaking a deadlock that persisted since 1994 for Rajasthan to utilise its allocated share of water. Since assuming charge as CM, he has engaged persistently on the subject with the state of Haryana and Union authorities to fast-track its implementation. The resultant successful outcome stands as a definite testament to his commitment and leadership.

Ensuring water security, transforming lives

The scale and ambition of the project are massive. At an estimated infrastructure cost of ₹34,102 crore, Rajasthan will receive nearly 580 million cubic metres (MCM) of Yamuna water from Haryana's Hathnikund Barrage through a sophisticated 295.5-kilometre underground pipeline network. Thereafter, water will be transported and stored in the Hansiyawas Reservoir in Churu district for local regional distribution. Other infrastructure would include modern water management systems, inspection roads and supporting facilities.

Implementation of the agreement will benefit lakhs of families in Rajasthan who have long been struggling with water shortages. Reliable water supply will not just address drinking water crises but provide a big boost to agricultural productivity through reliable water access, directly benefiting farmers. Additionally, it would facilitate industrial growth, groundwater recharge, new livelihood opportunities and curb distress migration due to water shortages. Women, in particular, stand to gain significantly, as cultural norms and caregiving roles have long compelled them to fetch water across long distances, often at the cost of their education, health and safety. Addressing this burden is therefore not merely about a water-related crisis but a step towards promoting inclusive development and dismantling structural inequalities. The agreement also covers financial responsibilities, cost-sharing, water allocation, monitoring and dispute-settlement mechanisms. The state leadership is also making additional efforts on groundwater recharge, reviving traditional water conservation practices and other inter-state water projects towards ensuring water security in Rajasthan.

The state of Haryana, too, is set to derive considerable benefits as a result of the agreement through enhanced regional infrastructure and drinking water provisions, especially in Bhiwani and Fatehabad districts. It exemplifies mature cooperative federalism, where both states emerge as beneficiaries.

The Yamuna Water Agreement conveys a clear message about governance, where long-stalled projects can be unlocked when long-term vision, active coordination and effective execution converge. It demonstrates the importance of partnerships built on purpose towards nation-building. For Rajasthan, this is more than a water accord. It is a crucial step towards realising the long-standing dream of Bhairon Singh Shekhawat of eradicating water scarcity in Rajasthan.

Shehzad Poonawalla, National Spokesperson, BJP
Vijeta Rattani, Sustainability and Development Professional

Punjab and J and K crisis exposes Congress's leadership paralysis



ANIL ANAND

As a Punjab watcher described the assembly poll-bound state as a "low hanging" fruit for the Congress which the party should strategize to grab the opportunity with both the hands, the mismanagement and mismatch between the thinking of the central and state leaderships and the resultant crisis has put a spanner in the Grand Old Party's (GOP's) chance to stage a come back in the strategically located state. How to manufacture a crisis afresh and how to mishandle the situation? This seems to have, since sometime back, become the USP of the Congress. And the current turmoil in Punjab, closely followed by Jammu and Kashmir, unit is a glaring example of this.

Well, severe factionalism in GOP's state and Union Territory units and repeated failure of the clueless AICC leadership to stem the rot, has a serious reflection in Punjab. It is a classic example of half a dozen chief ministerial hopefuls pulling in different directions but strategically joining hands to "challenge the authority of the high command." Instead of effectively mediating the central leadership seemed content offering peace-meal solutions and ultimately resorting to status quo. This has further aggravated the situation. In states and UTs where the Congress has

been facing such crisis, the factionalism has been allowed to foment with encouragement from the AICC quarters particularly the state/UT in-charges. The two classic examples are Punjab and adjoining J and K. The common denominator between the two is that PCC chief, Mr Amrinder Singh Warring (Punjab) and Mr Tariq Hamid Karra (J & K) being the hand-picked choice of Mr Rahul Gandhi. And there lies the problem and from where stems the argument of the central leadership's authority being under challenge. And, let Mr Gandhi take a decision, to remove such PCC chiefs, lest "we" end up antagonizing him. This is quite a fallacious argument furthered by some strategists sitting in the AICC in the name of protecting their leader. The argument stands no ground when viewed in the light of performance, on ground, of the incumbent PCC chiefs. After all, Mr Gandhi must have appointed Mr Warring and Mr Karra to strengthen the organization on which they seem to have failed. While the former has been the PCC chief for three years and the latter nearly two years.

No doubt there are other reasons behind factionalism. As reflected both in Punjab and J and K, the issue of prime concern to Mr Gandhi should be the tendency of AICC representatives including general secretary (organization) and the in-charges to ignore multiple opinions in the PCC before taking a realistic decision. Punjab and J and K have to be viewed from the prism of this horrific syndrome of perpetuating the crisis and hiding behind Mr Gandhi's name by avoiding acquainting him with ground realities. This is reflected in



the view of some senior Congress leaders that Delhi no longer sees the Punjab crisis purely through the prism of Mr Warring's performance. Instead, the larger concern is the authority of the high command itself.

Both Mr Warring and Mr Karra have badly fumbled to achieve the very objective, to rebuild party organisations in their respective domains, which Mr Gandhi must have wanted them to do. The poll-bound Punjab has assumed a greater significance since Congress has been battered by repeated electoral defeats and prolonged infighting. And snow is the chance of redemption. What is the harm if Mr Gandhi, properly informed about the ground realities by the in-charges, and the committees sent to such states and UTs from time to time to quell the factional wars, reviewed his decision? Where is the ego hassle if an incumbent is removed on grounds of failure to deliver

goods, may be due to wrong approach and style of functioning? No harm! It is in the fitness of things that to protect his nominee PCC chiefs, the set of AICC leaders do not sully his name.

The entire gamut of approach in dealing with states and UTs, particularly embroiled in crisis, needs to be drastically changed. Not always but most of the time, the AICC-appointed missions to such areas adopt a conveniently tailor-made approach rather than basing their reports on the actual ground realities. As a result, with invocation of Mr Gandhi's becoming a protective gear, the visiting committees are seen sheltering the incumbents. Wherever such committees give their findings based on the ground realities, it hardly favours the central leadership.

In the case of Punjab, a three-member committee led by AICC treasurer and an old warhorse, Mr Ajay Maken, had submitted a report resting on their interaction with a sizable section of Punjab leaders including rebels. Reports suggest that the Maken committee had clearly pointed out that an overwhelming majority opinion was in favour of replacing Mr Warring with former chief minister, Mr Charanjit Singh Channi. As the situation in Punjab stands, Mr Warring stands totally isolated and seems to be in no position to lead the divided house into 2027 assembly elections. How and why the central leadership, Mr Maken himself being among the top leaders in the party hierarchy, has ignored his panel's recommendation, and at what level, it is still not known. Whether Mr Gandhi, who has just returned from a two-week sabbatical abroad, has

seen the report or not? Intriguingly, the strong AICC coterie overlooked the Maken committee's recommendation, reflecting the majority view in the Punjab Congress. No time was lost announcing retention of Mr Warring as the PCC chief, and appointing Mr Channi and other rebel leaders as heads of other sundry committees in preparation for elections in total rejection of the recommendations.

The factional feud has reached a level of no return and the argument that the AICC's (read Mr Gandhi) authority will get eroded if Mr Warring is removed holds no good. The authority will, in fact, get strengthened if a decision is taken in line with the party's best interests. In cases such as Punjab and an equally strategic J and K, the central authority of the party should make a decisive mediation effort at the highest levels. Any delay will result in Congress losing valuable ground to the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in Punjab, and giving more strength to BJP in its stronghold of Jammu region, and the National Conference and Peoples Democratic Party in the Kashmir Valley.

Since Punjab and J and K are sailing in the same boat, the developments in the former are bound to impact Congress in the neighbouring Jammu and Kashmir. This is more so because rebel leaders Mr Channi and former deputy chief minister, Mr Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, represent Lok Sabha constituencies adjoining Jammu region, and had played an important role (though partisan) in the last assembly election in the UT.

The writer is a political analyst

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Order Order

SC rejects pleas against grant of bail to Chaitanya Baghel



The Supreme Court on Wednesday dismissed two separate pleas of the Enforcement Directorate and the Chhattisgarh Government challenging the bail granted to Chaitanya Baghel, son of former chief minister and senior Congress leader Bhupesh Baghel, in alleged liquor scam cases.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V Mohana, however, expunged the adverse remarks made by the Chhattisgarh High Court against the Economic Offence wing of the state police probe while granting bail to Baghel.

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) and the EOW wing of the police have filed separate pleas challenged the bail granted by the high court in the case and a related money laundering matter.

While the state Government alleged that Chaitanya Baghel was one of the prime accused and masterminds in the sensational case, his counsel had argued that the high court delivered a well-considered judgement in the case in which the probe was ongoing for the last two years.

On January 2, the high court granted bail to Chaitanya Baghel in two cases linked to the alleged liquor scam.

The single bench of Justice Arvind Kumar Verma allowed Chaitanya Baghel's bail pleas in a case lodged by the ED and another by the Chhattisgarh Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB)/EOW.

In its order on the bail application in the ED's case, the high court noted that the applicant's alleged role was "significantly lesser" than that of several senior accused who have already been granted bail. (PTI)

Delhi HC upholds denial of extension to Vedanta

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday upheld the Centre's decision to not extend its Production Sharing Contract with Vedanta for an offshore oil block in Gujarat and hand over the operations to Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd (ONGC).

Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav dismissed a petition by Vedanta Ltd seeking to set aside the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas's direction passed on September 19, 2025, which rejected its 2021 application to extend the Production Sharing Contract (PSC) dated June 20, 1998, for the Suvali oil block.

The petition also sought setting aside of the direction to ONGC to immediately take over the assets and operations of the petitioner under the PSC contract area.

The original term of the PSC - between the Centre, the petitioner, ONGC and Invenire Petrodyne Ltd- was for 25 years, i.e. from June 30, 1998 till June 29, 2023, and was extendable for a specified period under certain circumstances.

The petitioner was the designated operator under the PSC. After five interim extensions, the last interim extension expired on September 29, 2024. Vedanta, in June 2021, had sought an extension of 10 years, i.e. till June 29, 2033.

In the judgement, the court stated that the petitioner's act of "unilaterally deducting" the Government's share to either "neutralize its liability under the Excise Duty" or to "maintain its economic benefits" was a valid ground to refuse relief under the extension policy.

"Ex-facie the said unilateral deduction was not bona fide. The petitioner is handling public resources of the people of India. The scheme of the PSC is such as would require the private company to give the share of the Government.

This arrangement does, to a certain extent, put the private company in a dominant position as the reigns of the Government share lie in its hands. It must, however, be extra-cautious while treading this course. (PTI)

Thane court accepts woman's initial dying declarations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A sessions court in Thane has acquitted a 54-year-old man, who was accused of killing his wife by setting her on fire in 2007, holding that when multiple inconsistent dying declarations exist, the earliest declaration must be preferred.

In his order on Tuesday, Sessions Judge RD Sawant said the prosecution failed to prove the charge beyond reasonable doubt and dropped all charges against city resident Suresh Sanjiv Shetty.

The man was accused of pouring kerosene on his wife, Meena, and setting her ablaze inside their tin-shed room on March 20, 2007, after consuming liquor. Meena sustained 60 per cent burns and succumbed three days later.

Advocate Rajan Salunkhe represented Shetty.

Judge Sawant was critical of the prosecution's heavy reliance on a dying declaration recorded two days after the incident. Where multiple dying declarations exist and are inconsistent with one another, the earliest declaration, being



Quantum digital forensic science: A new pathway for new-age Indian judicial system



**DR T SENTHIL SIVA
SUBRAMANIAN**

21st century being well known for India's strong, scalable and sustainable digital era. India's digital growth showcases the strength of its frugal innovation, investments, technology, infrastructure and integration of 5th / 6th Industrial revolution technologies for emerging potential applications. India - A nation pioneering for developing holistic talented manpower through skill India digital hub is a testament for its success pathway. Digital technologies are rapidly growing in India, which could be Industrial Internet of Things (IIoT) and its allied enabling technologies like cyber security, AI, 5G and most importantly the Quantum Computing being a game changer for innovation and thereby push and boost our nation beyond the indispensable boundaries. Quantum computers which adapt the principles of quantum mechanics supersede the classical approach of computing.

India is spearheading in its digital technologies which has wide range of potential application being healthcare, smart farming, smart home automation, industrial automation and currently digital forensic which provides handheld support for India's digital judicial systems. Digital forensic is emerging in India with leaps and bounds due to its rapid awareness and adoption by wide researchers,

scholars, scientists and industry practitioners.

Digital forensic is a branch of STEALM - Science, Technology, Engineering & Entrepreneurship, Arts, Mathematics and a special emphasis on Law. Digital forensic clearly identifies, collect, preserve, analyse, interpret and carefully store and present the evidence and reports digitally that facilitate the integrity and sanctity of the forensic domain.

Quantum Era for India's Judicial systems

The launch of National Quantum Mission paves the way for new approaches and open new avenues in the field of forensic science in India.

Quantum Physics + Law = Quantum Digital Forensic Science

Quantum physics is going to revolutionize the India's judicial systems. Digital technologies for the forensic like Internet of Things (IIoT) and especially Quantum Computing can act as boosters and provide a new framework for the end users especially for the crime investigators.

The traditional cryptographic forensic methods deployed in Indian judicial systems are hash functions, digital signatures and encryptions. Digital forensic coupled with Quantum mechanics and digital computing called as Digital Quantum Forensic can form a resilience, robust and rugged digital evidence which leads to high level of confidentiality, authenticity and clear integrity to the India's digital evidence systems. Quantum entanglement and superposition principles give a new dimension to the Digital Quantum Forensic Science.



Indian judicial systems are being utilized by the traditional encryption securities as digital evidence which are vulnerable to presently emerging 5th / 6th industrial revolution technologies like super power quantum computing. The basic foundational pillars and conventional encryption securities like RSA, AES, and SHA-256 are completely driven by complex computational approaches. These securities are traditionally used in Digital Forensic science which enables digital custody, admissible for proceedings in judicial systems.

RSA is vulnerable and can be easily broken by today's Quantum computers. Meanwhile, AES and SHA-256 although they are strong but quantum algorithms can reduce their safety and securities. On the whole these securities can be easily compromised by present quantum era. The best approach is to deploy the prominent quantum cryptography technologies such as QKS and QDS which provides a rugged, robust, more resilient and digital

security for the digital forensic science.

Quantum forensic science showcase high security tamper-proof, legally accepted more powerful digital evidence and can be widely accepted by our Indian judicial law enforcement.

Quantum Digital Forensics adapts the smart quantum workflow like:

- Acquisition of digital evidence,
- Digital integrity (quantum hashing),
- Authenticity through QDS,
- Maintaining the confidentiality through QKD and Finally ends with
- Verification, validation and presenting the data to the judicial systems

India's deep-tech startup ecosystems like QNu Labs, Taqbit are pioneers in developing the Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) for real-time potential applications.

These startups are envisioned to develop Quantum Digital Public Infrastructure that can be deployed in India for various digital applications.

Quantum Forensic Science - A Viksit Pathway for Uttar Pradesh

Quantum Computing started giving a new outlook and shape for the state of Uttar Pradesh. Government of Uttar Pradesh is spearheading in capitalizing the potential of Quantum computing to apply for the digital forensic science. The state of Uttar Pradesh is marching towards *Viksit Bharat* and *Aatmanirbhar Bharat* in building Quantum Digital Forensic Public Infrastructure and thereby successfully implementing the quantum physics and advanced computational techniques for the judicial systems through the launch of Quantum Forensic Science. Quantum Forensic Science are expected to be adapted as best practices for Indian judicial systems. State of Uttar Pradesh has a strong digital infrastructure which can build its own **Quantum Forensic Data centre** that can acts as **Quantum Digital Forensic Hub** to serve for the whole nation.

Uttar Pradesh State of Forensic Science at Lucknow is enroute to build its First of-its kind - Quantum Digital Forensic Public Infrastructure that would cater to the need of India's judicial systems. State of Uttar Pradesh through Uttar Pradesh State Institute of Forensic Science will be developing unique of its kind talent pool of Quantum Digital Forensic students who can play a vital role in Indian judicial systems and set an example for the whole nation and world-wide.

The author is head of institute industry interface program Hindustan College of Science and Technology, Mathura

Nothing can shame people unfazed by Ram temple donation theft: Allahabad HC

PRESS TRSUT OF INDIA
■ Prayagraj

Taking up the issue of alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya, Justice Atul Sreedharan of the Allahabad High Court has observed that nothing can shame those who are unfazed by the development. The judge also suggested the death penalty for offences under the Prevention of Corruption Act.

Delivering strong observations on the Uttar Pradesh Government's recent bulldozer actions, Justice Sreedharan simultaneously criticised the systemic corruption plaguing Indian institutions, noting that the recent "theft" of donations at the Ram temple represents the "nadir of Indians' integrity".

Elaborating on this, he added that an average Indian has normalised corruption and no longer considers it wrong unless caught.

He further remarked that even the fact that India ranks 91 among 182 countries in the Transparency International 2025 report "does not shame



us". Referring to the "donation-theft" row, Justice Sreedharan said, "The recent controversy relating to the theft of donations at the Ram temple is the proverbial last straw on the camel's back. Nothing can shame people who remain unfazed by the theft at the Ram temple which epitomises the nadir of Indians' integrity".

Expressing concerns over how deeply corruption has been normalised in society, the judge went as far as suggesting that the State should consider amending the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, to introduce the death penalty for convicts. The scathing observations were made in Justice Sreedharan's

51-page opinion in a split verdict dealing with the issue of "bulldozer justice" and the demolition of houses belonging to accused persons under the guise of municipal code violations.

Setting the context for these demolitions, the judge said demolishing a house immediately after an offence is largely to satiate the "perceived blood lust" of a society fed on a staple diet of "bulldozer justice".

He highlighted that despite Supreme Court verdicts, the demolitions continue with impunity "as though these judgments do not exist or the State is certain that the defiance towards the law laid down by the highest court of

the land shall not visit them with any adverse consequences".

Furthermore, while examining how unauthorised structures come into existence in the first place, Justice Sreedharan noted that no dwelling place comes up overnight.

"The authorities who have the duty to ensure that such structures do not come up close their eyes deliberately on account of political or bureaucratic support that the builder has, or out of dishonesty," he said.

The court further observed that the creation of non-compliant houses is facilitated by dishonest officials who take bribes from builders and leave the ultimate buyer to suffer the enforcement of the law and face sudden eviction decades later.

In this context, Justice Sreedharan categorically remarked that the State is particeps criminis (an accomplice) for actively assisting violators through connivance and by providing sovereign amenities like water and electricity to these structures.

SCBA seeks probe into police action on students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA) on Wednesday condemned the police action on students and lawyers, and called for an impartial and time-bound inquiry into the incident. The SCBA headed by its president and senior advocate Vikas Singh, in its resolution, said the police action left several students and members of the legal fraternity, including members of the Association, injured.

"The use of excessive and disproportionate force against peaceful students and members of the Bar is deeply disturbing and wholly unacceptable in a democratic society," the resolution issued by SCBA secretary Pragya Baghel said.

The bar body urged authorities concerned to conduct an immediate, impartial and time-bound inquiry into the incident, identify those responsible for the alleged excessive use of force, and initiate appropriate action in accordance



with law. It also called on the authorities to ensure proper medical treatment and assistance for all injured students and members of the legal fraternity, while taking necessary steps to prevent the recurrence of such incidents. "The Association stands in solidarity with all those injured and reiterates its commitment to protecting constitutional rights, human dignity and the rule of law," it said. On Monday, thousands of students, demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET paper leak issue and irregularities in the exam system, attempted to march to Parliament but were pushed back with teargas and batons.

Chhattisgarh court orders probe against ex-Indian cricketer Rajesh Chauhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Durg

A court in Chhattisgarh's Durg district has directed the police to investigate former India cricketer Rajesh Chauhan over allegations that he duped a man of more than ₹15 lakh on the pretext of offering him a transport contract with a steel company.

Judicial Magistrate First Class Aishwarya Diwan, in an order passed on July 16, allowed an application filed

by complainant Dinkar Vishwamitra under Section 175 (3) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) and directed Mohan Nagar police to conduct a lawful investigation and submit a final report before the court.

According to the application, Chauhan introduced himself to Vishwamitra as a former international cricketer with close links to some leading industrialists and claimed that his firm, Govind Transport Company, had



secured a contract from Jindal Steel Limited in Odisha's Keonjhar district for transportation of iron ore and lumps.

The complainant alleged that Chauhan promised substantial profits and persuaded him to invest in the transport business by deploying

trucks as a partner.

To support his claims, Chauhan allegedly showed him work order documents purportedly issued in favour of Govind Transport Company by Jindal Steel Limited, the application said.

Believing the documents to be genuine, Vishwamitra entered an agreement with Chauhan on July 30, 2021, and paid ₹2.51 lakh through a cheque.

He subsequently transferred ₹15.01 lakh in two instalments to Govind

Transport Company's bank account for the proposed transport business, the application said.

The application alleged that after Chauhan stopped responding satisfactorily, Vishwamitra approached Jindal Steel Limited and learnt that neither Chauhan nor Govind Transport Company had ever been awarded any transport contract. It further claimed that the work order shown to him was forged and fabricated.

SC to hear Shiv Sena (UBT) plea against merger

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday sought responses from the office of the Lok Sabha Speaker and others on a plea filed by the Shiv Sena (UBT) challenging the Speaker's approval to the merger of its six MPs with the Shiv Sena led by Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe, which agreed to hear the plea filed by Shiv Sena (UBT)



leader Arvind Ganpat Sawant, refused to grant interim relief as of now.

"Issue notice," the bench said and posted the matter for hearing after two weeks. Ahead of the Monsoon

session, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on July 18 approved the merger of six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs with the Shiv Sena led by Shinde.

Official sources had said that with the merger of the six MPs, the strength of the Shiv Sena has gone up to 13.

During the hearing on Wednesday, senior advocate Devadatt Kamat, appearing for the Shiv Sena (UBT) leader, told the bench that the plea raises important questions concerning constitutional morality and propriety and the issue goes

to the heart of parliamentary democracy.

"No disqualification proceedings are pending," Kamat said, adding that the question of deciding on merger has not even arisen.

He said the circular issued on July 18 was signed by some joint secretary.

"We don't even know whether the Speaker has passed an order, not passed an order," Kamat said.

He argued that the whole thing was orchestrated only for the purpose of Parliament session.

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BPCL slips into red in Q1 on holding fuel prices

Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) on Wednesday reported a net loss of ₹3,962.13 crore in the June quarter on keeping petrol, diesel and LPG prices way below cost that had soared due to the West Asia crisis.

The net loss of ₹3,962.13 crore in April-June - the first quarter of current 2026-27 fiscal year - compared with a profit of ₹3,333.97 crore in the same period a year back, according to a stock exchange filing by the company.

BPCL and other state-owned fuel retailers - Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) - held petrol and diesel prices steady for two-and-half-months despite a more than 50 per cent surge in prices of crude oil - the raw material for making petrol and diesel - after the US and Israel attacked Iran on February 28 and Tehran retaliated.

And when these companies increased prices by over ₹7.50 a litre in the second half of May, it wasn't enough to cover for the cost. The cooking gas price increase of ₹89 per 14.2-kg cylinder too was a fifth of the required hike.

(PTI)

Eternal Q1 net profit jumps nearly four-fold to ₹92 crore

Eternal Ltd, which runs businesses including Zomato and Blinkit, on Wednesday reported a nearly four-fold jump in consolidated net profit at ₹92 crore in the first quarter ended June 30, on the back of strong revenue growth of its quick commerce vertical.

The company had posted a consolidated net profit of ₹25 crore in the corresponding quarter last fiscal, Eternal Ltd said in a regulatory filing.

Consolidated revenue from operations in the first quarter of FY27 stood at ₹20,211 crore as compared to ₹7,167 crore in the year-ago period, it added.

Total expenses in the reporting quarter were higher at ₹20,314 crore as compared to ₹7,433 crore in the year-ago period, the company said.

Food delivery business Zomato net order value (NOV) growth reached over 20 per cent YoY at ₹10,769 crore, after four consecutive quarters of acceleration, company CFO Akshant Goyal said.

Quick commerce Blinkit NOV grew 86 per cent YoY to ₹17,132 crore, while going-out, 'District' NOV growth accelerated to 60 per cent YoY to ₹3,218 crore, he added.

(PTI)

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | JULY 23, 2026

US bid of steep tariff on generic medicines could impact India: GTRI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The proposed steep tariffs announced by the US on generic medicines could significantly affect India's largest pharmaceutical export market, economic think tank GTRI said on Wednesday.

However, it said that the impact is unlikely to be uniform. "Many Indian generic medicines sell for seven to ten times less than branded alternatives. Even after a 100 per cent tariff, many products could remain cheaper than branded medicines, meaning much of the additional cost would likely be passed on to US health-care providers, insurers and patients rather than immediately eliminating Indian exports," it said.

It added that the greatest pressure is expected to fall on higher-value generic formulations and branded generics, where manufacturing in the United States could become commercially viable.

"The proposed tariffs could significantly affect India's largest pharmaceutical export market," Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) founder Ajay Srivastava said, adding that India should also reduce its dependence on the US market by expanding

exports to Europe, Latin America, Africa and Asia.

GENERIC MEDICINES: They are off-patent medicines that contain the same active ingredient, strength, dosage form, and therapeutic effect as the original branded medicine, but are sold under their generic name or another brand name, usually at a lower price.

TRUMP'S ANNOUNCEMENT: In a post on Truth Social, US President Donald Trump said beginning August 1, America will continue to have a zero per cent tariff or import duty on all generic drugs brought into the country for two years, after which it will be raised to 100 per cent for one year, and 200 per cent thereafter.

"This is done to RESHORE Generic Pharmaceutical Production into America, with a penalty to those Companies

that decide not to build Plant and Equipment within the stated period of time given to them," Trump said.

USA'S PHARMA TARIFF STRATEGY: The latest announcement completes Trump's effort to cover almost every segment of pharmaceutical imports. On Apr 2, 2026, the administration formally announced tariffs of up to 100 per cent on specified branded medicines and key pharmaceutical ingredients under the Section 232 national security framework, while excluding generic medicines.

The July 21 announcement now brings generic drugs into the proposed tariff regime, leaving virtually no major pharmaceutical category outside Trump's reshoring strategy.

US GENERIC MARKET: The US imported \$213 billion worth of pharma products in 2025,

including \$94.1 billion of finished medicines sold in retail packs, the category that includes generic medicines.

According to the GTRI, estimating the value of generic medicine imports is not straightforward because US customs data do not identify generics separately. Instead, they are classified under HS (Harmonised System) 3004, which also includes patented medicines, branded generics, and over-the-counter drugs.

As a result, estimates rely on industry data rather than customs statistics.

INDIA'S PHARMA EXPORTS: India has the most at stake among generic drug exporters. It exported \$25.8 billion in 2025, of which \$9.7 billion, or 37.7 per cent, went to the US, making America India's largest pharmaceutical export market.

Indian companies supply 47 per cent of all generic prescriptions dispensed in the US, making India the country's largest source of affordable generic medicines. However, because generics are sold at low prices, India's share of the value of US generic imports is estimated at only 30 per cent, well below its share of prescriptions, Srivastava said.

Pharma stocks fall; Aurobindo Pharma down over 4%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Pharma stocks declined on Wednesday, with Aurobindo Pharma tumbling over 4 per cent, after US President Donald Trump announced steep tariffs on imported generic medicines from August 2028, asserting that the move was aimed at onshoring the manufacturing of such pharmaceutical products.

The move could affect India, which is the largest exporter of generic drugs to the US. Shares of Aurobindo Pharma tanked 4.13 per cent, Glenmark Pharma edged lower by 3.26 per cent, Biocon went down by 3.18 per cent, Cipla slipped 2.54 per cent, Sun Pharma dropped 1.91 per cent, Dr Reddys Lab declined 1.86 per cent and Torrent Pharma dipped 1.38 per cent on the BSE.

In a post on Truth Social, Trump said beginning August 1, the US will continue to have a zero per cent tariff on all generic drugs brought into the country for two years, after which it will be raised to 100 per cent for one year, and 200 per cent thereafter.

"Effective August 1st, 2026, all Generic Drugs being brought into the United States will continue to have a TARIFF of ZERO

PERCENT for two years, after which the TARIFF will be raised to 100 per cent for one year, and 200 per cent thereafter," Trump said.

"This is done in order to RESHORE Generic Pharmaceutical Production into America, with a penalty to those Companies that decide not to build Plant and Equipment within the stated period of time given to them," Trump said.

The president said the objective of this policy is to protect the people of the United States.

"Renewed concerns over potential US tariffs on generic pharmaceutical imports weighed on investor sentiment. The pharmaceutical sector led the decline, falling nearly 2 per cent in early trade," Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, said.

Bullion capped by inflation concerns: Analysts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Gold and silver prices are expected to remain under pressure in the short term as central banks maintain a hawkish posture and delay interest rate cuts in response to heightened crude oil prices, analysts said.

While crude oil-driven inflation traditionally boosts precious metals, analysts warn that hawkish monetary policy responses could cap near-term gains for bullion.

According to experts, the bullion market's reaction to oil price shocks now depends less on inflation figures alone and more on how central banks respond. "Historically, sharp rallies in crude oil prices have triggered inflationary pressures, as witnessed during the 1970s oil embargo and several Middle East crises," said Manav Modi, Commodities Analyst at Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd (MOFSL).

Usually, gold and silver see a strong upward momentum during inflationary pressures triggered by a spike in crude prices. However, gold and silver have defied established market trends during

the recent escalation in the US-Iran conflict, which has threatened nearly a fifth of the world's energy supplies moving through the Strait of Hormuz. The fresh escalation in the Middle East has led to sharp volatility across commodity markets since last week. Brent crude was trading near \$68 a barrel before the conflict in West Asia in late February and surged to as high as \$126.41 per barrel by mid-April amid the peak hostilities.

Later, oil prices retreated to around \$70 after tensions eased between the US, Israel and Iran, before climbing back to about \$90 a barrel. The sharp swings in energy markets coincided

with a steep correction in precious metals. Gold futures, after scaling a record \$5,706 an ounce earlier this year, have fallen about 29 per cent to around \$4,070 an ounce.

Silver futures have declined more than 52 per cent from their all-time high of \$124.25 an ounce hit on January 29. The white metal is currently hovering around \$59 an ounce globally.

Rather than sparking a runaway precious metals rally, the recent oil supply disruptions have instead raised expectations that central banks across major economies will keep monetary policy tighter for longer, effectively capping bullion's short-term gains.

India's edible oil import bill may rise 9% in 2025-26: SEA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's edible oil import bill is estimated to rise 9 per cent to ₹1.75 lakh crore during the current marketing year ending October on higher volumes and rupee depreciation, according to industry body SEA. In a letter to the members, Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA) President Sanjeev Asthana expressed concern over rising import bills and said the oilseed revolution could no longer wait.

"India stands at a defining moment in its edible oil journey, and the warning signs are becoming increasingly difficult to ignore. The country's edible oil import bill, which stood at ₹1.61 lakh crore last year, is now projected to cross an unprecedented ₹1.75 lakh crore this year," he said. Earlier this month, SEA has reported that India's edible oil import rose 7 per cent to 103.88 lakh tonnes during November 2025-June 2026 period from 97.29 lakh tonnes in the corresponding period of the previous oil

year. The edible oil marketing year runs from November to October.

In the first eight months of the current oil year, Asthana said the import bill stood at ₹1.19 lakh crore as against ₹99,000 crore in the year-ago period. "This is not merely another statistic; it represents a substantial outflow of precious foreign exchange that could otherwise be channelled into strengthening India's agricultural infrastructure," he observed.

Asthana pointed out that a weaker rupee has made imports costlier. "At the same time, weather uncertainties, including below-normal monsoon forecasts and

delayed sowing in several oilseed-growing regions, are raising concerns over domestic production," he added.

The SEA President said the global developments are adding further pressure.

"Indonesia's expanding biodiesel programme is diverting larger quantities of palm oil from food to fuel, tightening global supplies, while geopolitical uncertainties and higher freight and insurance costs continue to keep international edible oil prices volatile. The net effect is that India may be compelled to import more, and pay considerably more for every tonne," he said.

Markets decline for 3rd day on higher oil prices

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty tumbled nearly 1 per cent on Wednesday, taking the losses to the third consecutive day, following a sharp spike in crude oil prices and selling in bank stocks.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 715.06 points, or 0.92 per cent, to settle at 76,755.05. During the day, it slumped 828.92 points, or 1 per cent, to 76,641.19.

The 50-share NSE Nifty declined 191.45 points, or 0.79 per cent, to end at 23,996.25.

From the Sensex pack, InterGlobe Aviation, Infosys, State Bank of India, UltraTech Cement, ICICI Bank, and

Top Losers		Top Gainers	
IndiGo	-3.57	Hind Unilever	0.75
Infosys	-1.97	NTPC	0.59
SBI	-1.81	Power Grid	0.58
UltraTech Cement	-1.80	Titan	0.38
ICICI	-1.50	Bharti Airtel	0.08

Axis Bank were among the major laggards. Hindustan Unilever, NTPC, Power Grid, and Titan were among the winners.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 4.68 per cent to \$95.27 per barrel.

"Indian equities closed lower as a sharp rise in crude oil prices and persistent geopolitical tensions in the Middle East kept investors firmly in risk-off mode.

The benchmark indices faced sustained selling pressure throughout the session, with broad-based declines across most sectors overshadowing an otherwise encouraging start to the first-quarter earnings season," Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth

tech firm.

Investor attention remained firmly on the macro backdrop as higher crude oil prices and renewed concerns over potential US tariffs on pharmaceutical imports weighed on sentiment, he added.

In Asian markets, South Korea's KOSPI and Shanghai's SSE Composite index ended higher, while Japan's Nikkei 225 index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index settled lower.

Markets in Europe were trading higher. US markets ended higher on Tuesday.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) turned buyers on Tuesday. They bought equities worth ₹1,650.16 crore in the previous trade, according to exchange data.

Rupee closes at 96.59 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee depreciated by 34 paise to close at 96.59 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday, weighed down by surging crude oil prices and heightened geopolitical uncertainty. Forex traders said risk aversion in global markets and a negative trend in domestic equities further dented investor sentiments.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 96.36 against the US dollar and traded in the range of 96.25 to 96.57 during the day. The domestic unit finally

Date	Rate (₹/USD)
Jul 15	96.25
Jul 16	96.42
Jul 17	96.30
Jul 18	96.36
Jul 19	96.36
Jul 20	96.25
Jul 21	96.25
Jul 22	96.59

settled at 96.59 (provisional), lower by 34 paise from its previous close. On Tuesday, the rupee had settled higher by 11 paise at 96.25 against the American currency.

"Following a brief rally on Tuesday, the Indian rupee

faces downward pressure amid surging crude oil prices and heightened geopolitical uncertainty," said Dilip Parmar - Senior Research Analyst, HDFC Securities.

According to Parmar, renewed concerns over US tariff rhetoric have further dampened sentiment. Spot SINR remains on a bullish track, with near-term support pegged at 96.10 and a retest of the record high around 97 on the horizon, he said.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading lower by 0.07 per cent at 101.10.

Launch cost cuts, space-grade manufacturing key as India eyes space ambitions: DoT official

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lowering launch costs through high-payload capabilities, indigenous production of critical space-grade components, and unlocking the downstream satellite data economy will be crucial for India to emerge as the world's third-largest space economy, a senior DoT official said on Wednesday.

Department of Telecom, Member (Services), Deb Kumar Chakrabarti emphasised the need for structural reforms, policy changes and greater innovation in the space segment as India moves ahead on its global ambitions in the sector. Citing a slew of government initiatives that have made

the space sector attractive for companies, he said a proposed PLI with a corpus of around ₹600 crores "is coming up very soon".

On the policy front, the official urged comprehensive regulatory reforms, including strengthening the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPaCe) into a full-fledged regulator with enforcement powers.

India is currently among leading spacefaring nations, placed at sixth position in space segment economy behind established players such as the US, China, UK, and France, and is aiming to become the world's third-largest space economy in the coming years, he said,

addressing IAFI's Space Policy Conference 2026. "...becoming the number three country in the space economy in the world... requires many structural changes and adjustments in different policies and regulations," he said. The total space economy in India is \$ 8.4 billion, with a goal of reaching

\$44 billion by 2033. "...and the rank of the country will rise from number six to number three. I think it's a huge jump that we have planned in future," Chakrabarti added.

It is pertinent to mention here that Skyroot Aerospace's Vikram-1 became India's first privately

developed rocket to successfully reach orbit, marking a historic milestone for the country's private space sector and commercial launch capabilities.

Outlining key priorities for the country, the DoT official noted that India has built a strong reputation in cost-efficiency and reliability in space tech, where startups like Skyroot and Agnikul are setting new benchmarks in lowering costs per kilogram in payloads.

Chakrabarti further said that the country must now move beyond small-payload launches and develop capabilities for high-payload launches to reduce costs further and remain globally competitive. Citing SpaceX's Falcon as an example, he said higher

payload capacity dramatically lowers per-kilogram launch costs.

"One of the sectors where India must concentrate and look into is the high payload sector and the per kg cost of launch to be reduced.

The number two point is the material dependencies," he said, identifying import of space-grade materials as another major challenge that needs to be looked at. India still relies on imports for critical inputs such as space-grade carbon fibre, radiation-hardened semiconductors and minerals including lithium, cobalt and titanium, making the sector vulnerable to supply chain disruptions and mission delays, he pointed out. "For example, the space-grade

carbon fibre...We do not make the semiconductors and the cosmic radiation-proof semiconductors. We do not make the critical minerals which are dependent on lithium, cobalt, and titanium...mostly we depend on China. As you depend on another country, there is a risk in the supply chain," he said.

The DoT official also drew attention to the monetisation structure.

Chakrabarti called for greater focus on the downstream space economy, noting that nearly 70 per cent of global space revenues come from applications such as satellite data, geospatial analytics and earth observation, compared to about 30 per cent from upstream activities like launch vehicles and satellite manufacturing.

FROM THE WORLD

USA

Can't arrest bibi: Mamdani

New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani said that the city would not be able to execute an arrest warrant issued by the world's top war-crimes court for Israel's Benjamin Netanyahu(BIBI), but urged the federal Government to do so. In the video Mamdani described the Israeli prime minister as a "war criminal" and said he is not welcome in New York City. "It is clear that we do not have the independent legal authority to enforce this warrant," he said in a video posted on X. "The federal Government however does and I call on them to join the ICC and execute this warrant," he added, referring to the International Criminal Court. Mamdani had told earlier that he and the city's legal department were discussing arresting Netanyahu if he comes to New York City for the UN General Assembly in September. (AP)

USA

US sends food for Cuba

A Cuba-bound cargo plane carrying food and hygiene kits left Miami on Tuesday under US efforts to give direct assistance to the island's residents while continuing to pressure their Government. The flight carrying 700 packages is meant to bypass the Cuban Government, with the items distributed directly to the Cuban people by Catholic groups in Cuba, according to the US State Department. Tuesday's shipment is a \$60 million first tranche of a total of \$100 million the US offered to Cuba some time ago. It comes after months of intensified US pressure on the Cuban Government and that has focused mainly on imposing significant sanctions against the country's military and intelligence apparatus. (AP)

US will destroy a bridge for each Iranian attack: Trump

JON GAMBRELL/ COLLIN BINKLEY ■ Dubai

US President Donald Trump has warned Iran that America will destroy one bridge or power plant each time Iran shoots at a ship in the Strait of Hormuz. The warning came after the US carried out another wave of strikes on Iran, where air defences opened fire over the Capital, Tehran. Iran launched a missile attack on a Jordanian city on Israel's doorstep, and alerts were issued in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia. In his warning on social media, the president returned to earlier threats to target civilian infrastructure in retaliation for Iranian

attacks. "From this point forward, any time the Islamic Republic of Iran shoots at a ship in the Strait of Hormuz, whether it be by Missile, Rocket, Drone, or any other device or weapon, the United States will bomb and destroy ONE BRIDGE OR POWER PLANT," Trump wrote on social media. The 11th night of American airstrikes on Iran came as diplomatic efforts have shown little public sign of progress. Officials on both sides have dug in on their dispute over the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial waterway for global energy that remains largely closed because of Iranian attacks. Iran has avoided striking Israel since hostilities resumed last month, apparently hoping to keep it from reentering the war. But the missile and drone attack on Jordan's city of Aqaba, within sight of Israel's Eilat, raised concerns over a further widening of the conflict after an agreement to halt hostilities collapsed. The closure of the strait, through which a fifth of the world's traded oil and gas passed during peacetime, has jolted the world economy with effects far beyond the West Asia. A new threat by Iran-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen to target Saudi shipping in the Red Sea puts another trade chokepoint at risk. Benchmark Brent crude oil rose to around \$94 a barrel in trading, and gasoline

prices are once again climbing ahead of US midterm elections this fall. Jordan's military said it intercepted four Iranian missiles over Aqaba, while two others fell in "uninhabited areas". Plumes of smoke could be seen overhead in videos filmed by people in the nearby Israeli city of Eilat. Jordan said it also intercepted four Iranian drones. Another missile alert



prices are once again climbing ahead of US midterm elections this fall. Jordan's military said it intercepted four Iranian missiles over Aqaba, while two others fell in "uninhabited areas". Plumes of smoke could be seen overhead in videos filmed by people in the nearby Israeli city of Eilat. Jordan said it also intercepted four Iranian drones. Another missile alert

sounded in Bahrain, and Saudi Arabia warned residents of the Persian Gulf city of Dammam to seek shelter. Saudi authorities later said the danger had passed, without elaborating. The US military said earlier Wednesday that it had completed an 11th night of strikes on Iran, with targets including aircraft hangars and drone storage sites. Iran's state-run IRNA news agency reported explosions across several provinces. Iran's Health Ministry says US strikes over the past 11 days have killed 53 people, including six women and three children, and wounded nearly 600 people. Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard insisted

its retaliatory attacks would continue. Before the latest strikes, Iranian Interior Minister Eskandar Momeni visited Pakistan, a key mediator in the conflict, seeking to revive diplomacy. But it was unclear what new arrangement might be reached to end the war, which lately has become a battle for control over the Strait of Hormuz. Iran's Interior Ministry spokesman Ali Zeinivand said "diplomacy isn't called off" and that messages were still being exchanged, without elaborating, according to IRNA. At a regional summit in the Philippines, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio denounced Iran's actions in the strait. (AP)

Bulgaria allows US air base use for West Asia support

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Sofia

Bulgaria's Parliament on Wednesday backed a Government proposal to allow the US military to use an air base in the Balkan country to support US operations in the West Asia, while some expressed concern about becoming involved in the Iran war. The Trump administration has faced pushback from certain other countries in the European Union over the use of air bases in support of its war with Iran. Legislators in Bulgaria voted 136-13, with two abstentions, to allow up to eight US KC-135 refuelling aircraft along with 250 personnel and supporting equipment at Bezmer Air Base from



Friday to Oct 1. No further approvals are needed. Under a 2006 US-Bulgaria defence agreement, the Bezmer facility, about 260 kilometres (160 miles) southeast of the capital, Sofia, is a joint-use facility. Any time the US wants to use the base for a new reason, it requires Parliament approval. The new military deployment comes after a request by the US Embassy. There was no immediate US comment Wednesday. Ahead of the vote, Prime Minister Rumen Radev declared that it was "categorically out of the question for military operations in the

West Asia to be conducted from Bulgarian territory." TV footage showed Radev telling a Government meeting that "the deployment of US tanker aircraft at Bezmer Air Base is solely for logistical missions involving in-flight refuelling outside Bulgarian airspace." Defence Minister Dimitar Stoyanov told legislators ahead of the vote that all necessary measures had been taken, both nationally and within the allied framework, to ensure that Bulgaria would not become involved in any conflict. "We requested and received guarantees from our strategic partner aimed at minimising the risks to our national security," Stoyanov said.

Rubio backs ASEAN, warns Iran tolls threaten global economy

MICHELLE L PRICE/ JIM GOMEZ ■ Manila

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio warned Asian leaders Wednesday that Iran's demand to control and collect tolls in the Strait of Hormuz would threaten the world's economy and set a precedent that could be repeated elsewhere in the world. Rubio spoke at the start of an annual meeting in the Philippine Capital, Manila, with counterparts from the Association of Southeast Asian Nations who have expressed alarm over the resurgent war in the West Asia that has battered their region. Despite Washington's preoccupation with the war, Rubio said "we're with ASEAN 100 per cent." "If we create a precedent in the Middle



East where a nation state can decide that they are going to control an international waterway, charge a toll and if you don't pay them, blow up your ships, we have created a very dangerous precedent which will repeat itself in other parts of the world, including in this region," he said. (A)

Pak: 31 killed in rain-related incidents

M ZULQARNAIN ■ Lahore/Peshawar

At least 31 people were killed and over 120 injured in separate rain-related incidents across Pakistan's Punjab and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa provinces over the past week, officials said on Wednesday. These regions have witnessed intense monsoon activity this month, with heavy rains triggering flash floods, roof and wall collapses, and electrocution incidents. At least 17 people, including children, were killed in rain-related incidents across Punjab since the latest monsoon spell began earlier this week, according to the Disaster Management Authority . (PTI)

Jaishankar calls for deeper India-ASEAN cooperation amid global turbulence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Manila

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Wednesday stressed the need for stronger cooperation between India and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), saying the current global environment is marked by unprecedented uncertainty and no country or regional grouping can address emerging challenges alone. Speaking at the ASEAN Post-Ministerial Conference with India 2026 in Manila, Jaishankar said the conference theme, "Navigating Our Future Together," reflects the shared responsibility of India and ASEAN in shaping a stable and resilient future.

"The world is extremely turbulent, and it is increasingly evident that no single nation or even grouping can deal with it on its own," Jaishankar said during his opening remarks. The External Affairs Minister, who is on a two-day visit to the Philippines, is attending meetings under the ASEAN framework as well as the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting. He also acknowledged the Philippines' role as the country's coordinator in strengthening the India-ASEAN Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. Highlighting key global challenges, Jaishankar said supply chains remain under significant stress due to ongoing geopolitical volatility and disruptions. He noted that energy, food, and health security can no longer be taken for granted, while maritime trade faces



Union Minister S Jaishankar exchanges a handshake with Canada's Minister of Foreign Affairs Anita Anand, in Manila, Philippines PTI

increasing risks. "Because we are all so dependent on maritime trade, that too could become a source of anxiety. Observing international law in that regard is therefore vital," he said. Jaishankar also noted that 2026 has been designated as the ASEAN-India Year of Maritime Cooperation, calling it an opportunity to strengthen collaboration in ensuring a secure and stable Indo-Pacific. Emphasising the growing scope of bilateral engagement, Jaishankar said the India-ASEAN partnership now spans multiple sectors, including trade and investment, mobility and talent, technology, digital transformation, artificial intelligence, sustainability, green initiatives, and regional connectivity. "It is only through deeper cooperation that we can de-risk and diversify," he said. The minister added that India and ASEAN have traditionally worked together to promote peace, stability, and prosperity across the

wider region. "This is a world in transition, and India and ASEAN, who account for nearly two billion people, must navigate it together if it is to remain safe and steady," he said. ASEAN, one of the region's most influential multilateral organisations, counts India among its dialogue partners alongside countries such as the United States, China, Japan, and Australia. During his visit, Jaishankar will also participate in the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting with counterparts from Australia, Japan, and the United States. The Quad foreign ministers last met in New Delhi in May, when US Secretary of State Marco Rubio visited India. India's engagements with both ASEAN and the Quad underscore its continued focus on strengthening regional partnerships, enhancing economic resilience, and promoting a rules-based Indo-Pacific amid evolving global challenges.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Pranali Ravinder Sakhare, D/O Ravinder Sakhare, R/O B-84 Vikas Vihar, Vikas Nagar, Near Punjab National Bank, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi - 110059, have changed my name to Jiya Ravinder Sakhare for all future purposes and documents. **PD(260)C I, Sazia, D/o JC-472535X** Sub Jan Mohammad, R/o- Vill & PO- Kurli, Teh & Dist- Bulandshahr, U.P- 203408, have changed my name from Sazia to Saziya Saifi, vide affidavit dated 22/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(262)C I, No.4290234L Sep Ritesh Kumar Singh, R/o- Vill & PO- Masar, P.S- Udwant Nagar, Dist- Bhojpur, Bihar- 802162 have changed my Daughter's name from Riya Kumari to Piya Kumari, vide affidavit dated 22/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. **PD(263)C I, Babali, Mother of** No.17020319A Hav Pushpendra Singh, R/o- Vill- Bahadurpur, PO- Karab, Dist- Mathura, U.P.- 281204, have changed my name from Babali to Babi, vide affidavit dated 22/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(264)C I, hitherto known as Sayyad Mohaboob Basha S/o Syed Hussain Peera, Permanent Address- 6-1-425/1, Siva Nagar, Gopavaram Mandalam, Badvel Municipality, Badvel, Cuddapah, Andhra Pradesh- 516227, Present Address- Qtr No P-86/23, Naraina Vihar, Delhi Cantt-10 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Syed Mahaboob Basha. **PD(265)C**

PD(266)C I, Prabhathi Ghosh, Mother of- No.14869257N Sep/MT Abhijit Ghosh, R/o- Vill & PO- Bahara, P.S- Kandi, Dist- Murshidabad, West Bengal- 742138 have changed my name from Sahadev Ghosh to Prabhathi Ghosh, vide affidavit dated 25/05/2026 before Executive Magistrate, Murshidabad. **PD(267)C I, Namdeo, Father of** No.15582177M Nk Bhume Anil Namdev, R/o- Vill- Adgoan, PO- Nidhona, Teh- Phulmbri, Dist- Aurangabad, Maharashtra- 431151, have changed my name from Namdeo to Namdev Shenpude Bhume, Vide Affidavit Dated 22/07/2026 Before Notary Public Delhi. **PD(268)C I, Parvatabai, Mother of** No.15582177M Nk Bhume Anil Namdev, R/o- Vill- Adgoan, PO- Nidhona, Teh- Phulmbri, Dist- Aurangabad, Maharashtra- 431151, have changed my name from Parvatabai to Parvatibai Namdev Bhume, Vide Affidavit Dated 22/07/2026 Before Notary Public Delhi. **PD(269)C**

National Highways Authority of India
(Ministry of Road Transport & Highways, Govt. of India)

PUBLIC NOTICE
National Highway-148 NA New User Fee Applicable on Delhi Vadodara Expressway
PUBLIC NOTICE ON NEW USER FEE (TOLL) RATES AT TOLL KIRANJ (KM. 55-880) NH-148 APPLICABLE FROM 23.07.2026

The public are hereby informed that pursuant to the approval of new user fee rates from Competent Authority, NHAI vide e-office, the user fee rates will be effective from 23.07.2026 at Construction of six-lane Access Controlled Highway from Jaitpur-Pushta Road to Junction near KMP Expressway with: NE-4 (Delhi Vadodara Expressway) -Design Ch. 9.000 to Ch. 59+063 in the states of Delhi & Haryana on Hybrid Annuity Mode under Bharatmala Pariyojana (Package II-III)-NH-148NA. The Revised user fee rates for Kiranj Toll Plaza at Km 55+880 w.e.f., 00:00 Hrs of 23.07.2026 are as under:

NEW USER FEE RATE OF KIRANJ TOLL PLAZA (KM. 55+880)

Category of Vehicles/ Applicable fee for completed length of 50.063 Km. (Km.9+000 to 59+063)	Fee for single Journey (Rs.)	Fee for Return Journey within a day (Rs.)	Fee for Monthly Pass Valid for 50 Journeys	Fee for commercial vehicles registered within the district (Rs.)
Car/JEEP/Van/Light Motor Vehicle	160	240	5340	80
LCV/LGV/Mini Bus	260	390	8630	130
Bus/Truck (Two Axles)	540	815	18080	270
Three Axle Commercial Vehicles	590	885	19720	295
Heavy construction Machinery (HCM) or Earth Moving Equipment (EME) of Multi Axle Vehicle (MAV) (4 to 6 Axles)	850	1275	28350	425
Oversized Vehicles (Seven or More Axles)	1035	1555	34515	520

Note: Rate of monthly pass for a person who owns a mechanical vehicle registered for non-commercial purpose and resides within a distance of twenty kilometres from the fee plaza is Rs. 360.00 (Rupees Three Hundred Sixty Only) for the Year 2026-27.

1. Name and address are as under, for any enquiry and/or giving complaint suggestions:-

Toll Agency	Concessionaire	IE	PD of NHAI
Mr. Vinod Yadav	Mr. Hemanth Pathak	Mr. Deepip Singh	Mr. Dhiraj Singh
M/s M/s Skylark	M/s Dineshchandra Vaishnodevi Infra Pvt Ltd. & M/s Dineshchandra Giriraj Infra Pvt Ltd, Kiran Toll Plaza, Haryana	M/s Intercontinental Consultants and Technocrats Pvt. Ltd.	National Highways Authority of India, CMU- Mathura, Plot no. 08, Near Toll Plaza Building, Faridabad Haryana-121003
Mobile, no. 9982429292	9582583896	8529745524	8130006117

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E mail : cs@ramapaper.com

Extract of Audited Financial Results For the Financial Year and Quarter ended on 31st March 2026

(Rupees In Lakhs)						
S.NO	PARTICULARS	Quarter ending on 31-03-2026	Quarter ending on 31-12-2025	Quarter ending on 31-03-2025	Year ending on 31-03-2026	Year ending on 31-03-2025
	(Refer Notes Below)	(Audited)	(Unaudited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)
1	Total income from operations (Net)	-	3.61	2.33	125.86	665.13
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(140.92)	(162.19)	(632.30)	(598.67)	(1,538.56)
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(140.92)	(162.19)	(738.10)	(614.49)	(1644.35)
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(140.92)	(162.19)	(738.10)	(614.49)	(1644.35)
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit/ (Loss) for the period (after tax) and other Comprehensive Income (after Tax))	(140.92)	(162.19)	(738.10)	(614.49)	(1644.35)
6	Equity Share Capital	966.47	966.47	966.47	966.47	966.47
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve as shown in the Balance Sheet of previous year)	-	-	-	(6,083.86)	(5,467.46)
8	Earning Per Share ((For continuing and discontinued operations and before extraordinary items) (of ` 5 /- each)	-	-	-	-	-
	Basic	(1.46)	(1.68)	(7.64)	(6.36)	(17.01)
	Diluted	(1.46)	(1.68)	(7.64)	(6.36)	(17.01)
9	Earnings Per Share (For continuing and discontinued operations and after extraordinary items)(of ` 5/- each)	-	-	-	-	-
	Basic	(1.46)	(1.68)	(7.64)	(6.36)	(17.01)
	Diluted	(1.46)	(1.68)	(7.64)	(6.36)	(17.01)

NOTES :
1. The above Audited Financial Results are in accordance with Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and approved and Signed by Resolution Professional of the company. Board of Directors is under suspension consequent to appointment of Insolvency Resolution Professional (IRP) by NCLT vide order dated 07th June, 2024.
2. Audit under regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 has been carried out by the statutory auditors of the Company. The auditors have expressed modified report on the financial statements of the Company.

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors
RAAMA PAPER MILLS LIMITED
Sd/- Sandeep Kumar Aggarwal
IBBI/IPA-001/IP-P01135/2018-2019/11828
Resolution Professional

Date: 21st July, 2026
Place: New Delhi

In the Matter of M/s Rama Paper Mills Limited (Under Crip)

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bunia

The outbreak declared on May 15 is unlike most previous Ebola outbreaks because the Bundibugyo virus responsible for it has no approved vaccines or treatments. It has also killed more



Officials have also warned that 80 per cent of new cases have emerged through unknown chains of transmission, a sign the outbreak is spreading faster than health officials can track it, even as they step up their response in Ituri province, the epicentre of the outbreak, as well as

"If we do not stop this outbreak today, it could become one of the worst Ebola outbreaks the world has ever documented," Kaseya said.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
 Karachi

Sangha said that of nearly 10,000 people who lived near the hospital, 120 tested HIV positive, including adults and children. The individuals who tested HIV positive are also being treated at Government expense. He said that under direct Government orders, the health department was working with a committee of reputable doctors to manage



Sindh Labour Minister Saad Ghani told the media on Wednesday that a standing committee of leading medical experts would be constituted to supervise both the treatment strategy and the management of a PKR 2 billion endowment fund set up for the affected children's long-term treatment. He said that all affected children were receiving treatment at five leading institutions, including Indus Hospital, AKUH and Dow University of Health Sciences. Sindh High Court last week gave the provincial Government three weeks to explain the HIV outbreak at the hospital-a facility run under the provincial labour department. Haani Jamal Khan, the advisor to Sindh Ombudsman, submitted a report at a hearing on Tuesday in which the total number of children infected with HIV was shown as 94. The court directed the provincial Ombudsman to hold hearings into the matter after a petitioner filed a preliminary list of children infected with HIV/AIDS due to the alleged reuse of contaminated syringes and asked the SHC to order an independent inquiry, registration of a case and lifelong medical treatment, and appropriate compensation for the affected children.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
 Karachi

The report shows that the \$27 billion includes fresh loans of \$16 billion, including a fresh loan of \$3 billion from Saudi Arabia in deposits



Finance minister, Muhammad Aurangzeb said this week that Pakistan has officially secured the rollover of the \$3 billion deposit as well alongside the original \$5 billion

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

The legislation passed by French lawmakers Tuesday allows the French food, environmental and occupational health agency to exceptionally authorise the use of acetamidipid and flupyradifurone for a few struggling agricultural sectors.



"Over the past nine months, I have defended those who do not march, who do not vote, and who do not shout: the silence of our forests, the

Pakistan's foreign exchange reserves took a hit earlier this year when it repaid a total of \$3.45 billion in deposits to the United Arab Emirates (UAE) in late April.

HARINDER MISHRA ■ Jerusalem



Weeks after the Iran-US conflict started in February end, the Indian carrier in April announced to put on hold its operations till the end of May, which was further extended till end July and now, extended till end of September.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of **Mrs. Seema w/o Aamir Khan** who is owner of Property area 1000 Sq. Ft. bearing Document No. 1479/3, situated at Prashant Vihar Colony, Village, Noida Chakhandi Bahar Pargana & District, Meerut, U.P. bearing Document No. 5192, dated 19.03.2026 bearing Document No.5192, Volume No. 4510, Book No.1, page 1-20 dated 20.03.2026, bearing Document No. 1479/3, created by her husband Mr. Aamir Khan, earlier Mr. Aamir Khan owned the subject property after demise of his father Mr. Aamir Khan, bearing Document No. 25.09.2017 document no 1754, now Mrs. Seema w/o Aamir Khan intend to mortgage the subject property to **THE NATIONAL TRADING CORPORATION LIMITED, That Original Sale Deed dated 08.02.2011 executed by Mr. Kalu Ramji Singh, bearing Document No. 2726, dated 08.02.2011 has been lost/misplaced** So, to protect the interest of the public, this public notice is that if any Person having any type of claim/rights/interest/creating mortgage over the subject property, please inform the address mentioned below, with his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be deemed that the subject property is free from all Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP**
N-181, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar, Meerut, Distt. Meerut, U.P.
Contact # 9910046316 & 916573473

Public Notice

Mr. M. Mahipal, Panch Ghatot and Mrs. Rashmi Ghantot, hereby inform the general public that they are the owners in respect of the property of the following description:-
Type-C, Pocket-A, Ground Floor, Ashok Vihar Phase-III, New Delhi 110052, originally registered with the Registrar of Stamps and Conveyance, Deed registered as Registration No. 6159, in Book No. 37, Volume 1557, dated 12/02/1977 and 23/03/1977. On 03/06/2005 it is hereby stated that the front portion of the said property is being sold to the public in original; however, the remaining pages are only photocopies as the original pages have been lost. In order to trace the same, further, the original DDA Declaration, letter issued in favour of Mr. Ram Kishan Ghantot dated 02/09/1977 and NOC from the Water and Electric connection dated 23/03/1977, are being made available to the public. It has also been lost/misplaced and is not traceable despite efforts. Any person(s) claiming any interest, dispute, lien, or demand in respect of the aforesaid property is hereby required to produce the original documents and supporting documents within 7 (seven) days of the date of publication of this notice. Failing which, it shall be presumed that no such objection exists and any transaction in relation to the said property shall be considered final, binding, and free from all claims.

PUBLIC NOTICE
is for general information that **Sarbrinder Kaur Puri** Wife of late **S. Gurdeep Singh Puri** resident of 67/8, New Rohtak Road, Behind Jeewan Mala Hospital, Karol Bagh, Central Delhi, Delhi-110005 declare **at name of mine** has **wrongly** written as **Sarbrinder Puri** in my **Husband Pension Record** (P.O).
My actual name of mine is **Sarbrinder Kaur Puri** which **may be amended accordingly.**
It is **certified that I have** complied with other legal **requirements in this connection,**



SOUTH COAST RAILWAY
VISAKHAPATNAM
 Follow us on @SCoRailwayIndia
 website: www.scor.indianrailways.gov.in

Tender Notice No. :
VSKP-TRS-RT-05-2026-27,
Dated : 20-07-2026

Sr. DEE/TRS/VSKP acting for and on behalf of the President of India invites

PUBLIC NOTICE
My client Chander Bhan Sharma, S/O Shri
and Sharma, r/o H.No. 244-A, Mathura
ad, Hari Nagar Ashram, Ashram, P.O.
Angura, District South Delhi, Delhi 110014,
severed all his relations and disowned his
daughter Ms. Charu Sharma from his all
movable-immovable properties due her
obedience. My client shall not be
responsible for her any acts.
**Araveen Singh (Advocate) A-84, 1st Floor,
Defence Colony, New Delhi-110024**

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my client, Amit Kumar, is in process to Purchasing the Residential Plot No. 32, area measuring 100 sq. ft. i.e. 83.61 sq mtr out of khasra no. 380 situated in the village Badhpura Pargana & Tehsil Dadi District Gautam Budh Nagar U.P. Manju by availing the loan from Piramal Finance Ltd. That Manju Sharma had purchased the said property from Nazma vide the Deed dated 9/8/2024 Doc no.41621. My client has informed us that the following original documents pertaining to the said property are not available with his seller and he is unable to produce the same in the file no. 2028000074925 dated 21/7/2026 in view of that.

Original Sale deed dated 08.09.2010 executed by Date Ram in favor of Nazima (doc. 10609)

person's having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, in any way of sale, exchange, mortgage, gift, lease, partition, or otherwise, gift, trust, tenancy, partnership, joint venture, partnership, family arrangement, maintenance, custody, partnership, possession, lease, tenancy, tenancy, license, lien, charge, mortgage, easement or otherwise howsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days on the date thereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and abandoned.

Kamalnati Gupta (Advocate)
No. F-2, First floor, Mahalaxmi Metro Tower, Sec-4, Vashi, GZ, Up, India 401006
982010063351

[illegible]



3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh

Email: sepwdph@rediffmail.com

Office of the Superintending Engineer

Date: 21/07/2026

Letter No. : 2672/58C(Yata-B)-03/2026

National Competitive E-Tender Notice

The Superintending Engineer, 3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh invites tender through E-Tendering (**Two Bid System**) on behalf of Hon'ble Governor of Uttarakhand for following works. All other information will be available online from **date 24-07-2026 at 05.00 PM** onward on website <http://www.uktenders.gov.in>.

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Earnest Money (in Lac)	Cost of Tender (₹)	Validity of Tender (day)	Period of Completion (months)	Contractor's Category of Registration
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	Improvement and asphaltting work of Chhadandev Nwali motor road in Didihat Constituency of district Pithoragarh, under Hon'ble CM announcement No. 364/2024.	4.27	5000.00 + 18% GST	90	12	Category "CC" or above for Road works in any State Govt./Govt. of India/ Govt. undertaking.

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

The collections and precious jewels once displayed there have been removed, as the museum said the gallery is returning to its 17th-century original ceremonial purpose. The stolen jewels remain unrecovered nine months later. The gallery's former exhibits will be relocated elsewhere in the museum, said Christophe Leribault, the

"That sinister day, when iconic pieces were taken, cannot be forgotten, and indeed, I believe, should not be," said French Culture Minister Catherine Pegard. "It was a trauma for the entire world, which, for several days, expressed its shock and sadness in every language. It was a trauma for us, discovering the fragility of a place we thought unshakable, and which, like so many others, proved vulnerable." (AP)

ASSOCIATED PRESS
 Chisinau

Addressing lawmakers just before the vote, Tofan said he understood his "responsibility

Tofan said he did not intend to launch a political career with his role as prime minister.



National Highways Authority of India

(Ministry of Road Transport & Highways, Govt. of India)

PUBLIC NOTICE

National Highway-NH-02 (New NH-19) New User Fee Applicable on Badarpur & Faridabad Toll Plaza

PUBLIC NOTICE ON NEW USER FEE (TOLL) RATES AT TOLL BADARPUR ELEVATED HIGHWAY SECTION (KM. 16.100 TO 20.500) APPLICABLE FROM 23.07.2026

The public are hereby informed that pursuant to the approval of new user fee rates from Competent Authority, NHAI vide e-office, the user fee rates to be effective from 23.07.2026 the user fee rates for use of section from Km. 16.100 to Km. 20.500 (Delhi-Agra Section) of NH-2 are going to be revised as under w.e.f. 23.07.2026 at Badarpur Toll Plaza (Chainage: 18.700 Km.) in the state of New Delhi and at Faridabad Toll Plaza (Chainage: 20.200 Km.) in the state of Haryana:-

Badarpur Elevated Highway Section (KM. 16.100 to 20.500)

Category of Vehicles/ Applicable fee for completed length of 4.4 Km. (KM. 16.100 to 20.500)	Fee for single Journey (Rs.)	Fee for Return Journey within a day (Rs.)	Fee for Monthly Pass Valid for 50 Journeys	Fee for commercial vehicles registered within the district (Rs.)
Car/Jeep/Van/Light Motor Vehicle	35	50	1140	15
LCV/LGV/Mini Bus	55	85	1845	30
Bus/Truck (Two Axles)	115	175	3865	60
Three Axle Commercial Vehicles	125	190	4215	65
Heavy construction Machinery (HCM) or Earth Moving Equipment (EME) of Multi Axle Vehicle (MAV) (4 to 6 Axles)	180	275	6060	90
Oversized Vehicles (Seven or More Axles)	220	330	7380	110

Note: Rate of monthly pass for a person who owns a mechanical vehicle registered for non-commercial purpose and resides within a distance of twenty kilometres from the fee plaza is Rs. 360.00 (Rupees Three Hundred Sixty only) for the Year 2026-27.

1. Name and address are as under, for any enquiry and/or giving complaint suggestions:-

Toll Agency	IE	PD of NHAI
Mr. Satyandra Singh	Mr. Rajesh Sharma	Mr. Dhiraj Singh
M/s Karmveer	M/s L.N. Malviya Office Project Pvt.,Ltd	National Highways Authority of India, CMU- Mathura. Plot no. 08. Near Toll Plaza Building, Faridabad Haryana-121003
Mobile, no. 8218611660	9812908579	8130006117

BUILDING A NATION, NOT JUST ROADS

PROSPECT

CSB Bank Q1 profit rises 27 pc to ₹150 crore

CSB Bank on Wednesday reported a 27 per cent increase in the June quarter net profit at ₹150 crore aided by core income. The private sector lender had earned ₹119 crore profit in the year-ago period. Total income improved to ₹1,516 crore from ₹1,286 crore a year ago.

Interest income grew to ₹1,287 crore from ₹1,041 crore, CSB Bank said in a regulatory filing. The bank's net interest income also increased 26 per cent to ₹479 crore from ₹379 crore in the same quarter in the previous financial year. The bank's asset quality improved as Gross Non-Performing Assets (NPAs) fell to 1.75 per cent of gross advances as of June 30, 2026, from 1.84 per cent a year ago. Similarly, net NPAs, too, declined to 0.39 per cent from 0.66 per cent at the end of the first quarter of the previous financial year. As a result, provisions and contingencies eased to ₹49 crore from ₹61 crore earmarked during the same quarter a year ago. The bank's capital adequacy ratio declined to 19.96 per cent from 21.71 per cent on June 30, 2025.

Coal India arm BCCL Q1 loss at ₹68 crore

Coal India arm BCCL on Wednesday reported a loss of ₹68.09 crore for the June quarter due to lower revenue and higher expenses. However, the company had reported a profit of ₹176.87 crore in the year-ago period, Bharat Coking Coal Ltd (BCCL) said in a filing to the BSE. Revenue from operations during the first quarter of the current fiscal year declined to ₹3,587.27 crore over ₹3,719.59 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous fiscal year. In a presentation, BCCL – a Miniratna PSU – said, “The reduction in sales is on account of reduction in outside dispatch from 83.53 million tonnes to 7.81 million tonnes.”

It further said the decrease in other income is primarily attributable to the reduction in provision and liability write back. The total expenses rose to ₹3,826.31 crore over ₹3,654.39 crore in the year-ago period, the filing said. Bharat Coking Coal Ltd manages an extensive network of open-cast and underground mines across Jharkhand and West Bengal, with a particular focus on the Jharia Coalfield. The company's operations span various strategic projects, each contributing to BCCL's mission to meet the country's coking coal mission while addressing critical fire control measures.

Edtech startup sortmyprep raises \$350,000 in pre-seed funding

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

sortmyprep, a vertical AI education platform built for school exam preparation, has raised approximately \$350,000 in a pre-seed funding round led by a group of prominent Indian and global angel investors. The company operates under ZKAP Edtech Service Private Limited. It is currently focused on international curricula and offers “sorty”, a board-aligned conversational virtual AI tutor, along with a 24/7 personalised doubt-solving platform.

The platform aims to close learning gaps by providing immediate doubt resolution. At the core of sortmyprep is its infinite personalised adaptivity engine. It tracks every student answer, identifies weak areas in real time, and automatically rebuilds study plans. The company says this moves beyond reactive revision to proactive, outcome-driven preparation for exams. The capital raised will be used to strengthen its vertical AI infrastructure, expand curriculum coverage, and accelerate growth across India and international markets.

The round saw participa-



tion from Boman Irani, Chairman of Rustomjee Group and Rustomjee International School; Sameer Mehta, co-founder of boAt; Subrat Pani, co-founder of OneAssist; Rohini Kasturi, CEO of HG Insights; and Ranjit Pawar, APAC Head at London Stock Exchange Group. The company previously received early institutional backing from PIEDS, BITS Pilani.

Founded by Ananya, Aryaman and Naman, sortmyprep combines its proprietary AI architecture with expert-validated academic workflows to deliver curriculum-aligned learning support. Today, sortmyprep serves students in more than 15 countries and has built a proprietary academic dataset of over one million human-generated learning

data points. The company reports that 71 per cent of its users have come through referrals and word-of-mouth, without paid marketing.

“What stood out was the team's execution. Building strong organic adoption without relying on paid acquisition reflects both product quality and market demand. They have demonstrated a deep understanding of the problem they are solving,” said Sameer Mehta, co-founder of boAt.

In addition to its investors, sortmyprep is supported through programs and partnerships with Nvidia, Google for Startups, OpenAI, BITS Pilani and Ashoka University.

“From a school's perspective, this solves a genuine problem. Students need support that is accurate, curriculum-specific and avail-

able whenever they need it. sortmyprep has built a product that students actively recommend to one another,” said Boman Irani, Chairman of Rustomjee Group and Rustomjee International School.

PIEDS, BITS Pilani, one of the earliest institutional backers, said the platform is well positioned to benefit from broader shifts in education. “sortmyprep has built a specialised vertical AI platform designed around 100 per cent curriculum accuracy and student outcomes. Their approach combines proprietary AI technology with expert-validated content, creating a scalable foundation for expansion across international and Indian education systems,” said Sachin Arya, Head of PIEDS, BITS Pilani.

The company believes its vertical AI platform and 100 per cent accurate board-aligned conversational AI tutor, sorty, are particularly relevant as education systems move toward competency-based learning models. Beyond its current focus on international curricula such as IB and IGCSE, sortmyprep plans to expand into CBSE, ICSE and other major global boards.

ADB delegation visits Assam Skill University

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

A high-level delegation from the Asian Development Bank (ADB), led by L Satya Srinivas, Executive Director for India, Board of Directors, Asian Development Bank, and Mio Oka, Country Director – India, Asian Development Bank, accompanied by the INRM Mission Team, visited the Assam Skill University (ASU) campus at Mangaldai on Wednesday.

The delegation was warmly welcomed by Subhash Chandra Das, IAS (Retd.), Vice-Chancellor, Assam Skill University; Dr Om Prakash, IAS, Commissioner & Secretary, Skill, Employment & Entrepreneurship Department; and Shri Hanif Noorani, ACS, Registrar, Assam Skill University.

During the visit, the delegation toured the university's workshops, state-of-the-art

lab facilities like the Semiconductor Laboratory, Electric Vehicle Laboratory, Solar Energy Laboratory, Robotics and Cobot Laboratory, Additive Manufacturing Laboratory, etc., and other academic facilities. They also interacted with students, faculty members, and project officials, gaining first-hand insight into the university's state-of-the-art infrastructure, industry-oriented practical learning ecosystem, and the progress of the Assam Skill University Project. As part of the visit, Shri L. Satya Srinivas and Mio Oka also participated in a sapling plantation ceremony on the university campus, symbolising the shared commitment of the Government of Assam, Assam Skill University, and the Asian Development Bank towards sustainability and environmentally responsible development.

UCO Bank Q1 profit rises 8% to ₹656 cr

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned UCO Bank on Wednesday reported an 8 per cent increase in net profit at ₹656 crore for the first quarter of the current financial year.

The Kolkata-based bank had earned a net profit of Rs 607 crore in the same quarter of the previous financial year.

Total income rose to ₹8,682 crore during the June quarter of 2026-27, from ₹7,433 crore a year ago, UCO Bank said in a regulatory filing. Interest earned by the bank improved to ₹6,996 crore, as compared to ₹6,436 crore in the June quarter of FY26.

During the period, operating profit of the bank also increased to ₹2,810 crore



from ₹1,562 crore a year ago.

The bank's asset quality improved as gross non-performing assets (NPAs) declined to 2.08 per cent of gross advances at the end of the June quarter, from 2.63 per cent a year ago.

Similarly, net NPAs, or bad loans, declined to 0.25 per cent from 0.45 per cent in the year-ago period.

HPCL books ₹11,526 cr net loss in Q1

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) on Wednesday reported a net loss of ₹11,526.41 crore for the June quarter, wiping out more than two-thirds of its profit for the previous financial year, as it sold petrol, diesel and LPG below cost despite a sharp rise in input prices following the West Asia crisis.

The loss compared to ₹4,575.87 crore earned in April-June 2025 and ₹4,901.50 crore profit in the preceding January-March period, according to a stock exchange filing by the company. HPCL had reported a net profit of ₹17,258.13 crore in the full 2025-26 fiscal (April 2025 to March 2026).

The company booked heavy losses on selling petrol, diesel and cooking



gas LPG during the quarter, wiping away record refining margins. It, alongside other state-owned fuel retailers – Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) and Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL), held petrol and diesel prices steady for two-and-a-half months despite a more than 50 per cent surge in prices of crude oil – the raw material for making petrol and diesel – after the US and Israel attacked Iran on February 28

and Tehran retaliated.

And when these companies increased prices by over ₹7.50 a litre in the second half of May, it wasn't enough to cover the cost. The cooking gas price increase of ₹89 per 14.2-kg cylinder too was a fifth of the required hike.

HPCL said it earned USD 23.80 on turning every barrel of crude oil into fuels like petrol and diesel in April-June – the first quarter of the 2026-27 financial year – as

Sebi cancels registration of 34 investment advisers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Markets regulator Sebi has cancelled the registration certificates of 34 investment advisers after they failed to pay the mandatory renewal fees. Under the Sebi (Investment Advisers) Regulations, 2013, registered investment advisers are required to pay a renewal fee every five years to keep their registration valid.

Sebi found that the 34 advisers had failed to pay the renewal fees within the stipulated period.

The regulator issued notices to these entities in June, asking them to explain why their registrations should not be suspended or cancelled. However, no replies were received within the prescribed time.

In its order dated July 21, Sebi said the registrations had ceased to remain in force due to non-payment of renewal fees and, therefore, cancelled their certificates with immediate effect.

The regulator clarified that cancellation of registration does not absolve the entities of liabilities arising from their past activities as registered investment advisers.

DRI busts clandestine mephedrone manufacturing facility in Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), under the Ministry of Finance, dismantled a clandestine Mephedrone manufacturing facility operating from a residential premises in Ankleshwar, Gujarat, and arrested three persons allegedly involved in an illicit drug manufacturing and trafficking network.

Simultaneous searches conducted at the residential premises of the accused led to the recovery of ₹21 lakh, believed to be proceeds of illicit drug trafficking, the finance ministry said in a statement on Wednesday.

In an intelligence led operation, officers of DRI unearthed a fully functional illicit laboratory equipped with sophisticated manufacturing apparatus, including an industrial oven dryer, hot



plate heaters, condenser assembly, electric stirrer, and other laboratory equipment used for the clandestine manufacture of Mephedrone, it said.

Mephedrone, commonly known on the streets as 'Meow Meow', 'MD', 'M-Cat' or 'Drone', is a highly addictive synthetic psychotropic substance that has emerged as one of the most abused stimulant drugs in India, it added.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (22.7.26)

ACROSS

DOWN

DOUBLE CROSSWORD THURSDAY | JULY 23, 2026

ACROSS

DOWN

GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY. AMRITSAR

Advertisement No. 07/2026

Walk-in-Interview

Walk-in-Interview is proposed for the various Non-Teaching positions in the university on contract basis. Details are available on www.digital.gndu.ac.in

22-07-2026

Registrar

2426/12/2026-27/13529 Dated CHD :- 22/07/2026

E-Tender Notice

GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY, AMRITSAR

SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE

Short Term E-Tenders are invited for the purchase of Melt Spinning Machine, Needle Punching Non-Woven Machine, Fast Braiding Machine and Flat V Double Bed Rib Knitting be submitted online latest by 6/08/2026 upto 4:00 p.m. Detailed information can be obtained from website www.eproc.punjab.gov.in. Any corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded, if required, on Punjab Govt. website: eproc.punjab.gov.in

Director of Research

2426/12/2026-27/13527 Dated CHD :- 22/07/2026

BRIEFLY

Guillermo Ochoa retires at 41, closing a 22-year career



Guillermo Ochoa – widely considered among the greatest Mexican goalkeepers in history–announced his retirement from elite soccer on Tuesday, bringing an end to a distinguished 22-year professional career. Ochoa, who turned 41 last week, had previously stated that 2026 World Cup would be his last tournament, though speculation had swirled about whether he might sign with a new club to extend his playing days. He put those rumors to rest.

“I gave it my all; I left everything on the field for my clubs and the national team, and today I hang up my gloves,” Ochoa posted on social media. “Being a goalkeeper means knowing you might wait 90 minutes for a single moment when everything depends on you. And when that moment arrives, you cannot hesitate.”

Ochoa was selected on Mexico’s roster for six World Cups – a number shared only by icons Cristiano Ronaldo and Lionel Messi. He served as Mexico’s starting goalkeeper in three of them: Brazil 2014, Russia 2018, and Qatar 2022.

Ochoa made his top-flight debut with Club America in February 2004. He spent his first seven seasons there before transferring to French club Ajaccio in 2011, becoming the first Mexico-born goalkeeper to play in Europe. (AP)

Kuldeep Yadav signs up for Yorkshire for eight games



Repeatedly overlooked from India’s playing eleven, left-arm wrist spinner Kuldeep Yadav on Wednesday signed to play eight games for top English county side Yorkshire in the ongoing season. “Yorkshire County Cricket Club is delighted to announce the overseas signing of Indian international spinner, Kuldeep Yadav. The 31-year-old will be available for five Metro Bank One Day Cup matches, before returning to Headingley for three of the final four Rothesay County Championship fixtures in September,” Yorkshire CCC announced on club’s website.

Yadav goes straight into the squad for Friday’s 50-over clash with Glamorgan at Neath.

On joining Yorkshire, Yadav said: “I’m really pleased to be joining Yorkshire and grateful for this opportunity. It will be a real privilege to represent a Club with Yorkshire’s proud history. “I’ve always enjoyed the challenge of playing in English conditions and after speaking with management, I became really excited to join up with the team and I’m looking forward to making a positive contribution during my time at Headingley,” Yadav added.

While India head coach Gautam Gambhir didn’t show much faith in his abilities, Yorkshire management believes that Yadav will add value during a hot and dry English summer. (PTI)

LPGA unveils Nanea Cup, \$4 million event that mixes pro players with collegians

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Daytona Beach (US)

The LPGA on Tuesday unveiled the inaugural Nanea Cup, an event being held in Hawaii next March that includes a mix of pro golfers and collegians as a way to showcase the present and future of women’s golf.

The event, which will be held March 11-14 at the Nanea Golf Club in Kailua-Kona, on the Big Island, features a \$4 million purse. The field will include 95 LPGA Tour players along with 25 of the nation’s top college golfers representing five universities: Stanford, Texas, Arkansas, Texas A&M and UCLA.

“As we continue to focus on routing, courses and purses, this event checks every box,” LPGA Commissioner Craig Kessler said in a statement. “Nanea is



a spectacular venue, our athletes will compete for a strong purse, and fans will get their first look at one of the most celebrated golf courses in the world.”

All competitors will play Thursday and Friday before the field is cut to the low 50 players and ties.

Paul Wade says he has probable CTE, urges no heading for junior players

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Perth

Former Australia soccer captain Paul Wade says he has been diagnosed with probable chronic traumatic encephalopathy (CTE) and has renewed his calls for all players under the age of 12 to be banned from heading the ball.

Wade, who played 84 internationals for Australia, on Wednesday said he realizes his memory is fading and he is experiencing mood swings due to repeated head injuries he experienced during his soccer career.

While it can only be definitively diagnosed by an autopsy after death, Wade received a diagnosis



of suspected CTE in late 2024 following the presentation of neuro-

logical symptoms. Then late last year following a subsequent neurological assessment and specialist evaluation, Wade was diagnosed with probable CTE. “Football gave me so much. It gave me a life, a career, incredible experiences and the privilege of representing Australia,” the 64-year-old Wade said. “But I also must be honest about the challenges I now face and the uncertainty that comes with living with a neurodegenerative condition. “I know my memory’s going. And I’ve

been told by a number of people I’ve become a little bit short-tempered.”

Wade said he doesn’t want to discourage anyone from playing soccer. “But we do need to understand more about the long-term effects of repeated head impacts and make sure that players, families and the game have the information and support they need to protect future generations,” Wade said. Dr. Rowena Mobbs, Wade’s neurologist and one of Australia’s leading concussion and CTE experts, has recommended a reduction in heading at the junior level.



Batter Shahidi steps down as Afghanistan ODI skipper



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kabul

Seasoned batter Hashmatullah Shahidi has stepped down as Afghanistan’s ODI captain but will remain available for the 50-over format as a player. Shahidi, 31, took over the ODI captaincy at the start of 2022 and led Afghanistan during the 2023 ODI World Cup and the 2025 ICC Champions Trophy. He is also captain of Afghanistan’s Test side.

The left-handed batter’s standout innings as captain came against India at the 2023 World Cup, where he struck 80 off 88 balls to help Afghanistan post 272. However, Rohit Sharma’s side comfortably chased down the target. “Today I announce with full respect and consent that I am resigning as captain of my team at my personal decision,” Shahidi posted.

Shahidi oversaw a memorable ODI campaign, guiding Afghanistan to wins over England, Pakistan, Sri Lanka and the Netherlands at the 2023 World Cup in India. Those results left them just short of a maiden semifinal berth, before he also captained the side at the Champions Trophy.

“It was a great honour for me to perform this responsibility as a Captain. I am proud to have served alongside my team with commitment,” he added. He has so far scored more than 2600 runs in 96 ODI with one century. “By the grace of Allah, with the efforts of the officials, coaches and players, we have achieved many victories, won important matches, defeated big teams and made the name of the team higher.”

Two-time champion Aryna Sabalenka and Wimbledon winner Jannik Sinner lead US Open fields

BRIAN MAHONEY ■ New York



Two-time defending champion Aryna Sabalenka and Wimbledon winner Jannik Sinner lead the fields for the US Open that begins next month. The US Tennis Association announced the direct entry lists Tuesday for the final Grand Slam tournament of the season.

Based on the July 20 rankings on the WTA and ATP Tours, the cutoff was No. 102 for the women and No. 101 for the men.

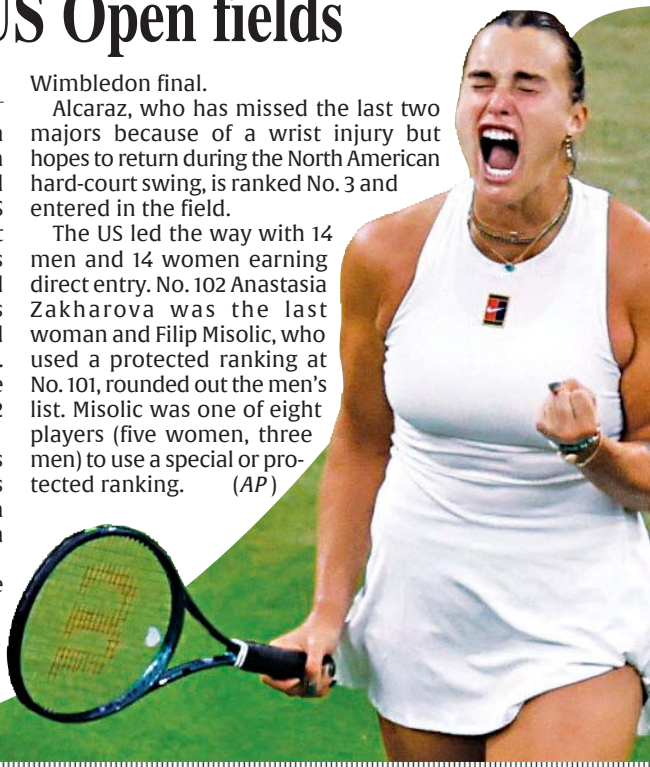
Sabalenka tops the women’s rankings and will arrive in Flushing Meadows trying to become the first woman to win three straight US Open titles since Serena Williams from 2012-14.

Sinner will be trying to regain the title that Carlos Alcaraz took from the 2024 champion when they met in last year’s final. The top-ranked Italian is coming off his fifth major championship, when he beat French Open champion Alexander Zverev in the

Wimbledon final.

Alcaraz, who has missed the last two majors because of a wrist injury but hopes to return during the North American hard-court swing, is ranked No. 3 and entered in the field.

The US led the way with 14 men and 14 women earning direct entry. No. 102 Anastasia Zakharova was the last woman and Filip Misolic, who used a protected ranking at No. 101, rounded out the men’s list. Misolic was one of eight players (five women, three men) to use a special or protected ranking. (AP)



We don’t have much options in any department: Anjum Chopra

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Former skipper Anjum Chopra doesn’t think that removing Harmanpreet Kaur from captaincy is a solution as the Indian women’s team do not have quality back-up options in any of the departments.

While another legendary former skipper Mithali Raj has urged the selectors to look at the bigger picture and groom young captain like Shafali Verma for WT20Is, Chopra doesn’t find it a feasible course correction.

“Why are we even talking about a change? You can make anybody the captain. That doesn’t mean that the rest of the 10 players will



start performing differently. And if that has to happen, then I think we’re in a very bad zone or a wrong place,” Chopra said.

“I’m not

saying that nobody can become captain. It’s not a permanent position. And if change of captaincy is solution, then I think in every series, we should keep changing captains if that is the way that we are going to get results,” she said. (PTI)

Tebas: Infantino should resign for destroying football industry

CARLOS RODRIGUEZ ■ Lausanne

Gianni Infantino should resign as head of FIFA for “destroying the football industry” by expanding international competitions, La Liga president Javier Tebas said Tuesday. It is not first time he has lashed out at Infantino over fixture congestion and for considering a proposal to expand the 2030 men’s World Cup from 48 teams to 64.

“Increasing the number of national teams makes no sense. The football industry isn’t just the World Cup, which is the most important event. But not everything can revolve around the World Cup,” Tebas told La Gazzetta dello Sport.

“In my opinion, yes, I think his



time is up,” he said of Infantino. “However, he has the support of the system and the federations, so there’s not much more to add, is there? There’s no opposition candidate, nobody

wants to stand just to lose. This is the system and it’s rotten at its core.

“He shouldn’t stay, but he won’t leave. I’ve heard many people who are against Infantino. They say it, but then they do nothing. I don’t know what’s worse, the silence or the complicity, because those who stay silent are perfectly aware of the damage football is suffering.” (AP)

World Cup final between Spain and Argentina watched by roughly 60 million

DAVID BRANDT ■ New York

There are a lot of things that could have gone wrong during this summer’s World Cup – a complicated logistical undertaking that included three host nations, 16 stadiums, 48 teams, 104 games and endless opportunities for controversy on and off the soccer field.

But in retrospect, a lot of things went right.

The United States, Canada and Mexico spent nearly six weeks hosting soccer’s biggest showcase and – at least for the most part – the action stayed on the field.

Fox said Tuesday that the Spain-Argentina final drew 38.937 million viewers – including a peak of 51.685 million – which easily set the record as the most-watched English-language



soccer telecast in US history, according to Nielsen Media Research. Spain won the final 1-0 in extra time.

Telemundo’s preliminary numbers for

its Spanish-language broadcast said the game had a total audience of 22.6 million, putting the total number of viewers in the US at more than

60 million.

Star players like Argentina’s Lionel Messi, France’s Kylian Mbappe and Norway’s Erling Haaland became household names across North America, television ratings remained high in the US even after the Americans were eliminated and despite high ticket prices, most games featured packed stadiums.

FIFA President Gianni Infantino gave effusive praise to the host countries on Sunday.

Attendance was good, so were ratings: Fox broadcast all 104 games in English on its platforms and American viewership remained strong even after the US was eliminated by Belgium in the round of 16.

Spanish broadcasts on Telemundo were also a popular option – even for

non-native speakers.

Fox averaged 7.737 million viewers for the 104 broadcasts on Fox, FS1 and Tubi – up from 3.588 million in 2022 and 2.77 million in 2018.

Though Nielsen’s viewership numbers give a window into the World Cup final’s widespread popularity, it’s a challenge to reflect how many people actually watched since some viewed the game in group settings such as watch parties. In 2025, Nielsen expanded its out-of-home measurement system to try and get a more accurate count.

Despite a few early hiccups, stadium attendance was also strong throughout the U.S., Canada and Mexico.

“We have had a record number of spectators in the stadiums, almost 7 million,” Infantino said. “We will have

had, I mean the official figures will come out soon, but probably over 6 billion people watching it from home.”

The weather cooperated – usually: Fans and players from other countries found out what Americans, Canadians and Mexicans have known for a long time – it can get pretty hot here in the summer. Climate change isn’t helping matters.

But Mother Nature could have been a lot meaner than she decided to be.

Even so, there were a handful of games that featured particularly hot and muggy conditions. The best example was a knockout-round game between Paraguay and France on July 4 in Philadelphia when temperatures hovered around 100 degrees Fahrenheit (38 Celsius). (AP)

Ready infrastructure sealed India's CWG bid: Commonwealth Sport CEO

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Glasgow

Ahmedabad's ready-made world-class sporting infrastructure played a decisive role in securing the hosting rights for the centenary 2030 CWG, Commonwealth Sport CEO Katie Sadleir said, adding that the bid perfectly aligned with the governing body's revamped low-cost hosting model.

India was awarded the hosting rights for the 2030 Commonwealth Games in November last year.

The decision came after Commonwealth Sport, formerly the Commonwealth Games Federation, adopted its "Games Reset" model aimed at making the event more affordable following Australian state Victoria's withdrawal as host of the 2026 edition because of spiralling costs.

"We were really fortunate having two of our largest members (India and Nigeria) put forward an expression of interest



"They are champions, they are legends and the Commonwealth is so important. So from that perspective, seeing a country that had an aspiration to do both (host the Commonwealth Games and Olympics) is very attractive because it meant that they're really serious about what they're doing in sport."

The 2030 CWG are also expected to showcase India's traditional sporting heritage, with indigenous disciplines set to feature for the first time.

Kabaddi, kho kho, mallakhamb and yogasana are among the sports under consideration for inclusion in the programme alongside the compulsory disciplines.

Sadleir said giving the Games a local flavour was an important part of the hosting philosophy, while stressing that the sports chosen should also become competitive across the Commonwealth not just in India. "We do think profiling indigenous sports is really important. The programme of sports for the Games must reflect things that are important to all Commonwealth countries, but there also must be a flavour of the host. (PTI)

for 2030," Sadleir told PTI.

"The facilities (in India) were fantastic and the fact that they were up and they were there. So it wasn't about building facilities. The capital

investment from the government to have world-class facilities was absolutely outstanding.

"And I think that the team that they put together in terms of how connected they were and working as one to show how much it meant to them, how much it meant to the government, and the people of India to host the Games."

Sadleir said India's passion for the Commonwealth Games also made a strong impression during the evaluation process.

Though not a sporting superpower, India lies fourth in the all-time Commonwealth medal tables behind Australia, England and Canada.

"The Commonwealth Games is really important for the Indian population. It's been one of our highest-viewed events and, not to undermine anyone, but I know that quite often they think of Commonwealth Games medals in the same kind of stance as they think of Olympic medals."

India are also bidding to stage the 2036 Olympics.

Vijender says male boxers need more competitions



POONAM MEHRA ■ New Delhi

His path-breaking performances lifted Indian boxing to unprecedented highs but Vijender Singh is worried about what the future holds for the country's male pugilists, who are "not getting enough competitions" while dealing with a selection system that promotes sycophancy.

In an exclusive interview to PTI, India's first Olympic medalist in boxing, the only one with three consecutive Commonwealth Games medals and two Asian Games medals also said that at this point, the women boxers are outperforming

men and are brighter medal prospects for the 2028 Olympics.

"...whether it's Sakshi (Chaudhary), or Preeti (Pawar), they are doing extremely fine, and they are in nice form. The boys, they are doing also good, but overall, I can say that girls will do well in the Commonwealth Games," he said referring to the two strong medal contenders in the CWG squad. "Asian Games, it's going to be tough, especially for boys. Par ladkiyan hamari jeet jayengi, ladkiyon se mujhe bohot umedein hain (Our girls will win, they will perform well, I have high hopes from them). (PTI)

InsuranceDekho to be on-air broadcast sponsor of India-Zimbabwe T20I series



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India's three-match T20I tour of Zimbabwe, beginning on Thursday, will have InsuranceDekho, an insurtech platform, as the co-presenting on-air broadcast sponsor, with former India captain Sourav Ganguly serving as the brand ambassador.

The company will also be the on-ground title sponsor for India's two-

Test tour of Sri Lanka in August, with the series to be branded as the InsuranceDekho Cup.

"As a captain, I learnt that a team plays fearlessly only when it knows someone is behind it. That's exactly what InsuranceDekho does - for its advisors, for families, and now for Team India. I'm proud that Bharat, Khul Kar Khelo travels with the team on these tours," said Ganguly.

PCB makes padel mandatory training component at NCA



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

The Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) has made padel a mandatory training component at the National Cricket Academy in Lahore, requiring players to participate in 40-minute sessions on alternate days to boost agility, reflexes, and fielding-specific movement.

The new ruling has been passed by senior selector and director high

performance, Aqib Javed, who said the players will have to play padel sports during long-duration training camps at the NCA.

"Many of our players are already playing padel sports regularly but had to travel long distances to the limited courts in their home towns. We have now built a padel court facility at the NCA for the players," the former pacer said.



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Harare

Shreyas Iyer would be eager for his first win as India captain while his young team eyes course correction against a spunky Zimbabwe that is expected to fight hard during the short three-match T20I series starting here on Thursday.

Having lost six out of his first seven T20I games as skipper in series defeats to minnows Ireland and a seasoned England side, the rubber against Zimbabwe gives Iyer and company a chance to get the house in order.

A series win against Zimbabwe would be the expected outcome but a defeat could unnerve the dressing room that also features a 15-year-



old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

For this tour, India will have a stop-gap head coach in VVS Laxman, whose personality is diametrically opposite to the combative regular gaffer Gautam Gambhir.

It is not that Laxman wouldn't want to win the series but his propensity to experiment with playing eleven is far less compared

to Gambhir.

The spotlight will once again chase 'Boy Wonder' Sooryavanshi, who is set to open in all three games alongside Abhishek Sharma as Sanju Samson hasn't even been selected. The Harare Sports Club ground brings back fond memories for both Abhishek

and Sooryavanshi. The Punjab opener made his debut and then scored his first T20I ton here in his second appearance.

For Sooryavanshi, this is the ground where earlier this year, on February 6, he hammered a hapless England U-19s with a big hundred in the junior World Cup final. But this series will have a different context. It was supposed to be an opportunity to experiment for a new-look bowling attack, but has turned into a must-win affair due to recent debacles.

The afternoon games at the Harare Sports Club's tracks, which always have a bit of juice and carry, can pose problems for most of the Indian batters save skipper Iyer as they don't tend to use their feet.

Blessing Muzarabani and Richard Ngarava, two tall and potent fast bowlers have the ability to cause chaos if Indians become over-confident.

Faced several ups and down in last four months: Vaibhav Sooryavanshi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Harare

Indian batting prodigy Vaibhav Sooryavanshi has acknowledged that he has endured "several ups and downs" in the past four months but his confidence remains intact heading into the T20I series against Zimbabwe, beginning in Harare on Thursday.

Riding on his IPL blitzkrieg, the 15-year-old made it to India's T20I tours of Ireland and England. Although he did not feature in the two-match series in Belfast, he made his international debut in the second T20I against England in Manchester, becoming India's youngest-ever international cricketer, eclipsing Sachin Tendulkar's long-standing record. Sooryavanshi played the next three matches but managed only modest scores and was left out of the fifth and final T20I as Sanju Samson returned to the XI. India went on to lose the series 0-4.

His omission sparked criticism from several former cricketers, who questioned the team management's decision to drop the teenage opener after just three innings.

"Yes, there have been several ups and down in the last four months; it's part of



cricket it will keep happening but I have to follow the process and give my 100 per cent for the team," Sooryavanshi, whose familiarity with the conditions here could strengthen his chances of making the playing XI for Thursday's opener, told 'bcci.tv'.

The youngsters was visibly emotional after being left out of the fifth and final T20I against England. Acknowledging the challenges of dealing with setbacks at a young age, he said the support he received from those around him helped him move on and regain his focus.

West Indies beats New Zealand by two wickets in 5th ODI



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bridgetown (Barbados)

Shimron Hetmyer held his nerve late in run chase to make an unbeaten 69 and steer West Indies to a two-wicket win over New Zealand Tuesday in the fifth and final one-day cricket international. New Zealand took the series 3-2, clinching it in Game 4 after winning Game 2 by five wickets and Game 3 by six wickets in a comeback following West Indies' seven-wicket victory in the opening game.

Hetmyer's fifth ODI half-century and his partnership of 95 with Sherfane Rutherford (61) allowed the West Indies to reach 269-8 in reply to New Zealand's 268-9 with 15 balls remaining. All five matches in the series were won by the team batting second.

India beat Pakistan, Oman in Youth Hockey5s Asian Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Muscat

The Indian sub-junior boys' team maintained its winning run, outplaying Pakistan and Oman in the Elite Pool of the FIH Youth Hockey5s Asian Championship here.

Led by Ketan Kushwaha, India first registered an emphatic 14-0 win over Oman, with the skipper scoring four goals (6', 11', 15', 20'). Ashish Tani Puri (1', 16', 19') struck a hat-trick, while Rahul Yadav (2', 12') and Shahrulkh Ali (3', 13') scored braces. Prahalad Rajbhar (9'), Karan Gautam (15') and Romit Pal (18') also found the back of the net.

Against Pakistan, India prevailed 7-4, with Karan Gautam (5', 9', 19') completing a hat-trick. Rahul Yadav (3'), Prahalad Rajbhar (10'), captain Kushwaha (11') and Romit Pal (11') were the other scorers for India. Aslam Muhammad Farhan (6'), Adeel (8') and Usman Muhammad (10', 16') scored for Pakistan.

The Indian sub-junior girls, meanwhile, were held to a 2-



2 draw by China before thrashing Uzbekistan 16-0 in another Elite Pool match.

Trailing for most of the contest after Chen Ge (4') put China ahead, India fought back

through Nousheen Naz (16', 17'), who scored twice to give her side the lead. However, Jiaxin Guo (19') netted a late equaliser to earn China a share of the points.